rumor has it

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by eris_ce

Summary

Phainon shook his head with a sigh. “You know,” he began, crossing his arms over his chest and leaning against the wall, “you’re a lot more attractive if you’re only singing and playing the guitar.”

Mydei frowned at the backhanded compliment. Then, in the hopes of turning this situation on him and catching him tongue tied instead, he raised a brow. “You find me attractive?”

Unfazed, Phainon shrugged. “So what if I do? It doesn’t mean anything.”

He almost convinced both of them that it *was* nothing. But Phainon’s expression darkened, just a little bit, and he glanced at Mydei once more. “Unless, of course, you want it to.”

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or, what happens when you put a rising singer and a seasoned one together in one music tour?

Notes

inspired by this official art of mydei. damn.

also, this is the working playlist for this fic.

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there is now a chinese translation of *rumor has it.* thank you very much, kubicmay, for translating!!

THERE ARE NOW ALSO FANARTS OF THIS FIC AAAAAAAA
😭😭😭
> hot art of chapter 1 by @ZLjiejielover
> heartstopping art of chapter 3 by @lazz_kwn
> gentle art of chapter 4 by @PikminPurplest

dirty little secret [track 01]

Chapter Notes

track 01: *dirty little secret* by the all-american rejects

additional tags: semi-public handjobs

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s not like Mydei never wanted this life for himself.

If anything, everything he had done thus far had led up to this. From all the lessons he took up learning the guitar (both its acoustic and electric variants), to all the covers he’d been secretly recording and uploading, to finally getting his own contract and manager with a record label–they all molded him to undertake the weight of this moment. After years of pining for a shot in the limelight, he finally had his own opportunity served to him on a silver plate.

Still, no matter how glorious and exciting all these were, the fact that he was going to be the opening act for an incredibly popular rock band made him nervous.

“Do you have everything you need with you already?”

Mydei glanced at his phone now, his attention shifting from his thoughts and back towards the present. Taking up the entirety of its screen was his mother, Gorgo, who had her own gaze averted from Mydei. She looked like she was preoccupied with the drive home, but Mydei knew her attention was divided between the road and him.

Not wanting to make her any more distracted than she already was, Mydei answered her promptly. “I do,” he reassured her. “All the band equipment arrived earlier, including mine.”

He looked around at his large but otherwise empty hotel room. He had just checked in earlier this afternoon, and this suite was to be the place of his residence for a few more days until the tour officially began. And though he had taken his luggage and both of his guitars with him—leaving his speakers, amplifiers, and other equipment under the care of the logistics team—there was still more than enough room for one.

It was a luxury Mydei had only once dreamed of.

However, to the band he was traveling with, this was mere reality. To the Flame-Chasers, this was just another day in their superstar life.

He looked back at his mother. “Don’t worry about me,” he added, soothing her yet again. “I’m fine.”

She snorted. Passing streetlights bathed her in alternating shows of light and shadow. “It is futile to tell a mother not to worry about her own child, no matter how grown that child may be,” she chastised. She glanced at him briefly. “Especially if her son in question is about to embark on his first tour across the country.”

Mydei rested his chin in his hand. “You have full access to every one of those shows should you wish to come see me in one.”

“And I will,” she promised. Though her eyes were on the dashboard, the camera caught the way her expression softened. “Though I regret not being there with you at your first one. This was all you dreamt of when you were younger.”

“Mom,” Mydei said, smiling fondly, “I’m *fine*. I’ll make sure to send you all the photos and videos I can.”

“You better.”

Before either of them could make another remark, their conversation was promptly interrupted by the ringing of the doorbell. Mydei schooled his features back into neutrality as he rose to his feet, taking his phone with him as he padded to the door.

“Expecting a visitor at this time?” If he didn’t know any better, Mydei would have thought his mother sounded almost teasing.

“No,” he said. He glared at her, though she couldn’t see him. “Why do you make it sound like that?”

“It was just a question, my love,” she replied, attempting to dismiss Mydei’s suspicions. “No need to get all defensive.”

Mydei rolled his eyes. He peered into the peephole of his door, ascertaining who had come to check on him. Then he turned the lock, pressed the handle, and swung the door open for the man standing on the other side of the door.

Mydei had already seen him through the peephole. But it still surprised him to find the lead singer of the Flame-Chasers truly waiting for him on the other side. He was whistling a song from his own band as he waited, though he quickly fell silent upon finding himself face-to-face with Mydei.

Away from the public eye, Phainon was dressed in a simple garment of a plain hoodie and a pair of loose sweatpants. When he beheld Mydei—who was dressed similarly, just in dark colors as opposed to Phainon—he grinned.

“Hello,” Phainon greeted. He looked like he was about to say something more when his eyes caught sight of Mydei’s phone in his hand. Then his expression shifted, and his smile turned a little more polite than it just was. “Did I catch you at a bad time?”

“It’s fine.” Mydei turned the phone, revealing the image of Gorgo on its screen. “I was just talking to my mother.”

Phainon ducked, presumably within view of the camera, and waved. “Hi, ma’am!”

“Hello, Phainon,” Mydei heard her greet in return. “It’s a little late, isn’t it?”

Mydei immediately averted his phone from Phainon. “Yes,” he interrupted, answering on his behalf. “Which is why it’s best for us to get some rest.”

Phainon, either oblivious to Gorgo’s subtle teasing or deliberately ignorant of it, nodded. “I was just checking up on Mydei to see how he was settling in.”

“How chivalrous of you,” Gorgo crooned. “Thank you for taking care of my son.”

Mydei rubbed the spot between his brows. “I’ll call you again tomorrow,” he said, dismissing her as gently as possible. “Drive safely, and text me when you get home.”

“Alright.” On the video, Gorgo pressed two fingers to her lips before tapping them against her own camera. “Love you.”

Mydei mimicked her gesture, kissing two of his fingers before placing them over his phone. “Love you too.”

As soon as both of them hung up, Mydei pocketed his phone in the pocket of his pants. Then he crossed his arms over his chest, all his softness melting away, and looked at Phainon. “What are you doing here?”

Phainon remained standing just outside of the doorway. He made no move to invite himself inside, and Mydei made no move to invite him either.

“Like I said,” he reiterated, his politeness giving way to his usual teasing self, “I’m here to make sure you’re settling in alright.”

Mydei angled his body and gestured at the neatness of his room. “Everything’s in order,” he said concisely.

Phainon pouted. “No room tour?”

Mydei looked at him with incredulity. “We have the same kind of suite.”

Phainon sighed, looking forlorn as he leaned against the doorway. “You’re so much nicer when your mom is around.”

Mydei heaved his own sigh, though he only looked exasperated by it all. “If there’s nothing else, I would like to get some rest. I’m fine, but I’m a little tired.”

“Really?” Phainon took a half step closer. “I still remember the days leading up to my first tour. I could hardly eat or sleep from the anxiety of it all.”

“So? Are you still anxious now?”

“Only a little. But I’m here to make sure you don’t lose yourself in that same overwhelming feeling.”

“Are you really?” Mydei asked. “Or are you just here to ensure I don’t fuck up the opening act?”

Phainon laughed. “Hey now! What do you take me for?” He paused in consideration before finally adding, “Can’t it be both?”

Mydei shot him a look. “There it is. Your faux concern.”

“It’s not a pretense! I really am concerned!” Phainon shook his head with a sigh. “Honestly, Mydei. You doubt my intentions a little too much.”

“For good reason,” Mydei said under his breath, though his words seemed to be lost on Phainon as he continued to talk.

“You know,” he began, crossing his arms over his chest and leaning against the wall, “you’re a lot more attractive if you’re only singing and playing the guitar.”

Mydei frowned at the backhanded compliment. Then, in the hopes of turning this situation on him and catching him tongue tied instead, he raised a brow. “You find me attractive?”

Unfazed, Phainon shrugged. “So what if I do? It doesn’t mean anything.”

He almost convinced both of them that it *was* nothing. But Phainon’s expression darkened, just a little bit, and he glanced at Mydei once more. “Unless, of course, you want it to.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “What does *that* mean this time?”

“Whatever you want it to mean.”

They stared at one another, their shared gaze an impasse. Then Phainon smiled cryptically, dismissively, and he pushed himself off the wall.

“Anyways,” he said with a wave of his hand. “It’s getting late, and I want to get as much sleep as I can before the tour begins in a few days.”

He turned on his heel. “Good night, Mydei. If you need anything, I’m just a room away.” He looked over his shoulder, blue eyes hooking in Mydei’s golden ones. “And, if you need anything *else*, know that our previous arrangement still stands.”

He turned away and Mydei watched him go, his eyes tracing every inch of his back: from the top of his head, to his waist, to the heels of his feet. Though the clothing he wore was a size too big on him, Mydei could almost imagine the tautness of his muscles, the shape of his waist, and the curves of his body beneath the layers.

He found himself clenching his jaw, considering.

Phainon may be telling the whole truth, but Mydei was definitely a little dishonest with himself. For all his show of confidence, he *was* a little nervous for the tour.

So, with his best attempts to swallow his pride, Mydei cleared his throat. “Phainon.”

Phainon paused. He glanced at Mydei, eyes wide with innocence. “Hmm?”

Mydei’s fingers tightened against his arms. Was Phainon going to make him spell it out? “I may be a little high strung,” he said in a quiet voice.

Phainon smiled. He turned fully and made his way back to Mydei. “Now what does *that* mean this time?”

Mydei scowled as Phainon entered his personal space. He hated it when his own words were thrown back at him, and he hated it when someone was far too close to him.

And yet.

Phainon continued taking a step forward until he had one leg pressed between Mydei's. His thigh rubbed against his groin as he snaked an arm around Mydei's waist.

"Are you, perhaps, looking for a way to blow off some steam?" he asked, pulling him closer. His eyes dropped down to Mydei's lips once, but he made no move to further close the distance between them.

Mydei stiffened. Despite himself, he found himself leaning in closer and closer. "Don't make me regret this."

Phainon only grinned in response. Then he was pushing against Mydei, leading them both back inside the privacy of the suite, before closing the door behind him.

Mydei could deny this as much as he wanted to. But as they fell in a tangle of limbs and lust, articles of clothing slowly falling apart between them, he knew it was futile to do so.

After all, this wasn't their first time. Nor was it their second, nor was it their third.

From the moment Mydei met Phainon, he was ensnared with two arrangements. Both bore different loads of responsibility, but both were of his own volition.

The first was his contract with Phainon and the Flame-Chasers, a promise that Mydei would be their opening act for their music tour this year.

The second, Mydei thought, as he and Phainon finally stumbled into his bed, was this.

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A Few Weeks Ago

On the day Mydei signed the contract, it felt like the hours were simultaneously fleeting and unending.

The hours were fleeting because, in hindsight, he could hardly recall the details of what went down during the morning and the afternoon. All he remembered was the comprehensive meeting that transpired between him and his manager, and the Flame-Chasers themselves and their own manager. Both parties had met and finalized the details of what their contracts would entail, and by the time Mydei had signed the pages, he was ready to celebrate his win with a solitary unwinding in his own room.

However, he was immediately pulled into the celebratory party the Flame-Chasers were hosting that evening, and that was when the hours turned from surprisingly brief to excruciatingly endless.

The club Mydei was in now was a little smaller than others he had gone to in the past, and tonight's event was strictly accessible by invitation only. He would have thought that the combination of the limited space and the limited crowd would make the whole ordeal less overstimulating for him, but all that did was make the venue appear more packed than it already was. Despite its walls made of black marble, its tables made of dark slates, and its couches and chairs made of smooth velvet, the stylish interior was a mere background to the way everyone was losing themselves to the alcohol, to the music, to the conversations. Mydei was not a fan of extroverted spaces to begin with; being in one, no matter how luxurious it was, was already testing his limits.

But even though Mydei found himself doubting the enjoyability of such an occasion, he knew he had to stay, at least for a few more hours. Apart from being the opening act for the Flame-Chasers, he was here to further broaden his horizons. This party, which tided in not only the band members but their sponsors and close affiliates as well, was a chance to promote Mydei's name even further.

After all, the only reason Mydei was presented with this opportunity in the first place was because one of his solo performances had gone viral on the Internet. Overnight, he went from being just another indie singer to someone worth keeping an eye on. His record label could hardly keep up with inquiries regarding his availability, and they had to filter out multiple invitations before finally settling on the Flame-Chasers' proposal.

Despite his introverted nature, Mydei knew he needed to maximize this momentum and ensure that he wasn't just a passing name in the music industry.

That didn't mean he didn't get tired, though. In fact, he was frankly more exhausted than he'd ever been so far.

"Enjoying yourself?"

Mydei didn't even know he was staring into space until the familiar voice brought him out of his reverie. Beside him, the lead singer of the Flame-Chasers himself, Phainon, settled into the available space beside Mydei.

Mydei took in the sight of him. In most of his public appearances, Phainon was notable for wearing two things: a dark choker that opened to the side to reveal the tattoo of a sun on his neck, and a white leather jacket studded with spikes at the sleeves and held together by a belt at the hem. He wore both of these things now, alongside a pair of fitted jeans and a pair of low boots.

Mydei, not one to be underdressed, was in a similar get-up. He had opted to wear the usual black leather jacket he wore during his solo performances. Leather bracelets adorned his wrists, and his waist was dripping with several silver chains. A pair of leather pants dressed his legs, accentuated by the boots that came up to the midpoint of his shins.

Outwardly, Mydei fitted right in. But to say that he was enjoying himself seemed like a stretch.

He offered Phainon a small shrug in response. Though the music wasn't loud, he still had to raise his voice to be heard over the chatter of the place.

“It could be worse.”

Phainon smiled knowingly. “You don’t have to pretend. My first party within the A-lister scene was overwhelming for me too.” He had a glass in one hand, which he tipped to his lips before placing it against the table before them. He gestured to the empty space in front of Mydei. “You don’t drink?”

Mydei shook his head. “I like to take care of my voice.”

“It’s not so bad,” Phainon countered. “I still drink too, just moderately. It takes the edge off of things.”

Mydei forced himself to recline against the couch. He was sitting too stiffly anyway. “Does that mean you still get nervous before shows and tours?”

“Of course. I don’t think that ever fully goes away.” Phainon draped his arms against the back of the couch and glanced at Mydei. “Why? Are *you* nervous?”

“A little,” Mydei confessed.

“Ha! Then you’re already better than me.” Phainon stared at the small crowd, his gaze looking but not quite seeing, as he replayed a memory only he could see. “I was a mess before our first big tour. My bandmates, Cas and Anaxa, were lucky; they could afford to drown their restlessness with alcohol. Drinking moderately is fine, but not if it’s days before a big event. I had to find other means to deal with the anxiety.”

“Such as?” Mydei inquired. Perhaps he could learn a thing or two from Phainon in this regard.

But Phainon only pursed his lips. He glanced at Mydei before quickly looking away. When he reached for his glass again, Mydei noticed that there was a slight blush against his cheeks, red and sharp against the silver hair that framed his face.

“Ah, well,” Phainon merely said, sipping his drink. “They’re the physical kind.”

It was Mydei’s turn to blush. Phainon need not say anything more. “Oh.”

Neither of them looked at the other for a while as Phainon set his glass back down against the table.

Shit, Mydei thought. He shouldn’t have asked.

But while Mydei was still gathering his bearings, Phainon was already clearing his throat. He angled his body towards him, already taking the conversation back into his own hands. “But what about you? Do you need us to prepare anything for you?”

Mydei almost sighed in relief. He was glad for Phainon’s quick recovery. “What do you mean?”

“Cas usually asks for a certain brand of liquor to bring with her on tour, so I make sure our manager procures that for her beforehand.” Phainon smiled. “So if you have any special requests, feel free to name them.”

“I’m fine. I have my own means as well.”

Phainon raised a brow. “Such as?”

Mydei blew out a breath. He considered denying it, but if Phainon had been honest with his, then Mydei owed it to him to do the same. “Same as yours.”

“Oh.” Phainon tilted his head. This time, he held Mydei’s gaze, and it was Mydei who couldn’t afford to hold his.

“Yeah.” He looked away, studying the wall a little too intensely, before looking back at Phainon.

He was still regarding Mydei. And when their eyes finally met again, the corner of his lips turned upward, almost amusedly.

“How interesting,” Phainon remarked slowly, “for both of us to have the same coping mechanism on this matter.”

Mydei scowled. “Don’t be weird about it.”

“I’m not,” Phainon assured him. He flicked his wrist, and his fingers caressed the edge of Mydei’s shoulder. “I, of all people, would understand that some things are just purely physical.”

Mydei continued to glare at him. Still, for the first time since he arrived at this party, he found himself unclenching, as Phainon absentmindedly traced circles on his shoulder.

It was as he said anyway. Some things were just purely physical indeed.

But whatever reprieve he had managed to achieve was short-lived, for immediately after his conversation with him, several sponsors came up to approach them. Mydei was back on high alert, and his face remained a stiff picture of polite smiles and courteous quips as Phainon introduced themselves to their patrons.

The rest of their time passed in a similar manner. Mydei found himself wounding tighter and tighter, his exhaustion running through his veins, as he rehashed the same spiel of introductions and small talks. Phainon, thankfully, remained beside him the whole time. Whenever Mydei ran out of things to say, Phainon would be there to step in and take over, bridging the gap between two connections and solidifying them.

By the time they finally had some time to themselves, Mydei’s social energy was running on its last dregs. Mydei dropped all pretense and immediately flopped back against the cushioned couch, already exhaling a pent-up sigh.

But as he rested against the velvet cushion, he found himself leaning back against Phainon’s arm. He unknowingly pinned it between his back and the couch for several seconds before he sat upright once more and glanced behind him.

“Sorry,” Mydei said. He snuck a look at his direction. “I didn’t see your arm there.”

Phainon waved off his apology with his other hand. He kept the same arm draped over Mydei’s space. “Don’t worry about it.” He nodded towards their retreating patrons. “Were you nervous?”

“What makes you say that?” Mydei asked drily, almost sarcastically, knowing full well his body language gave him away.

Phainon laughed, no doubt thinking the same thing. He reached over and gave Mydei’s shoulders a squeeze before letting him go. “You’re as stiff as a board,” he remarked. He leaned closer and whispered. “*Relax.*”

Mydei huffed. Every little thing was beginning to make him impatient, and every new stimuli was beginning to chafe at him. He pulled away from Phainon, beholding him with an irritated frown.

“How can I,” he snapped, sounding a little harsh, even to his own ears, “when I’m being introduced to someone new every minute?”

Phainon’s cheery expression finally faltered, and that miniscule shift in his demeanor made Mydei guilty instantly.

Guilty, he concluded, and worried. It was only the first day with the Flame-Chasers and he was already fucking this up.

Mydei rubbed his face with his hands, sighing as he did so.

“Sorry.” He continued to wipe against his eyes before looking at Phainon. He repeated meekly, “Sorry. I didn’t mean to sound ungrateful.”

Though all his mirth was gone, Phainon’s expression remained looking kind. He studied Mydei, retreating away from him to grant him some space.

“Would it help if we took a breather first?” he asked genuinely. “We’ve been in here for a while anyway. A change of scenery may help.”

Mydei slumped his shoulders as he exhaled. “Yes,” he admitted in defeat. “I would like that a lot, actually.”

Phainon brightened. He looked pleased and relieved that his suggestion was well-received, and he remained beaming as he stood. “Come with me then. The rooftop is the perfect place to get away from here temporarily.”

He didn’t need to hold a hand out; his eyes were an invitation enough, and Mydei found himself following after him without another word.

Phainon led them away from the most crowded parts of the club, keeping to the walls and the outskirts of the room, up until they reached a little nook that led to the fire exit. Phainon ducked into it now, pushing the door open until they were faced with stairs that disappeared into several zigzag lines overhead.

Both of them quietly made their way up, neither of them speaking, up until they finally reached another door. Mydei watched Phainon push it open, already eager for the reprieve of the cool night air against his skin.

Except, the door remained shut. Even beneath Phainon’s force, all it did was creak in protest. Still, it remained shut and inaccessible.

“Huh,” Phainon mused. “It’s usually open.” He tried to push against the door once more, but it only rattled against its hinges. He took a step back and frowned at it, as if doing so would get it to unlock itself. Then he glanced at Mydei and offered him an apologetic look. “I can get the key from the bartender. Just wait here and–”

But Mydei was already leaning back against the wall. “It’s fine.” He rested his head against it and closed his eyes. He took a deep breath, inhaling the musty smell of concrete and dust in the thick silence. It was a far cry from the fresh air he’d been hoping for, but it was infinitely better than the club. “The quiet here is much better already.”

He heard Phainon lean back against the stairway railing, the metal of his jacket clanking against the steel of its material. “Already overwhelmed by stardom?”

“A little.”

“You get used to it.”

Mydei cracked an eye open. He found Phainon watching him, studying him curiously. He mustlike shit, he thought to himself, if Phainon was staring at him wide-eyed like that.

Meanwhile, and on the contrary, Phainon himself looked as fresh as he did when the night began. Despite several drinks in his system and the beginnings of sweat beading at his temple, he still looked like the poster child of what it meant to be a celebrity.

“To think you have to go through these everyday,” Mydei found himself muttering. *And still look good while doing it,* he added to himself in his head.

Phainon laughed again, though the sound was more subdued this time. “I told you,” he replied, “I have my own means to deal with it.”

Something about the way he said it made the back of Mydei’s neck prickle. He opened both eyes fully, resuming a more upright position without pushing himself off of the concrete wall. He narrowed his eyes at Phainon, trying to glean what he could from an otherwise indecipherable expression. Then he turned to the door. “Is this door really locked, Phainon?” he questioned, pressing a hand over it.

“Of course it is,” Phainon said, confirmed with the way it refused to budge even beneath Mydei’s touch. He crossed his arms over his chest. “Why are you accusing me of lying? Do you think this is a ploy to get you alone?”

Mydei shot him a look. “You make it sound as if you have dubious motives of your own.”

“Because that’s exactly what you’re implying!”

Phainon pushed himself off the railing. The space between them was already sparse, and the sole movement made the distance between them

even smaller. Even if Mydei were to take a step back now, all that he would find was the wall behind him.

So he stood his ground and watched as Phainon took another step closer.

“But,” the blue-eyed man went on, his voice dropping another octave lower, “if you’re implying something else, then I’m open to hear you out.”

Phainon rested one hand against the side of Mydei’s head, caging him from escaping. Mydei found himself bristling from the lack of an exit, but he also found himself a little aroused by their increasing proximity.

Shit.

“What makes you think I want your help to relieve my stress?” Mydei quipped. Though his own voice had dropped lower, he was relieved to hear how steady he sounded.

Phainon snorted. “Oh, Mydei.” He stroked his cheek, right where the tattoo of a red diamond lay beneath his eye. “If you didn’t want me too, you would have already pushed me away.”

Unknowingly, Mydei found himself leaning into Phainon’s hand. He pressed his cheek against it, his warm face mingling with the equally warm temperature of Phainon’s palm. “Too?”

Phainon traced his hand down his cheek, towards his chest, until his waist. Then he hooked his fingers into the waistband of Mydei’s pants and tugged him closer. Mydei gasped in surprise when he felt both their bodies flush against one another.

“You heard me,” Phainon said. Then he leaned in, his eyes already fluttering shut, as he made his move to erase the remaining inches between them.

Mydei almost allowed him to. He really, really almost gave in. But, at the very last moment, right before their lips touched, Mydei held up a hand between them and stopped Phainon from kissing him.

“Wait,” he said, his gaze stern against Phainon’s questioning one. “Before we go any further, I want to establish some boundaries first.”

Phainon raised his brows. But he pulled away from Mydei’s hand in understanding obedience. “Fair,” he said, yielding. Still, he remained holding Mydei. “Lay your terms.”

Mydei forced himself to look Phainon in the eye without breaking from his gaze. This close together, he could see the specs of darker blue within his bright irises.

“This arrangement will be strictly transactional,” Mydei started, “and nothing more.”

Phainon nodded. “I agree.”

“And,” Mydei added quickly, rushing to get the words out before he could lose his nerve, “I would prefer if we keep kissing out of this.”

Phainon would have been surprised, if Mydei hadn’t already proven his words with his earlier actions. Still, he asked, “Why? Are you a terrible kisser?” When Mydei glared at him, Phainon grinned. “Kidding.”

“Just avoid the lips. Anywhere else is fine,” Mydei clarified.

Phainon smirked. “Heard, loud and clear.” He tilted his head. “But may I ask why?”

“It’s just a personal preference.” Mydei finally averted his gaze. “It’s a little too intimate for something casual.”

From the corner of his eye, Mydei watched Phainon try to catch his gaze. “Alright.” When his attempts were unsuccessful, he cupped Mydei’s cheek and turned his head until they were looking each other in the eye once more. He let his thumb brush against Mydei’s bottom lip, just the ghost of a touch, just barely there, before he pulled away. “I can work with that.”

Mydei bit against the same spot Phainon had just touched. “And you?” he asked, yearning to say anything to distract himself from the predicament he

was in. “What are your boundaries?”

Phainon’s hand, though discreet, was unmistakable. It traveled lower and lower, until his fingers toyed against the buckle of Mydei’s belt. They moved casually as they worked to slowly undo the leather strap over its lock. “Similar to yours,” he agreed. “This will be a purely physical and casual arrangement.”

He leaned forward, his lips tracing Mydei’s ear while his hand continued to undo his belt. “And I want the assurance that this will not interfere with our professional lives in any way.”

Phainon inhaled the scent of Mydei, his face pressing against the side of his neck.

“Keep the tour running without hitches,” he carried on, still caressing Mydei, “and keep the tabloids from catching us like this. The last thing either of us needs is a rumor amidst everything going on.”

He pulled back, every part of him pausing from his flirting as he stared into Mydei’s eyes. “Can you guarantee that?”

“I can.” Mydei grabbed Phainon’s waist and pulled him closer, thrusting his hips against his own. The sudden movement caused both of their clothed erections to rub against one another, and Mydei couldn’t help but falter at the much needed friction.

Still, he forced himself to ask Phainon back, “Can *you?*”

“Without a doubt.” Phainon reached between them before finally pulling Mydei’s belt free from its buckle. With how quick his hand worked to undo it, Mydei realized that Phainon was just toying with him all this time. He could end this just as quickly as it began, with how experienced he was in handling him.

Though Mydei had his own share of experiences, he suddenly felt a little inept in the light of Phainon’s demonstrations.

“Now,” Phainon said sultrily, “where were we?”

With Mydei’s belt finally loosened, Phainon’s fingers found the zipper of his pants beneath. He dragged it down, allowing him access to what lay beneath. Then, with one rough pull, he grabbed the waistbands of Mydei’s pants and his underwear before sliding it down.

Mydei gasped. He immediately placed his hand over Phainon’s, even as he felt his cock spring free, exposed to the stale air of the fire exit they were in. “Here?” he asked. “Someone might see us.”

Phainon raised a brow. “And is that someone in the room with us right now?” He swatted Mydei’s hand away and glanced down between them, at the fullness of Mydei out on display. He smirked. “Besides, it seems like you’re enjoying this as much as I am. Nobody really comes up here anyway, so don’t worry about it.”

“Except you, it seems.” Mydei narrowed his eyes. “How many people have you taken up here?”

Phainon laughed, equal parts amused and endeared. He wrapped a hand around Mydei and began to stroke him, starting an excruciatingly slow pace as he did so. “Do you want the truth or the lie?”

Mydei swallowed, all his attention shifting to where Phainon was touching him. He suddenly found it a lot harder to speak. “Either.”

Phainon dropped his head and kissed the window between Mydei’s jacket and his shirt. He continued to stroke him as his lips traveled to trace the pulse points over his neck.

“You’re the first,” he whispered, voice almost like a purr. “So don’t overthink it, and don’t hold yourself back.”

Mydei shivered against him. His hips began to rut in time with Phainon’s hand, and he could feel the beginnings of his precum leaking out of him. “I’m not overthinking it.”

“Good.” Phainon’s hand began to move faster.

Mydei rested his head against the wall behind him. Despite his best efforts, he found himself panting, completely pliant beneath Phainon’s touch. Phainon hummed in approval, pleased to know that he could get Mydei undone this quickly.

“Consider this the first fulfillment of our arrangement,” Phainon said, his promise sinking true as he increased his pace just a little more.

Mydei gasped. His arms wrapped themselves around Phainon’s neck as his legs began to tremble. Phainon must have sensed Mydei’s weakness, for he pressed him up and pinned him further between his body and the wall.

In this position, Phainon’s knee was placed perfectly by the base of Mydei’s cock. He used this to advantage now, rubbing Mydei as he stroked him.

“Now,” Phainon went on, talking over Mydei’s barely concealed moans, “any time you need to blow off some steam, you can come to me.”

Phainon’s pace remained brutal. After several more heartbeats, his other hand went south to join him. With one hand still sliding up and down Mydei’s cock and with his knee still rubbing against him, his other pressed against the head of his dick. “Or, rather, come for me.”

Mydei needed no further prompting. He wasn’t usually this easy to please, but he wasn’t usually this tense either.

It would have been embarrassing, if this wasn’t the whole purpose of their getaway in the first place.

So Mydei allowed himself to let go, to cum into Phainon’s hands, to let his moans bounce back between the walls of the fire exit. He had half a mind to be mindful of where he was ejaculating, but whatever concerns he may have had were erased by Phainon, who continued to touch him roughly even as he came.

“Phainon,” he choked out, even as he continued spurting into his hands. “Too much.”

“What was that?” Phainon asked, unrelenting. “I can’t understand you if you can’t speak clearly.”

Mydei couldn’t even glare at him. He was too busy falling from his own orgasmic high, and Phainon’s refusal to back down only made his pleasure more unbearable.

The only time Phainon finally, finally, *finally* pulled away was when Mydei stopped shuddering. He disentangled himself from Mydei, eyes bright as he took in his fucked-out expression. “Feeling better?”

Mydei was still catching his breath, but he glanced at Phainon. Then he looked down between them, at the web of cum in Phainon’s hands, at the liquid still clinging against his own shaft, at the errant stains against his own pants. He clicked his tongue.

“You made a mess,” he said by way of answering, neither confirming nor denying Phainon’s assumptions.

“Me?” Phainon echoed incredulously. “Is that any way to thank someone who lent you a helping hand?”

Mydei scowled, his lips already parting to clap back with a retort. But whatever he was about to say died in his tongue as he watched Phainon lick the mess off his own fingers.

With his eyes trained wholly on Mydei, he sucked one digit after another, his mouth taking every one as his tongue lapped at the ones he missed.

“Uh,” Mydei stuttered dumbly. It was downright filthy, he knew, but the sight of Phainon licking his cum from his fingers did something to him.

Phainon continued staring at Mydei. By the time he was done cleaning his hands, his eyes were dark again. “Do you need help cleaning yourself too?” he asked sweetly.

Mydei hesitated. He had fully meant to answer him, to provide him with a decision he had made up in his head. But he took far too long to respond, and Phainon smirked, taking that as an answer enough.

“Alright then,” he decided, getting down on his knees.

Mydei looked down at him, equal parts horrified and turned on. “Wait,” he began, unsure of what exactly he wanted at this very moment.

But Phainon only looked up at Mydei. Then, without breaking eye contact, he flourished a handkerchief from the pocket of his pants and began wiping Mydei clean.

Mydei gaped at him, completely speechless. Phainon smiled, eyes wide with mock innocence. “What?”

Mydei gritted his teeth. “Nothing.”

“Really?” Phainon finished wiping him clean before he rose to his feet. He held out the already soiled handkerchief to him. “Did you expect something else?”

Mydei scowled. He took the handkerchief and continued wiping himself clean, though he had to admit that Phainon had done a good job with that already.

“Let’s just go back to the club,” he muttered, pulling his clothing back over himself. Then he caught sight of Phainon’s erection, still hard and straining against his own pants. “What about you?”

“I can take care of it later.” Phainon adjusted himself so that his jacket fell right over his waist, hiding the evidence of his own arousal beneath. “Don’t worry. You’ll have many opportunities for that. Tonight, as long as you’re feeling okay now, then that’s good enough for me.”

When Mydei continued to look at him dubiously, Phainon laughed. “You’re cute when you’re concerned. But I’m fine, really.”

He gestured to the descending stairwell. “So, if there’s nothing else, I believe it’s time to return to the party.”

With one last wink directed at Mydei, Phainon turned. And then he was going down, following the path that would lead them away from their newfound dirty little secret and back towards the limelight with everyone else.



That had been weeks ago, back when they were little more than strangers to one another. Since then, they’ve kept the sexual aspect of their relationship purely within private walls (most of the time) and they refrained from engaging in anything more that could be mistaken as romantic. Beneath the daylight’s gaze, they were completely professional in their rehearsals, in their planning, and in their promotional events. But hidden within the twilight’s eye, they were completely physical in their touch, in their intimacy, and in their sex.

It was, by all means, the perfect arrangement within an already perfect business venture.

And as Phainon moved inside of Mydei now, their gasps and their moans and their skin creating a symphony of their personal duet within the hotel room, Mydei knew. Even before Mydei realized it, a part of him had always known–even during their first meeting, even during then.

With how good Phainon felt inside of him, he was going to keep coming back for more.

And come, he did.

Chapter End Notes

addendum: please don’t expect me to update this as fast as *parasocial.* i recently got promoted at work (which means more patients and

paperwork) and my time will now be even more divided between them and my hobbies (fic writing).

thnks fr th mmrs [track 02]

Chapter Notes

track 02: *thnks fr th mmrs* by fall out boy
(i wrote this chapter with this song on repeat. rip to my 2025 spotify wrapped.)

additional tags: rimming, anal fingering

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s not like Phainon never wanted this life for himself.

If anything, everything he was doing thus far proved otherwise. From all the days he spent practicing songs with his band (both their own original ones and covers), to all the endorsements and sponsorships he was representing, to finally starting the first leg of their second cross-country tour–they all molded him to undertake the responsibilities he bore everyday. After years of basking in the limelight, he was a veteran when it came to juggling the opportunities presented to him and his band.

Still, no matter how prestigious and esteemed all these were, the fact that he was looking after a novice and budding rock star made him humble.

Not that he was complaining. If anything, having someone so unfamiliar with the tricks of the trade made him feel a sense of normalcy he hadn’t felt in a long, long while.

“What’s with that face?”

Phainon glanced at his bandmates now, both of whom were staring at him with similar expressions. The three of them were arranged atop the center stage of their concert stadium, finalizing their blocking and wrapping up their rehearsal for tomorrow’s show. The rest of their technical crew and other managers were a flurry of busy activity around them, adjusting volume configurations and making sure the lights were all set appropriately.

Beside Phainon was Anaxa, the Flame-Chasers' bassist and the one responsible for asking the question to begin with. The lone eye from which he viewed the world now regarded Phainon with skeptical curiosity.

"What do you mean?" Phainon asked, unknowingly broadcasting those words into the microphone. His voice blared from the speakers, creating an echo throughout the large space, and he pulled away with a wince. He looked at Anaxa again and repeated, without the amplification of the speakers this time, "What face was I making?"

From behind Anaxa sat Castorice, her tiny frame almost dwarfed by the set of drums before her. Still, she twirled a drumstick between her gloved fingers, catching Phainon's attention with the movement. "You've been more relaxed than usual." She attempted to mimic Phainon's expression, her eyes turning wide and her lips turning into a half-smile, before she shrugged. "Usually you're an anxious mess by now."

Phainon brushed a strand of his hair from his eyes, wiping the sweat from his brow with it. "Am I no longer allowed to be excited for tomorrow's tour?" He turned to them, leaning his body weight against the mic stand. "Besides, I'm trying to set a good example for Mydei. You know how nerve-wracking it was during our first tour. I'm sure he feels the same."

Anaxa raised a brow. "He isn't even here yet. What example are you trying to prove?"

"I'm here to be the picture of composure," Phainon explained matter-of-factly. "And if the two of you truly believe I'm as relaxed as I look, then I'm doing a better job with my act than I thought."

Castorice chuckled. "Well," she said, drawing out the vowel of the word, "you're doing a better job than the act you put up at breakfast earlier, at least."

Phainon cringed before putting a finger up over his lips. "Shh," he advised. "That was a lapse of judgment on my end. And if I knew we were all convening as one so early in the morning, then I wouldn't have kept Mydei for so long."

“So you admit,” Castorice replied amusedly, “that you were with him this morning?”

“Perhaps not just this morning,” added Anaxa. “You know how Phainon is when he needs to blow off some steam.”

Phainon clicked his tongue. Then he took several steps away from the mic stand, drawing closer to them. “Hey now,” he started a little more solemnly. “It wouldn’t hurt to be a little more careful with the teasing. A chance at gossip is all the tabloids need before this blows out of proportion.”

Anaxa and Castorice, to their credit, sobered immediately. Having been in a band together for many years meant that they had experienced a variety of highs and lows. They knew just how quickly a simple tease could turn into something more harmful, how a simple rumor could become something that hurt themselves and the people around them.

Despite their banters and jabs, they knew when to draw the line and when to keep the things that were private away from listening ears.

“It goes the same for you,” Anaxa reminded him at last. “You can’t be that careless again. If not for your sake, then for your darling rookie’s.”

Phainon thought back to that night in the fire escape, where he and Mydei had settled the rules of their arrangement. The three rules were simple enough: keep it casual, keep it private, and keep it free from any romantic attachments.

Then he thought back to this morning, when he and Mydei stumbled together in the breakfast buffet of their hotel lobby, unbeknownst to them that they were the only ones missing from their teams’ joint meeting. It was a small and informal one consisting only of Phainon’s bandmates, their manager, and Mydei’s manager. Phainon had been able to play it cool and play it off, but it had taken Mydei a little longer to adjust. He eventually settled into his usual collected persona, but Phainon had seen how nervous Mydei had been at the thought of being caught.

“Relax,” Cyrene, the Flame-Chasers’s band manager, had told him eventually, unable to hold herself back from watching him fidget any longer. “There is nothing to be worried about.”

“And,” she had added, “if there was a hypothetical scenario where there truly *was* a secret to be kept, then there is still nothing to be worried about.” She’d reached over across the table and had clasped Mydei’s hand in hers. “We act as one team now. There are no loose lips here.” She’d smiled reassuringly at Mydei before regarding everyone else with a warning look. “At least, not around this table.”

It had been enough to placate Mydei and reign in everyone else to be on their best behavior. And while Phainon did feel guilty at embarrassing Mydei like that, it had been a relief to hear Cyrene reassure them in that manner.

Phainon sighed, pulling himself away from the memory and back towards the present. But before he could get another quip in, he caught sight of a familiar shade of blonde from the corner of his eye. His attention slid towards it immediately, and he found himself perking up as he watched Mydei appear from the side of the stage, his guitar bag slung over one shoulder. Phainon lifted a hand in a wave and returned to his mic to greet him. “Speak of the devil—welcome, Mydei!”

Mydei turned towards the speakers first before he turned to Phainon. He slowed his steps as he made his way up the stage, suddenly uncertain. “What?”

Anaxa shook his head. He turned back to his sheet music, plucking some chords of a song with his bass guitar once more. “Ignore him,” he advised. “We’re almost done rehearsing anyway.”

“We *are* done,” Phainon corrected, stepping away from his mic. “We were just playing some of our favorite songs now to shake off our nerves. Give us one more track, and then it’s your turn to rehearse.”

Mydei resumed his trek across the stage, his eyes tracing the stadium around them. Though his expression remained carefully devoid of his

emotions, the way his golden eyes widened and gleamed betrayed his nonchalance. He drank in the sight of all the rows of empty chairs, thousands of them staring back at them and facing their center point.

He looked at Phainon. “Take your time,” he decided. “I’ll spectate your last song.”

Phainon’s smile remained bright as Mydei settled beside him. “Amazing, isn’t it?”

A crewman immediately set up another mic stand before him as Mydei knelt down and carefully laid his guitar down. Mydei glanced at him. “What is?”

“The stadium,” Phainon clarified. He gestured to where Mydei had been gawking. “Did you know our tickets for our opening show tomorrow are all sold out?”

Mydei began to set up the wires of his guitar, connecting them to the appropriate channels and the appropriate speakers. “Yes, I know.”

“The place has a capacity of fifteen thousand.”

“Okay.”

“And to think this is the smallest one we’ll be performing for this tour!”

Mydei, who had been too preoccupied with tinkering with the settings of his electric guitar, finally looked up. He heaved a long exhale of his breath.

“Phainon,” he said sharply. “Are you riling me up on purpose?”

Phainon picked up his guitar, a sapphire beauty adorned with white trimmings. “Now why,” he said in a low voice, looking up at Mydei from beneath his lashes as he slowly rose to his feet, “would I do *that?*”

Mydei scowled, and Phainon winked back at him in return.

“Anyways,” Phainon said, already beginning to strum some chords in his guitar. Anaxa and Castorice recognized the tune immediately, and they both positioned themselves to follow after Phainon’s lead. From the way Mydei’s expression brightened, he recognized the song too.

“We’ll play one more song, as promised,” Phainon said. He nodded to the guitar and the mic already in Mydei’s hands. “You can chime in with us, if you know this song.”

“Do *I* know *this* song?” Mydei looked like he was getting more irritated by the minute. He began to match Phainon’s strumming chord for chord, proving his assumptions otherwise. “Do you think I have no idea who Fall Out Boy is?”

Phainon only laughed. “Only teasing, Mydei,” he purred. Then, after another repeat of the same chords, he leaned into the mic and jumped right into the song.

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A Few Hours Ago

When Phainon woke up in the morning, he found himself staring directly into the sunlight streaming in through the open windows. It was a blinding and unwelcome assault upon his vision, and he immediately squeezed his eyes shut again to protect himself from its glare.

How unlike himself, he thought, to fall asleep with the curtains parted like that. Several years of being under the scrutiny of the media and the paparazzi taught him to sleep with curtains drawn, no matter how high up he was from the ground.

Clicking his tongue in displeasure, Phainon rolled over and turned his back to the light. His arm was already outstretched, prepared to retrieve his extra pillow and use it as a shade over his eyes. But instead of coming into contact with the soft cotton cushion, he found his hand landing against the warm skin of someone else’s face instead. The joints of Phainon’s fingers

knocked against the bridge of that man's nose and the curve of his cheek, and the man let out a surprised grunt as he was roused to wakefulness.

Phainon's eyes snapped open, and he hurriedly blinked away the stars left behind by the sunlight earlier. He withdrew his arm, his momentary surprise making him forget *who* was beside him.

The man beside him, however, looked like he remembered exactly who he was with.

With his eyes still partly shut from drowsiness, Mydei glared at Phainon. "What?" he demanded. He raised his hand over himself, using it as a shade against the sun. "What did you hit me for?"

Phainon blinked at him. "Sorry," he said dumbly, his mind still not quite in the present just yet. "I forgot I wasn't alone."

Mydei angled away from him. "Not alone," he said, his morning voice rougher and deeper than his usual one, "and not even in your own room." Then he muttered something too low for Phainon to catch fully, something about courtesy and being woken up so rudely in the morning.

But what Phainon *did* catch was the mark at the base of Mydei's neck, fresh in all its purple bloom and an irrefutable reminder of what they did last night. The mark was one of many, though the constellation of hickeys lay mostly across the broad expanse of Mydei's chest, easy to conceal with a single article of clothing.

Phainon continued to stare at him for several more seconds, his eyes tracing the hickeys he'd left behind. Then he rolled over onto his side, propped his head on one hand, and grinned.

"Oops," he said. Mydei, who had successfully retrieved his phone by his nightstand and was now scrolling through it, spared him a sideways glance. Phainon reached over and began playing with a lock of his gold and crimson hair. "I mean, you *did* say I could spend the night here instead of returning to my own room."

Mydei only rolled his eyes and continued staring at his phone. Phainon tilted his head and tried to peer at his screen. “What time is it anyway?”

Mydei moved, angling his phone away from him. “It’s just a little past eight,” he declared. Then he moved again, elbows propping himself up into a sitting position, and let the blanket slide past his torso to settle at the base of his waist. He rested his back and his head against the bed’s headboard. “You better get up. Your soundcheck at the stadium starts at eleven today.”

“So concerned,” Phainon mused. “That still leaves me with a lot of time, you know.”

“For?”

“For this.”

From beneath their shared blanket, Phainon began to slide his hand up over Mydei’s bare thigh. Although mapping Mydei’s body was not a foreign occurrence to him, the feeling of Mydei’s muscles rippling beneath his palm was always a welcome sensation.

Mydei flinched, his body tensing in complete surprise, before he slapped Phainon’s hand away. “What is wrong with you?” he demanded. “This early in the day? Really?”

Phainon pouted. “Why?” he challenged. “Am I only allowed to be horny at night?”

Mydei’s glare looked like it yearned to burn through Phainon’s soul. Still, with the sun directly over the both of them, Phainon could see how the light illuminated the blush tinting his cheeks. “Whatever happened to not letting this interfere with our profession?”

“Hmm.” Phainon rolled over until he found himself settling in the space between Mydei’s legs. The blanket was barely doing anything to conceal the both of them now. Most of it had slipped onto the edge of the bed and was spilling onto the floor. “Is this interfering with it now?”

Mydei drew in a deep breath. “We have to prepare for our soundchecks.”

“We do,” Phainon agreed. He leaned down and pressed a kiss against the inside of Mydei’s thigh, right at the distal end where his knee began. “But last I checked, you were scheduled to rehearse on stage *after* us.”

Phainon began to make his way up. He alternated his actions, taking turns between planting tender kisses against skin and lustful bites that left more lasting marks.

“So, in reality,” he said, speaking in between his ministrations, “both of us have more than enough time for this.”

He glanced up at Mydei, who was still holding his phone. However, he was no longer paying attention to it. In fact, all he was doing was clutching it tightly, the intense grip of his fingers onto the device betraying how much he wanted this too.

Phainon’s lips finally came to rest against Mydei’s groin. However, instead of kissing his way up the already hardened shaft, he stopped and tilted his head in question. “What do you say, Mydei? Do you think you can spare me a few more minutes?”

Mydei swallowed. His glare had lost all its edge completely, and he was beholding Phainon with a different kind of fire now. Phainon smiled, knowing that his victory was imminent and that it was only a matter of time before Mydei gave in.

Finally, Mydei placed his phone down on the empty space beside him. “Just this once,” he conceded, his voice low. “I prefer not to start my mornings in this manner.”

Phainon needed no further permission. Still, all he did was wrap a hand around Mydei’s cock and nuzzle his cheek against it. “Why?” he asked for the second time that morning. “Will you end up thinking about my cock for the rest of the day if you do?”

Mydei scoffed. “Don’t think so highly of yourself.”

“I try not to.” Phainon finally sat up. He hooked his arms beneath Mydei’s knees, tugging him closer to him and sliding him from the headboard and back onto the mattress. Mydei gasped, his hair fanning out in a glorious crown behind him, as he laid down on his back and stared up at Phainon.

Phainon settled between Mydei’s legs again. Mydei had to prop himself up on his elbows to meet Phainon’s gaze. When their eyes met, Phainon smirked. “But when you look at me like that,” he said in an equally low voice, “you’re only proving my point.”

It was the last thing he said before he ducked his head and kissed the spot between Mydei’s legs.

Except, it wasn’t his cock he was tasting this time.

Mydei immediately arched his hips off the mattress as Phainon’s tongue found the rim of his hole. Phainon’s hands were a strong force that quickly pinned him back down, and, with Mydei stabilized against the bed, he continued to lick against the entrance of his ass.

“Wait,” Mydei huffed. Phainon could feel Mydei trying to stare him down and get his attention. When that proved futile, Mydei reached out and grabbed a tuft of Phainon’s hair. “*Phainon.*”

But Phainon was relentless. He continued to rim the outline of his hole, his tongue prodding further inside with every attempt. He wasted no time asking Mydei questions nor did he trouble himself with looking at him to gauge his reactions. The way his grip loosened against his head, the way he fell back down against the bed and the pillows, and the way his body responded to his rimming–all these were answers enough.

Motivated by Mydei’s body language, Phainon continued to lap at his entrance, burying his face closer and closer against Mydei’s flesh the more he attempted to prod at his insides. Mydei resisted at first, his sphincter tense and unsure as he struggled to relax himself. But with every stripe Phainon licked upon his ass, Mydei melted further and further into a mess of pliancy.

And as Phainon continued to taste him, going deeper and deeper, he began to detect the faint saltiness of cum. Phainon realized it must be from his own cum from last night, still recent enough inside of Mydei for it to linger, despite their best attempts to clean themselves up after everything they've done.

Or, perhaps, Mydei didn't bother to clean himself up as thoroughly as he said he did. Perhaps he liked having Phainon's cum inside of himself after all.

The possibility of that thought being true was enough to make Phainon hard. He moaned into Mydei, and the vibrations of his voice must have sent a jolt of pleasure through Mydei, for he jerked his knee up from the sudden sound. In response, Phainon merely held his legs down once more, ensuring that Mydei remained pinned onto the mattress.

Phainon lapped at his entrance for several more minutes, just until it was wet and loose enough for what came next. Beneath him, Mydei was a writhing mess, squirming and panting as he took all that Phainon was giving him.

When Phainon was satisfied with his work, his hand went to his own cock, already weeping with precum. He gathered whatever he could from his tip, pumping his shaft several times to milk some more of his fluids. Then he aligned his glistening fingers right over Mydei's ass.

With one last lick over his hole, Phainon leaned back. Then he traded his tongue for his finger, never leaving Mydei unattended for more than a few seconds, as he sank his digit into his entrance.

Mydei let out a soft whimper as Phainon felt his finger stretch his walls. Phainon glanced at him, fully expecting him to be looking away. But he found himself staring right into Mydei's eyes instead, his brows drawn together in a silent plea as he watched Phainon thrust a finger into him.

Their eyes met and locked, and Mydei immediately tried to school his expression into something less needy. But Phainon only smirked and began

to pump his finger in and out of him. Mydei clenched his jaw and held his gaze, but the way his eyes widened told all Phainon he needed to know.

“You’ve been awfully quiet,” he teased, still moving his finger at an excruciatingly slow pace. “You can afford to be a little loud. I wouldn’t mind.”

Mydei’s hand gripped the sheets beneath them, crumpling the cloth into a bundle of wrinkles. “And risk straining my voice for tomorrow’s show?” he snapped, though his infliction was lost with his breathlessness.

Phainon dragged his finger in, all the way to the hilt of his knuckle. The movement melted the sternness of Mydei’s expression with it.

“Huh. You’re right,” Phainon mused, his finger unmoving inside of Mydei for several seconds. Then he pulled his finger out all the way, smiling when Mydei gasped at the sudden absence. “I guess you’ll have to do your best to keep quiet then.”

With the same hand, Phainon touched his cock, attempting to take more of his precum as lube. When he came out lacking, he leaned forward and spat into his soiled fingers. Then he positioned his hand back over Mydei’s entrance, watched his saliva drip down two of his fingers, and sheathed both into it without further hesitation.

Mydei, who had been holding Phainon’s gaze with near perfect precision all this time, finally looked away. He clamped one hand over his mouth as he turned his head and squeezed his eyes shut. Yet despite his best attempts at staying silent, Phainon heard his moans seep through his fingers, a muffled song that carried through the expanse of the bedroom.

”Shh,” Phainon soothed, even as he began a faster pace. Though he had two fingers pressed inside of him now, he made sure to avoid Mydei’s prostate. Teasing him in this manner was far too fun, and he had no plans of ending it any time so soon. “Whatever happened to not straining your voice?”

Mydei glared at him. Phainon needed only to move his fingers faster, and that glare disappeared immediately.

“Fuck me,” Mydei moaned, his words muffled beneath his hand, as his hips began to move in time to Phainon’s fingers.

“I’m getting there,” Phainon promised with a smile.

Phainon continued to tease him for a few more minutes, two of his fingers pumping in and out of Mydei as his other hand began to touch himself. Through it all, Phainon continued to watch him, drinking up every strained expression and every muffled whimper and turning every one into additional fuel to continue pleasuring him.

When Phainon was satisfied with his work, he pulled out once more. Mydei turned back to him, his hand finally releasing his own mouth, as he struggled to catch his breath. His eyes found Phainon’s first, both of their gazes locking once more in a silent conversation of their own. Then they traveled south, landing right to where Phainon’s other hand was still pumping his own cock.

“Put it in already,” he said hoarsely. When he looked back up at Phainon, there was a fierce hunger that wasn’t there previously. “I can take it.”

“I know you can.” Phainon’s hand prodded at Mydei’s entrance, three fingers circling the rim this time. “But I want to have a little more fun with you first.”

Mydei tensed. This time, one hand of his flew down to circle Phainon’s wrist in a vice-like grip. “What?”

As an answer, Phainon pressed those same three fingers in and let Mydei’s walls swallow him whole. Mydei’s head snapped back against the pillow, his arm coming to rest over his eyes, as he let out a desperate moan that bordered on a yell. This time, when his back arched off the bed and his hips began to gyrate over Phainon’s fingers, Phainon didn’t bother to pin him down.

Phainon bit down against his bottom lip, his own resolve cracking as he stared at the way Mydei was coming undone. Every thrust was deep, all three of his fingers sinking in until they were no longer visible, and every

thrust was fast, all three of his fingers moving brutally in and out of Mydei. He matched his movements with the one over his cock, knowing he was a minute away from giving in and sliding it inside Mydei instead.

But just before that minute was up, just before he resolved to pull his hand out of Mydei, just before he was ready to finally slide himself inside of him, the doorbell to the suite rang.

Huh?

Both Phainon and Mydei froze, their acts of lust stuttering to a stop as their heads whipped towards the open bedroom door. From his spot on the bed, Phainon was in direct line of sight with the main door that led in and out of the suite, and he stared at it with bated breath.

“Are you expecting someone?” he asked Mydei, looking away from it to look down at him.

Mydei stared back at him, his expression a crossfire between lust and horror. “No,” he said, turning to the door. “Are you?”

“Why would they look for me in your room?” Phainon asked, though the possibility wasn’t exactly off the table either. If Anaxa and Castorice had come looking for him in his room and had found it empty, then it would not be entirely unreasonable to look for him in someone else’s.

Mydei swallowed. He was still looking at the door. “Maybe they got the wrong room.”

Phainon highly doubted it. But as he stared down at Mydei’s distracted expression, he decided to play along with it. “Perhaps,” he said, beginning to move his fingers inside of him once more.

Mydei whipped his head towards him. “Are you crazy?” he hissed. “Someone could be looking for me.”

“Or they could have the wrong room, like you said.” He leaned over Mydei, his body hovering over his as he propped himself up on one arm while the

other continued to move inside him.

“I know you’re close, Mydei,” Phainon whispered. He thrusted his fingers as deep as he could and let it rest there, just shy of his prostate. “Why not let yourself go before whoever is on the other side of the door comes in?”

Mydei opened his mouth to protest. But Phainon silenced him easily by curling his fingers, letting himself press against the most sensitive spot inside of him at last.

It was the final nail in the coffin. Mydei’s face contorted into an expression of release and his arms came up to wrap around Phainon’s back. His body began to writhe and tremble and he was finally, finally, *finally* coming.

Phainon didn’t stop moving inside of Mydei. If anything, he continued to move into him, pressing against his prostate with every thrust, as Mydei released his cum all over themselves.

And that final act, the feeling of Mydei’s warmth splattering over Phainon’s stomach, was Phainon’s breaking point. With his eyes still watching Mydei’s fucked out expression, he came as well, his cock twitching as his cum mingled with Mydei’s and created a joint artwork of their own.

“*Fuck*,” Phainon breathed, his voice cracking as he watched their bodies become painted with white streaks. Distantly, he knew this was supposed to be disgusting. It was hot and erotic and downright filthy.

But how could he bring himself to care about what he was *supposed* to feel? How could he bring himself to care, if the pure satisfaction, the pure bliss, the pure ecstasy he was feeling now was just as valid?

If anything, it was quite impressive that he’d managed to come this much from just the sight of Mydei alone.

But Phainon didn’t have time to linger on that. In fact, he didn’t have time to linger on anything: not on the way he was still coming down from high, not on the way Mydei was still moaning beneath him, not on the way their bodies were now a canvas of white.

Whatever he would have savored was sidelined as he was subsequently distracted by the second ring of the doorbell followed by a strong knock on Mydei's door.

"Mydeimos? Are you awake?"

Mydei, who must have been temporarily distracted by his own orgasm, finally came to his senses. He looked at Phainon in alarm, and Phainon looked back at him with similar urgency.

Both of them recognized that voice after all.

"Shit," Mydei cursed. "*Shit.*"

This time, when he pushed Phainon away, Phainon allowed him. He dragged his fingers out of his ass, both of them wincing and their cocks twitching one last time in a final attempt to release whatever was left of their cum.

Then they were moving, their naked bodies scampering about the place to clean and dress themselves up.

"I'm awake, Aglaea," Mydei called out to his manager as he struggled to wipe the cum off his abdomen with several tissues. He grabbed one of the robes from the closet, hands clumsy but quick as he tied the ribbon over his waist. However, it did little to hide the still obvious tent between his legs, and he groaned at the sight. "Give me a minute!"

"Where am I supposed to go?" Phainon asked in a loud whisper, having just wiped himself clean to the best of his abilities. He began hopping into his sweatpants, nearly tripping onto the floor in the process.

"Just stay out of sight from the door," Mydei replied. Though he sounded less rattled than Phainon, he was still visibly nervous. He pulled a pair of his sweatpants over himself, effectively dampening the evidence of his arousal. "It's not like she's coming in."

“And if she does?” Phainon questioned. He gathered his shirt from the floor and began to pull it over himself. “I’ll hide in your bathroom, just in case.”

Mydei waved him off, still adjusting the robe over himself to hide his softening erection. “Just be quiet and don’t make a sound.”

Phainon gave him a thumbs up. He briskly made his way to the bathroom, shut the door after him, and locked it with a sense of finality. Then, after staring at the closed barrier for several seconds, he pressed his cheek and his ear against the surface, straining to eavesdrop all that he could.

From the other side of the door, he heard Mydei’s footsteps grow fainter with every step. Then there was the sound of a lock turning and a door being swung open and a throat being cleared.

“Good morning, Aglaea.” Even from this distance, Mydei’s voice sounded confident and sure. It was a far cry from how depraved he was mere minutes ago, and Phainon was almost impressed by how easily he could conceal and bury that side of him.

Aglaea’s voice was softer in volume, but Phainon still managed to glean the strong timber of her tone through the wooden barrier of the door. “Good morning, Mydei.”

There was a brief lapse in the conversation before she spoke once more. “I just came to check up on you. The rest of us are already having breakfast in the lobby.”

“Ah.” Though Phainon couldn’t see him, he imagined Mydei looking away, a habit he seemed to have whenever he felt sheepish. “I’m sorry to keep you all waiting. I overslept.”

“It happens. I was merely concerned.”

“I’ll be there shortly.”

“Alright.”

There was another agonizingly long pause. Phainon could imagine Aglaea scrutinizing Mydei, her knowing gaze roving over his physique before studying the interior of his room. Although it was difficult to say, Phainon guessed that she remained just outside of it, uninvited by Mydei as he had promised. From what little he knew of Mydei's manager, he knew that she was a master in paying attention to details. It would stand to reason that she was assessing Mydei's room with the same attentiveness now.

"By any chance," he finally heard her say, her voice just a little louder than earlier, "have you seen Phainon?"

Phainon froze. Then he pressed his ear more firmly against the door, longing to listen to every word that came after.

Mydei, to his credit, did not miss a beat. "Not recently," he lied smoothly. Even his response was perfectly timed, neither too quick nor too hesitant. "Why?"

"Everyone else but the two of you are already downstairs. Cyrene had already gone up to check on him in his room."

"I'm guessing he wasn't there?"

"No."

"Well," Mydei concluded, "I don't know where he is. I'll be sure to pass the message if I see him, though."

"Please do. He and his team are scheduled to rehearse in the stadium earlier than us."

"As I'm aware."

"His bandmates are also looking for him too."

There was another momentary pause, and Phainon could almost imagine Aglaea looking at Mydei with the same mysterious expression she always wore. "Maybe *you'll* have more luck finding him than any of us," she added almost mysteriously.

Phainon thought he heard Mydei sigh. Then he replied, in the most defeated tone Phainon had heard him say yet, “Alright.”

Both of them spared no extra words in exchanging their goodbyes, their muttered words trailing away into the sound of a door swinging shut. Then the sound of footsteps drew closer and closer, and Phainon unlocked the bathroom door and pulled away just in time for Mydei to pull it open.

They stared at one another in silence, both of them wearing the same grim expression. Then Mydei’s morphed into one of complete and utter annoyance, and Phainon couldn’t help but burst into laughter at the sight of it.

“It was *not* funny,” Mydei snapped, crossing his arms over his chest.

“It was.” Phainon made a pinching motion with his index finger and his thumb. “Just a little bit.”

“Were you even listening? Aglaea may as well have said, ‘I know Phainon is in here.’” When Phainon remained chuckling and amused, Mydei clicked his tongue. “This is the last time you’re staying the night.”

“But visiting you in the morning is fine?” Phainon teased.

Mydei’s voice was a deadpan. “Get out.”

“Okay.”

Phainon stepped out of the bathroom, standing within Mydei’s personal space as he did so. His eyes fell upon the bare skin of Mydei’s neck, marred only by the red and purple bruise. No matter how Mydei could have arranged it, the robe would not have been able to conceal the hickey there.

Phainon brushed aside Mydei’s hair from his shoulder. “You know,” he began, leaning in to kiss at the spot, “you should wear something that will conceal this during your soundcheck. Aglaea may have caught on, but the rest haven’t yet.”

Mydei’s hand flew to the same spot, right as Phainon pulled away. “*What?*”

Mydei pushed past him, his jaw dropping in horror as he beheld his reflection. With Mydei's attention elsewhere, Phainon used that moment to sprint towards the door, away from the radius of Mydei's incoming wrath.

"I'll be more careful next time!" he promised, taking a look at the peephole to ensure that no one else was in the hallway. Then he looked over his shoulder, blowing a furious Mydei one last kiss as he opened the door. "See you later! Bye!"

Before Mydei can get another word in, Phainon helped himself out the door, disappearing from his view completely.



That was earlier during the day, back when Phainon had the luxury of evading Mydei and back when he could afford to escape from the intensity of his gaze. But whatever transpired between them in the morning had been hours ago. Now they were several miles away from the privacy of deluxe suites and several opportunities away from shying from the spotlight.

Instead, all they had was this. All they could do now was stand face-to-face with one another, right in the midst of the public scrutiny of bandmates and staff alike, as they strummed their guitars and sang in perfect harmony to the beat and rhythm of the song.

The whole time, Phainon kept his eyes on Mydei, a silent challenge in and of itself as they each goaded the other to look away first. Mydei, not one to lose this time, kept his eyes on him just as fervently, taking up the role of the second voice and providing back-up to Phainon's main vocals.

As they passed verse after verse, chorus after chorus, they found themselves drawing closer and closer to one another. They took their mics, the stands, the guitars with them as they slowly closed the already small gap between them.

When they settled into the bridge of the song, Mydei finally looked away first. He closed his eyes as he turned to his mic and gave one last strum on

his guitar. “*They say!*”

Phainon grinned, triumphant with his quiet win yet again, even as he and Mydei stopped playing their guitars momentarily to focus on singing the bridge of the song.

“*I only think in the form of crunching numbers.*”

He gestured for Mydei to sing the next line, and Mydei immediately obliged.

“*In hotel rooms, collecting page six lovers.*”

Phainon let his guitar go, trading the object between his hands for his mic stand instead. He leaned right into Mydei’s personal space, both of them almost nose to nose with one another.

“*Get me out of my mind.*”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. He stopped cradling his guitar long enough for him to flick the collar of Phainon’s shirt, eyes dark as he sang the next line that belonged to him.

“*And get you out of those clothes.*”

Mydei began to strum anew, building into the crescendo that would lead away from the bridge and back into the final chorus. Still, neither of them broke eye contact as Phainon winked.

“*I’m a liner away from getting you into the mood.*”

Both of them finally broke apart, with Mydei sliding his hand down the neck of his guitar and Phainon singing out, “*Whoa!*”

Anaxa, Phainon, and Mydei all let go of their instruments in perfect synchrony. Only Castorice was played now, her arms swinging with renewed fervor as she carried the song on the drums. Apart from her, the only other sound that reverberated throughout the stadium were Phainon

and Mydei's voices, both of them singing together as they drew closer and closer.

"*One night,*" Phainon sang, "*and one more time!*"

Mydei scoffed. "*Thanks for the memories,*" he continued, "*even though they weren't so great.*"

They sang the next line together, with Phainon retaining his role as the main vocalist while Mydei hit a higher note.

"'*He tastes like you, only sweeter.*'"

Mydei and Anaxa gave a brief strum over their instruments, even as Phainon continued to sing into his mic.

"*One night, yeah, and one more time! Thanks for the memories.*"

Mydei glanced at him and chimed in. "*Thanks for the memories.*"

Then they joined together to sing the same line as earlier, both of them belting out the next line. "'*See, he tastes like you, only sweeter!*'"

They sang the rest of the remaining chorus together, with Castorice drumming to her heart's content as Anaxa bobbed his head in time with his own bass. Mydei carried on with playing over his electric guitar while Phainon focused on being the main voice instead.

If any of them bothered to look around, to pull away from their practice and pay attention to their surroundings, they would have found most of their crew watching the four of them play. Everyone else who was in the stadium with them was transfixed on the way they all played together, each task frozen midaction as the people took their time basking in the power of their chemistry.

And by the time Castorice slammed her arms down against her drums one last time, by the time Anaxa let the last of his bass vibrate through the stadium, by the time Mydei and Phainon let the last of their notes trail off

into silence–every single one of the staff and crew had their eyes on the four of them.

And if any of them bothered to notice, they would have found that their performance was absolutely electrifying, entrancing in every sense of the word.

Distantly, Phainon knew that. And, distantly, Phainon knew that this was the same thrilling feeling he loved, the same high he chased every time he performed on stage.

The only difference was, this time, he had someone beside him who amplified those feelings tenfold.

Unconsciously, and even without knowing he was already doing so, Phainon's gaze slid over to find Mydei's. Mydei had his own head ducked down, his gold hair a bright fire around him as he struggled to catch his breath from their powerful show.

Well. At least he felt the same way as Phainon did in this regard.

Castorice was the first to recover among them, the first to speak up after the last of the sound disappeared from the air. She looked up, her purple strands framing her face in a messy border, and looked towards Phainon.

"Wow," she breathed. She straightened in her seat and found Anaxa's gaze, and only then did Phainon realize how heavily his bandmates were breathing. "That was actually impressive."

Anaxa, who was usually so put together and laidback during their soundchecks, looked just as breathless. He glanced between Phainon and Mydei, tilting his head as he did so. "Did you guys rehearse this beforehand?"

Phainon ran his fingers through his hair and shook his head. He glanced at Mydei again. This time, Mydei was already staring back at him with a dark and indecipherable expression. "No."

Phainon averted his gaze. He pretended to tinker with his mic, adjusting it just so and sliding it even more snugly against its clip. “But,” he remarked, his teasing quips falling away in favor of complete sincerity, “it seems we’re perfectly matched.” He looked at Mydei again, offering him a small smile. “Don’t you think so?”

Although Mydei had just arrived, beads of sweat were already rolling down his temples and his hair was a disheveled mess over his shoulders. He gathered them now, tying them back in a low ponytail as he shook his head at Phainon. “And you had the nerve to imply that I didn’t know the song,” he muttered.

Phainon blinked, brows rising in surprise. Then he laughed, his body leaning against his mic stand as he balanced himself on the way it pivoted against the ground.

“Oh, Mydei.” He straightened himself up and began to slide his own guitar over his head. As he set it down against its guitar stand, he grinned at him. “I’m so glad you’re joining us for this tour.”

Mydei swallowed. This time, it was his turn to turn away. And although Mydei’s cheeks were already red from the rush of blood from their rehearsal, Phainon liked to think his words played a part in his blush as well.

But whatever moment they shared was interrupted by the flurry of activity resuming around them. Anaxa and Castorice moved, already following after Phainon’s lead as they began to pack up for the day. From the corner of his eye, Phainon saw Anaxa rest his bass guitar on a similar stand while Castorice stood from her seat with her drumsticks already in hand.

Knowing that they would be making their way out in no time, Phainon used that small window of opportunity to approach Mydei. Mydei, who was still turned away from him, spared him only a sideways glance.

“I’d love to stay and play more songs with you,” Phainon confessed, voice a little soft so that the mic couldn’t catch his words, “but the band and I *do* have some other things to polish before tomorrow.”

Mydei raised a brow at Phainon. He took a half step back, ensuring that the mic wouldn't pick up his voice either. "You say that as if you need my permission to leave," he replied in an equally soft tone. "You don't."

Phainon laughed again. "It's just my way of saying farewell, Mydei." His eyes dropped down, towards the place where the base of his neck met the slope of his shoulder, towards where an unassuming mark lay hidden beneath black shirt. He flicked his gaze back up to meet his. "Don't give meaning to something that doesn't have one."

Mydei scowled. "And don't go around putting words in my mouth."

Phainon grinned. "Alright."

Both of them continued to stare at one another. Suddenly, neither of them could offer anything to fill the silence between them.

"Anyways," Phainon said, right before the silence bordered on awkwardness, "see you back at the hotel then?"

Mydei worked his jaw, knowing that he couldn't react in any way that would give them away. "See you," he replied simply, concisely.

Phainon smiled. He opened his mouth to say something, to follow up with one last teasing remark. But whatever he would have said was drowned by Castorice's whistle aimed towards his direction.

"Phainon," she called. She and Anaxa were already standing by the edge of the stage, off to the side where the platform disappeared into a short flight of steps leading downward. She gestured to him. "Are you coming or not?"

Anaxa snorted. When he spoke to Castorice, Phainon caught his words, even from this distance. "'See you back at the hotel'?" he echoed. "Oh, I'm sure."

Mydei cringed in embarrassment, catching his comment all the same. He gave Phainon a rough shove, pushing him away from his personal space.

“Go,” he said, already turning away as he began to strum some chords onto his guitar. “They’re waiting for you.”

Phainon nodded. With all his words spent, he gave Mydei a half-hearted wave. Then he looked to his bandmates, both of whom were still patiently waiting. “Coming,” he called back, already jogging towards their direction.

And come, he did, oblivious to the fact that if he had spared one last look over his shoulder, he would have caught Mydei watching him go.

Chapter End Notes

sorry this took a while! i *did* get very busy at work.

the anal fingering part was inspired by this. if i had to be embarrassed by this tweet, then i might as well use it to my advantage.

i also took time to review some technical music terms, and i took time to watch some videos on how *thnks fr th mmrs* could be played on the electric guitar, the bass guitar, and the drums. it guided the way i envisioned the scene, even though i used only 1% of all that i researched into this chapter.

don't threaten me with a good time [track 03]

Chapter Notes

track 03: *don't threaten me with a good time* by panic! at the disco

additional tags: semi-public blowjobs

See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time Mydei wrapped up his soundcheck, pored through all of tomorrow's itineraries, and finalized other remaining matters with Aglaea, the sun had very well set beneath the horizon and the city was quiet with the beginnings of sleep. Even as Mydei trekked quietly through the hallway of his hotel floor now, the usual chatter he could glean behind closed doors were all hushed or completely silent.

Sighing, Mydei tapped the keycard over his door and helped himself back into his suite. He let the water run in his bath, placed all his belongings back to their proper corners, and shrugged off the light jacket he adorned during rehearsals. Then he stripped himself of his clothing, sat against the edge of his bathtub, and began to wait for the water to fill.

For the first time since he opened his eyes today, he was finally and truly alone.

It was a welcome reprieve, an escape he appreciated rather than dreaded. And, because it was the only time he could afford to actually open his phone apart from work matters, Mydei began to scroll through it now as he waited naked by the tub.

The first thing he did was update his mother, to let her know that he was back in his hotel room and was set to retire for the night. Gorgo replied immediately, asking for more details about how his day went and whether he had already eaten, and the two of them exchanged a quick conversation for several minutes. By the time mother and son bid each other good night,

the bath was filled and ready and Mydei helped himself into it soon afterward.

The second thing he did, after settling into the warm water with a relieved groan, was check the rest of his notifications. Most were from the social media accounts that Aglaea herself moderated for him, and he dispelled all of those in the hopes of avoiding thoughts of the concert for the meantime.

Then, before he could delete the notifications in bulk, he noticed one in particular that stood out to him.

Mydei rested his elbows against the side of the tub as he opened the message, dated almost an hour ago.

> Phainon: u back yet? [9:45PM]

Mydei was careful to keep his phone above the water as he typed his reply.

< Mydei: Just got back. [10:38PM]
< Mydei: I want to be alone for now, though. [10:38PM]

Although he knew that Phainon was probably still wide awake, Mydei was surprised to see him crafting his response almost immediately. He watched the three bubbles bob, waiting as Phainon typed.

> Phainon: okaaay [10:38PM]
> Phainon: u dont have to play so hard to get every time [10:39PM]

Mydei scowled. He typed his own response, just two words that said, *I'm serious.* and sent it to him.

> Phainon: okay [10:39PM]
> Phainon: im just a call away if u need anything though [10:39PM]
> Phainon: /srs [10:39PM]
< Mydei: I'm having a bath right now. [10:39PM]
> Phainon: let's have a call right now [10:39PM]
> Phainon: matter of fact let's have a video call while we're at it [10:40PM]

Despite himself, Mydei snorted, the sound almost bordering on a chuckle. Then he tilted his head as he reread one of the messages, frowning as he struggled to make sense of it.

< Mydei: What is “/srs”? [10:40PM]
> Phainon: oh it means serious [10:40PM]
> Phainon: like [10:41PM]
> Phainon: i mean what i’m saying [10:41PM]
< Mydei: I know what serious means, Phainon. [10:41PM]
> Phainon: i just see it around twitter haha so i wanted to use it [10:42PM]
< Mydei: What kind of Twitter account do you have?? Does Cyrene not moderate your account for you? [10:42PM]
> Phainon: i made my own throwaway acc [10:43PM]
> Phainon: its amusing to see the things people say [10:43PM]
> Phainon: ive seen people write the most unhinged tweets about me [10:43PM]
< Mydei: I’d rather not, thanks. [10:44PM]
> Phainon: suit yourself! [10:44PM]

Mydei paused. Then, before he could truly entertain the idea of making a throwaway account as Phainon suggested, Phainon sent him a screenshot. Mydei clicked on it, narrowing his eyes in dismay as he read through the text written over it.

nobody @notkkslna • 9h
*can’t wait to see **mydei’s** conspicuous body during the concert!! 😍 finally get to see my favorite singer perform in the flesh tomorrow OUGHHHHHHH 😍*

> Phainon: see this is the first thing that appears when i search your name [10:47PM]
< Mydei: Who the fuck? [10:47PM]
> Phainon: it has over 1k likes. impressive!!! [10:47PM]
< Mydei: Don’t ever send me tweets like these again. [10:48PM]
> Phainon: damn 😭 tough crowd [10:48PM]

Mydei shook his head to himself before placing his phone down and away from the tub. Then, before Phainon could plague him with more unsolicited

screenshots, Mydei busied himself with bathing and scrubbing himself clean first. As soon as he was done and had a towel wrapped around his waist and another draped over his shoulders, he picked his phone up again and found a string of new screenshots sent his way. Mydei read none of them, skipping straight to telling Phainon off instead.

< Mydei: Send me one more, and I'm blocking you. [10:59PM]
> Phainon: nooo don't block me your so sexy aha [10:59PM]
< Mydei: *You're [10:59PM]
> Phainon: it's a meme mydei [11:00PM]
> Phainon: IMG_5328.jpg [11:01PM]
> Phainon: this one!! [11:01PM]

With a roll of his eyes, Mydei left him on read in favor of continuing to dry himself.

But as Mydei brushed his teeth and donned the rest of his nightwear, he found himself actually…relaxing. Whatever tension he carried earlier, all of his worries over tomorrow and beyond—they all seemed further than they were just an hour ago.

Mydei glanced at his phone, still lit up and open to his conversation with Phainon. He glanced back at the bathtub, at the bubbles still lining its sides and the beads of water still moist at its feet. Then he glanced at his reflection, rubbing at his tired eyes as he finished brushing his teeth.

Well, he decided. Whatever the reason was for his comfort, whether it was a hot bath or a boy with blue eyes, he wasn't going to nitpick on it now. The only thing that mattered was that he felt relaxed enough to finally retire for the night.

After cleaning everything up in his bathroom, Mydei padded over to his bed and laid down upon the pillows there.

< Mydei: I'm going to sleep now. [11:15PM]

Mydei plugged his phone into his charger, already expecting Phainon to protest or make up some excuse to keep him up. But his immediate replies

proved otherwise, and Mydei paused as he read through them.

> Phainon: that's good [11:15PM]
> Phainon: that means ur feeling better [11:15PM]
> Phainon: so rest well [11:15PM]
< Mydei: But I never said I wasn't feeling well. [11:16PM]
> Phainon: u didnt have to [11:16PM]
> Phainon: like i told u before, i was in ur shoes once [11:17PM]
> Phainon: anyways, good night! don't overthink things! [11:17PM]

Mydei's fingers hovered over his keyboard, suddenly unsure whether he should offer anything in return. But, after another moment's consideration, he left Phainon on read. Then he dimmed the lights to his room, pulled the sheets over himself, and went to sleep.

Or, at least, that's what he thought would happen.

In actuality, all he did was dim the lights to his room, pull the sheets over himself, and close his eyes. Then, when nothing happened, his brows drew together and he shifted over in bed, adjusting himself so that he could settle into a more comfortable position. But when that was ineffective, he kicked the blanket away from him, believing that perhaps he was just a little too warm to fall asleep now. But when even that attempt proved futile as well, he took another pillow and pressed it over his face, hoping that the added weight would make him drowsier.

Mydei carried on like that for a while, tossing and turning as if doing so would make him find the best position to fall asleep in. But sleep continued to refuse him, hour after hour, and by the time he dared to check the time, Mydei was disappointed to find that it was already two in the morning.

"Fuck," he swore to himself. He rolled to a sitting position and rubbed his hands over his eyes. Then, when he realized that nothing about him was drowsy at all, he rose to his feet, spun on his heel, and headed over to the balcony.

As soon as he threw open the doors, a cool breeze wafted in through and caressed his skin. Though his room was undoubtedly colder, it still sent a

pepper of goosebumps across Mydei's arms. Yet Mydei welcomed it all, inhaling the open air of the city and staring out at the quiet way it slumbered this late into the night.

Mydei rested his elbows against the railing. Then he closed his eyes, took another deep breath, and exhaled it out in one slow breath.

"I guess you ended up overthinking things, huh?"

Startled, Mydei turned his head towards the direction of the voice. He had hoped he was mishearing things (though why he would conjure up his voice in the middle of the night was beyond him), but Mydei found himself staring at the source instead, disproving his imagination and confirming the reality before him.

To his right, leaning against his own balcony railings, was Phainon. He had his arms draped lazily against the balustrades, and his hair was windswept into unruly waves by the night breeze. Everything about him—from the old cotton shirt over him to the worn sweatpants around his legs to the easy slouch of his shoulders—emanated the picture of ease. The only thing alert about him were his eyes, bright and blue and beaming as he stared back at Mydei. And when their gazes finally met, he smiled wider and gave a small wave.

Mydei, instead, returned his cheer with a frown. "What are you doing here?"

Phainon raised his brows. "Why do you sound so surprised?" He rested his chin against one hand, shifting just a little closer towards Mydei's direction. "Am I no longer allowed to enjoy my own balcony?"

"It's not that," Mydei lied. It was absolutely that, but he knew it was unreasonable to chase Phainon out of the jurisdiction of his own suite.

And, given what Phainon had told him before about having his own worries regarding his shows, it only made sense that Phainon would be out here as well, calming the storm of his thoughts with the serenity of the night.

So, instead of admitting that Phainon's assumptions were correct, Mydei gestured towards the dozing city. "I thought celebrities avoided lingering outside, just in case the paparazzi were nearby."

"Then what are *you* doing here? You're a celebrity too, you know."

"Not as much as you are."

Phainon laughed. "I doubt the media would discriminate between the both of us, especially now that we're going on tour together." He shrugged. "But what does it matter? It's the middle of the night, and we're far from the ground enough that it's no cause for concern."

Mydei didn't even consider that. In fact, he didn't consider any of the things Phainon had just said. He still wasn't used to this level of fame, and such details still didn't come to him naturally. In his mind's eye, he was still beneath the shadow of the Flame-Chasers, still just a man that did not warrant enough attention unlike the band he was opening for.

"Besides," Phainon went on, oblivious or uncaring that Mydei was silent in his own thoughts, "what will they do with a picture of me on the balcony? At most, it will be something that will circulate online for a day and then be forgotten about just as quickly."

Phainon paused. Then he shifted even closer, sliding over until he was at the edge of his balcony nearest to Mydei. "But, now that you're here, I guess it will make a good headline if they caught us talking like this," he teased.

Instead of sliding closer to him, Mydei retreated from Phainon. He leaned against his own balcony with a scowl, most of his body angled away from him. "Don't instigate," he warned.

Phainon grinned amusedly. "Why are you so particular about being caught with me anyway? You're less fussy when you're around Anaxa or Cas."

"I'm not always alone with them," Mydei pointed out. "The press will have less room for misinterpretation."

“Oh?” Phainon’s eyes gleamed. “So it really is just me.” He tilted his head curiously. “Could it be that you have someone who has expressed their disapproval of me? Is there someone waiting for you at home?

“There is none,” Mydei said firmly. “If there was, do you really think I would be—?”

Mydei stopped. *Do you really think I would be sleeping with you?* is what he had meant to say. But it sounded far too crude and far too explicit to admit under the moonlight. Despite Phainon’s reassurance that they were far from listening ears and prying eyes, it was still too bold to say aloud in public.

Phainon, however, didn’t seem to care.

“Would be what?” he pressed. His wide eyes looked back at him innocently. Too innocently. “Having sex with me?”

Mydei glared back at him. What’s wrong with this guy? For someone who wanted to keep their physical relationship a secret, he was far too loud with his mouth. “Yes.”

“Ha!” Phainon shook his head. “You’d be surprised by how many celebrities fuck around behind their partners’ backs.”

Mydei frowned. “Why? Do you?”

“*Me?*” Phainon rested a hand over his chest. For once, Mydei was uncertain whether his affronted look was an act or not. “Are you asking me if I have a lover or if I would betray them like that?”

“Both.” Although it was a statement, it came out sounding more like a question.

“Hmm.” Phainon’s expression remained mysterious. “What do you think?”

“I don’t know.” Mydei already had enough on his mind. Was he supposed to guess what’s on Phainon’s too? “That's why I’m asking you.”

“What would you do if I had a lover?”

“I would tell you to fuck off and stop our arrangement immediately.”

Phainon raised a brow. “Such conviction.”

He turned and leaned his back against the balcony. Then he extended his neck out, letting his head hang against his shoulder as he closed his eyes to feel the wind against his skin. Even from this angle, Mydei could see the tattoo of the golden sun, bare and shining against his smooth skin.

“Don’t worry,” he finally said, his eyes still closed. “If I had one, the tabloids would have already picked it up.” He cracked an eye open and glanced at Mydei. “And if I had a lover, I would not be fucking you.”

Mydei paused. Then he sighed and rested his head against his hand. “Did you have to draw out the answer that long?”

Phainon laughed. “Why? Scared you’d lose me already?”

“Scared I was intruding on something.”

“Not afraid enough if it took you this long to ask. We’ve already spent a number of nights together.” The corner of Phainon’s lips twitched. “Am I that good in bed that you’d turn a blind eye to the truth?”

Mydei lifted his head. He hoped the night was dark enough to conceal his heated blush. “Don’t go around putting words in my mouth.” He scowled again. “Do you even think before you speak?”

“All the time!” Phainon said confidently. “I’m just doing my best to rile you up.”

Phainon moved again. This time, he turned so that his whole body was now facing the direction of Mydei and his balcony. He studied Mydei’s expression, his posture, his body language. Then he grinned triumphantly. “Seems like it’s working.”

Mydei rubbed his temples, heaving a sigh as he did so. He had come out here to get his mind off of things, and all that did was replace one problem for another. “Good night, Phainon.”

“What?” Phainon exclaimed. When Mydei truly began to turn back to his room, he stuttered. “Wait. Really? Leaving so soon?”

Mydei already had one foot back inside his room. He turned to Phainon and put a finger to his lips. “Quiet,” he said. “You’re going to wake the whole hotel up.”

Phainon was still gaping after him when Mydei helped himself back into his room. He had barely closed and locked his balcony doors when he heard his phone ping with a new message.

Sighing, Mydei picked up his device from where he’d left it on the nightstand.

> Phainon: sorry [2:12AM]
> Phainon: i know you said you wanted to be left alone tonight [2:12AM]
< Mydei: It’s fine. [2:13AM]
< Mydei: Your irritating personality managed to stave my thoughts away. [2:13AM]
> Phainon: HAHAHA [2:13AM]
> Phainon: then it seems my plan worked ☺ [2:13AM]

Mydei laid his head back down against his pillow. He angled his screen towards him when it pinged again, and he watched the messages pour in, one after the other.

> Phainon: ok night night [2:15AM]
> Phainon: and do try to get some sleep [2:15AM]
> Phainon: can’t have my opening star be tired for tomorrow’s show [2:15AM]

Mydei hesitated. For all of Phainon’s loudness, for all his pushiness, for all his teasing, the fact remained that Mydei *did* feel more at ease after

speaking with him. He had a unique way of redirecting Mydei's worries, sure, but it was a method that worked on him perfectly every time.

So, Mydei thought, it was only reasonable for him to reply back and wish him the same.

< Mydei: Good night. Please get some rest as well. [2:17AM]
< Mydei: Can't have our main star fumbling tomorrow's show. [2:17AM]

Without checking to see if Phainon replied, Mydei set his phone facedown. Then he reached over, turned off the lights to his room, and finally fell into a dreamless slumber, resolving to think no more of hypothetical questions and imaginary scenarios.



But whatever comfort and solace he found last night all disappeared in the morning.

Mydei woke up with his heart beating erratically in his chest, as if he had spent the whole night running instead of resting. The rhythm of it only increased as the hours passed by, its song never slowing down even as he bathed and ate and changed his clothes. It continued drumming even as he climbed onto their tour bus and settled into his usual seat at the back and waited quietly as their teams ran through the schedule one last time. Then it continued pounding even as stylists and technicians and managers flitted about over him, dressing him up to an ideal image of a rockstar and ensuring his guitar and his mic were tuned to perfection.

Through it all, the only things anchoring him to reality were his phone and the papers in his hands. Even then, they were weak placeholders, never quite enough to placate the storm of his thoughts.

If he wasn't so preoccupied with reviewing his music sheets and designated stage blockings, he would have noticed Phainon watching him. Phainon, having been down this road before, was the example of outward confidence. He cracked jokes with all the stylists, wished all the technical crew a

smooth show, and poked fun at Anaxa and Castorice several times. But every time Phainon turned to Mydei to do the same, he sobered up and watched him quietly instead, trying to gauge how lost he was in his own thoughts and how best to pull him out of them.

If Mydei was less worried, he would have seen Phainon reach for him more than once, his arm just hovering in midair, before he ultimately withdrew it back to himself.

But Mydei was very much deep inside his own head, and he observed none of those things as he poured all his attention on making sure he made no mistakes during his first big concert.

It was only after all the hours of preparation drew to a close and the stadium began filling up with people did Mydei finally snap out of it. Although they had been backstage all this time, hidden in their shared dressing rooms, they were reminded more sternly to remain out of sight until it was finally their turn to appear on stage.

And though the concrete was thick, even Mydei could hear the collective thunder of people's murmurs as they filled the stadium to the brim. Above and all around them, footsteps echoed through the walls, their vibrations making their presence known to the musicians who were set to play.

Mydei finally set his phone and his printouts down. Then he slumped back against his seat, took a deep breath, and exhaled it with a glance at the vanity placed before him.

"Oh," he whispered, completely taken aback by the man staring back at him. It was undoubtedly still him, with his blonde and red hair and his crimson tattoos. But now there was a light layer of make-up over him, smoothing every crease and blemish on his face. Black eyeliner lined the first fold of his eyes while red underlined the ones beneath them, and his lips were gleaming with a light touch of cherry gloss. Even his hair looked like it was curated to be messy, a singular braid running down the side of his right ear while the rest was styled to mimic messy locks running together.

The rest of him was dressed just as beautifully. He was adorned from head to toe in black: black shirt, black leather pants, black belt, black boots, and his personal black leather jacket. Apart from the scattering of stones that filled his clothing here and there, he was the personification of what it looked like to be a wraith. He looked mysterious, alluring, and confident.

And it was the complete opposite of what he was feeling now.

“Hey.”

Mydei turned. Beside him, Phainon sat back against his own chair. Whereas Mydei was the picture of night, Phainon was his complete counterpart. Apart from his signature items of the choker and the white leather jacket, he also wore a tight fitting shirt beneath and a pair of dark pants lined with white thigh straps. Phainon had his phone in his hands, but its screen had gone dark from all his time staring at Mydei.

And though Phainon was merely lounging back and looking at him, he looked more confident than Mydei could ever appear to be.

Mydei swallowed. “Hey,” he echoed. Then he frowned, surprised to hear how timid he sounded even to his own ears.

Phainon raised his brows, equally puzzled. “You usually sound more confident than that.”

“I know.” Mydei cleared his throat, as if doing so could clear the shakiness of his tone as well.

Phainon chuckled. He stood up and pocketed his phone. Then he stretched his arms over his head with an obnoxious yawn. “Come on. Walk with me.”

“To where?” Mydei asked. Still, his body obeyed out of its own accord, his feet rising to stand. “We were advised to stay put.”

“We’re not going out and shaking fans’ hands,” Phainon reassured him. “I’m just taking you to the vending machine nearby. You look like you could use a drink.”

Mydei looked around. While stylists and some of the technical crew were still milling about in their dressing room, Mydei realized that neither Anaxa nor Castorice were within sight. They must have left to take a break of their own or they must have been talking to Cyrene. Either way, if they were wandering around, then Phainon's invitation must be harmless as well.

Right?

Before he could think on it further, Mydei found himself stepping out of their dressing room and after Phainon. He glanced over his shoulder, at the door with two strips of paper that read *Mydei* and *The Flame-Chasers*. Then he glanced back to Phainon, who was already striding away and down the very bright but very gray corridor.

Mydei moved until he was walking alongside him. "I don't really need one, though."

Phainon raised his brows. Beneath the harsh white lights of the hall, Mydei could see the gold eyeliner over his eyes. It sparkled and glimmered now, almost as bright and noticeable as the sun peeking out over his collar. "What?"

"A drink." Mydei buried his hands in the pockets of his pants. "I'm fine."

Phainon didn't say anything in reply. Mydei narrowed his eyes, his confusion turning into suspicion. But before he could untangle the oddity of his actions, he spotted the vending machine that Phainon was pertaining to. It was a sleek silver thing boasting of a variety of beverages, ranging from mineral water to flavored ones to actual juices and sodas.

Just as Mydei was gearing up to say more, Phainon reached for his wrist. "I know," he said.

Mydei looked down at where Phainon was holding him. "What?"

But Phainon didn't give him a chance. Instead, he tugged him forward and sideways, towards a door directly adjacent to the vending machine. Mydei didn't even have time to yell before he was being shoved inside, his feet

stumbling over one another. Then Phainon was closing the door behind them, his hands fumbling for the lock first before he fumbled for Mydei.

Mydei busied himself by sliding his hand against the wall until his fingers came upon a switch. He flicked it immediately, illuminating the very sly and very mischievous expression of Phainon before him. It also lit up the rest of the cramped space, which turned out to be nothing more than a janitor's closet half-filled with cleaning materials.

Mydei gritted his teeth. He tried to move, but the small interior only allowed him to press closer upon Phainon in the process. "What are you doing?" he demanded, his voice strong and sure. "What's gotten into you?"

Something flickered beneath Phainon's blue eyes. "There's the Mydei I know," he murmured. Then his hand began to travel from Mydei's arm, down to the place between his legs.

Mydei's own hand was upon Phainon's wrist immediately, his grip like steel as he stopped him from going any further. "*Phainon.*"

Phainon, to his credit, stopped moving. "I'm only here to ease your mind a little bit." With his other hand, he reached up and rubbed at the spot between Mydei's brows. "Keep worrying like that, and you'll get wrinkles within a year. You'll need more make-up during photoshoots if that happens."

Mydei swatted his hand away. "Do you think I care about what happens in a year? I'm asking you what's happening *now.*"

"And I've already explained my side." The hand over Mydei's crotch began to move, his palm rubbing lightly against the thick layer of clothing.

And Mydei, with his treacherous, traitorous body, couldn't help but gasp at the sudden and welcome friction.

"Are you opposed to this?" Phainon went on, continuing to touch Mydei.

Mydei's grip tightened against Phainon's wrist. He could feel the muscles of his fingers move beneath his grip. "I'm set to play in thirty minutes."

"Then we just have to make this quick."

"You can't be serious."

"And you've been *too* serious all this time."

Phainon leaned forward. With his lips right by Mydei's ear, he asked in a low voice, "If you don't want this, just say the word, and we'll leave. This is nothing more than an offer to help ease your mind."

Mydei clenched his jaw. "Couldn't you have offered this sooner?" he gritted out. "You'll make a mess of me if you do it now."

"Is that all you're concerned with? If so, then you really don't have to worry about that." Phainon pushed him lightly, pressing him up further against the wall until there was no space left between Mydei's back and the concrete. Then, with a slight shift of his clothes so that the white hues wouldn't be stained with dust, Phainon knelt down against the floor. He scooted over, making space until he was directly facing the front of Mydei's belt.

Mydei stared down at him. He went from having a thousand worries in his head to none. In fact, he couldn't even think straight at all as he stared down at Phainon kneeling in front of him.

"Say yes," Phainon began, his fingers hooking on the metal buckle, "or say no. Your thirty minutes have been ticking from the moment we started."

Mydei blinked. Then he ran his fingers through his hair and pursed his lips.

"Fuck," he swore. How was he supposed to refuse with Phainon staring up at him like that? It was so unfair.

"Don't make a mess," Mydei finally decided. He reached down and rested the tips of his fingers on Phainon's chin. "And make it quick. Like you promised."

Phainon’s eyes were an inferno of blue. “Done,” he said.

Then he was moving, hands nimble and quick, as he worked to undo and unzip Mydei from his pants.

Mydei wanted to watch him. He wanted to watch Phainon so badly, to memorize the way he was kneeling almost sacredly before him, to etch into his mind the image of him reaching into Mydei’s pants, to see the moment he finally took his cock out for him to taste.

But the moment Phainon looked up at him, with Mydei’s shaft in his hand, Mydei knew that it would be best if he didn’t watch this at all. Otherwise, all he would be thinking for the rest of the concert was the look on Phainon’s face now.

And that was one mistake he could never afford to make.

So, with his resolve crystallizing, Mydei rested his head against the wall and closed his eyes. With his vision impeded, he focused fully on the way Phainon slid his hand over his length, his grasp strong and sure, as he coaxed him to be as hard as he could.

Then, just as Mydei felt the beginnings of his precum leak out from his tip, he felt Phainon’s breath ghost across his dick. Mydei shuddered, already knowing what was coming next. It was all the warning he got anyway before the dry softness of Phainon’s fingers was replaced by the wet warmth of his mouth.

Mydei moaned immediately, and he followed it up by slapping his own hand over his mouth. He continued to squeeze his eyes shut, desperate not to look and begging his own self-control to keep his gaze averted, as he forced himself to stay quiet as well.

But as Phainon took him in, his mouth bobbing over his erection over and over again, Mydei couldn’t decide which was more difficult: the resolve to keep his eyes closed or the urge to cum into Phainon’s mouth right then and there.

Even though that, exactly, was the point of this whole ordeal. Despite the knowledge that they had to make this quick, Mydei wanted to hold himself back, just a little, and savor this moment just a little more.

Phainon continued to move, taking Mydei further and further every time, until Mydei could feel the tip of his own length hit the back of his throat. Phainon moaned, and Mydei felt him shift his position, angling his head just a little differently to take Mydei fully in the best way possible.

Don't look, Mydei thought to himself, even as the darkness of his vision turned to stars as he felt his cock being swallowed by Phainon whole.

Don't look, he told himself, even as Phainon popped his dick free from his mouth, licked stripes across the shaft, and took him in again, rougher this time.

Please don't look, he begged of himself, even as Mydei began to thrust into Phainon's mouth, his hips rutting against him with a mind of its own as he neared his release.

"Phainon," Mydei gasped, a strangled moan slipping past his lips as he said his name. "I'm gonna cum."

Phainon said nothing. Instead, he grabbed Mydei's waist, his hand circling around until he was gripping his ass. Then he helped Mydei move, his hands commanding Mydei's hips to thrust forward and use his mouth as he pleased.

It was the last push Mydei needed. With a restrained cry, Mydei felt himself cum, his cock spurting white liquid into Phainon's mouth. Phainon moaned again, and he pressed his face against Mydei's crotch, imploring both of them to stop moving as he took all that Mydei released inside of him.

And when Mydei was done, when the last of his cum had been ejaculated, when there was nothing left to release and give to Phainon, only then did he finally, finally open his eyes.

The first thing he noticed was how heavily the both of them were panting. With his attention finally diverted away from his orgasm, he could see and hear just how much they were heaving. It was made even louder by the small space they were both trapped in, and Mydei almost feared that they were being loud enough to be heard outside.

The next thing he saw was Phainon, his own eyes closed but his mouth still open around Mydei's cock. His expression was serene and peaceful, yet there was undoubtedly an undercurrent of lust running beneath.

He must have felt the weight of Mydei's stare, for he glanced up and met Mydei's eyes head-on.

Mydei swallowed. "Phainon," he said hoarsely, though there was no vitriol at all in his words. "Your promise."

Phainon nodded. Then, with all the grace of a man careful not to make a mess, he began to pull away, his mouth sliding out from Mydei with excruciating slowness. Both of them groaned, Mydei more so from the oversensitivity of the sensation on his cock. Yet he watched, impressed, as Phainon truly pulled away from him without a single drop spilling onto his clothing or onto the floor.

Damn. At least Phainon truly was a man of his word.

"Phainon," Mydei said again. "You can spit it out now."

When Phainon didn't respond, Mydei reached down. "Hey." He held his face between his hands, tilting it up so that they were looking straight at one another. Phainon only stared back at him, eyes wide and twinkling. Mydei frowned and commanded, "Don't swallow."

In response, Phainon only winked. Then Mydei watched as Phainon swallowed all of the cum in his mouth, his throat bobbing with the motion until there was nothing left to empty.

Mydei gaped at him. He couldn't even say that he was horrified at the sight.

If anything, the vision of Phainon on his knees before him, with his choker and white leather jacket on and with remnants of his cum at the corner of his lips, was extremely hot.

He was still staring agape when Phainon wiped his lips with the back of his hand. “Too late,” he said. “I promised you I wouldn’t make a mess.”

Mydei finally clamped his mouth shut. He inhaled a sharp breath, responding as he exhaled. “But your voice—”

“Will be fine.” Phainon placed his hands over Mydei’s own, which were still cupping Phainon’s face. “Although I do appreciate the concern.”

Something about the warmth of Phainon’s hands over his brought Mydei back to the reality of their situation. Mydei furrowed his brows, wondering when he’d let himself get so carried away as to hold Phainon in this manner. Then he immediately let him go, almost a little too quickly and a little too roughly. Phainon fell back against his feet, brows rising. But Mydei was already turning away, putting his cock back in his pants and zipping them back over himself as he began to curse.

Phainon, meanwhile, stood up without another word. Mydei could feel the weight of his gaze on him, heavy and quiet as Mydei buckled his belt back over himself. When he finally gathered the strength to face Phainon again, he found him already smiling back at him. “How are you feeling?”

Mydei clicked his tongue. “Don’t ever do that again.”

“Why not? You look a lot better now.”

Mydei shoved Phainon back, but all that did was draw another laugh from the white-haired man. “Fine, fine,” Phainon said. “You can do the same thing to me next time and we can call it even.”

Mydei grabbed the collar of Phainon’s shirt, fully intending to deny such a preposterous suggestion. But as he pulled him close, their chests brushing against one another, Mydei heard the way Phainon’s breath catch as they collided.

This close against one another, Mydei could see how wide Phainon's pupils have become, obviously large even in the light of the janitor's closet.

"You know what?" Mydei whispered. "Maybe I will."

Phainon's teasing expression faltered. It was brief and it was barely a fraction of a second, but it was enough for Mydei.

It was enough for him to know that, at the very least, Phainon was just as flustered as he was.

Phainon cleared his throat, gathering his composure as he did so. "Alright," he said. With one hand, he brushed Mydei's grip from him. With the other, he reached for the handle on the door and unlocked it. "I look forward to it then."

Phainon finally looked away, breaking free from Mydei's grasp completely as he cracked the door open. After peering through the sliver of space, he pushed it open fully and stepped out. Then, when he was certain there truly was no one else, he gestured for Mydei to do the same.

But as soon as Mydei stepped out, his lungs already expanding to inhale the less stale air of the corridor, he was greeted by the thunderous voice of his manager.

"Mydeimos. There you are."

Both Mydei and Phainon flinched. Then they turned, their shoulders slumping slightly as they beheld the stern, almost disapproving gleam of Aglaea's gaze.

"Where—?" she began. Then she looked between him and Phainon, understanding dawning in her eyes. She crossed her arms over her chest, her furious look becoming deadpan. "Ah."

"It's not his fault. I can explain," Phainon began, already rushing to spew out his excuse.

"He's right," Mydei nodded. "It's not my fault."

Phainon turned to him incredulously. “Okay, now wait a second.”

”There is no need for explanations,” Agalaea interrupted. “I can see the truth just fine.”

Aglaea stepped forward. Before Mydei could offer his own version of an excuse, she hooked her arm around his and began tugging him forward, down and away towards the other end of the corridor.

“However,” she said, already rushing away, “I do have to steal Mydei away now. He’s set to perform in fifteen minutes.”

Mydei watched her look over her shoulder, her eyes flashing as she addressed Phainon. “As for you, you should find Cyrene. She has been looking for you as well.”

“Yes, ma’am!” Phainon said, all professional and polite.

Aglaea harrumphed and turned back to the direction they were going. When she did, Mydei risked a glance over his shoulder, casting Phainon one last look.

Phainon, who looked every bit like a scolded puppy, brightened upon seeing Mydei. He cupped his hands over his mouth, his lips parting as he wished him well.

“Break a leg, Mydei!” he cheered. Then his smile softened into one of complete sincerity. “You’ll do great.”

Mydei swallowed. Given how fast they were moving, there was nothing left to do but nod back at him. Then he turned away from Phainon, his attention shifting from him to Aglaea completely. “I—”

“We’ll talk about it later,” she cut in immediately. She glanced at him. “For now, you need to get your head in your performance. I trust that you are prepared enough for your set?”

Mydei decided to drop the subject. She was right anyway. The concert superseded whatever foolishness she caught them in. “I am.”

“Perfect. Because we have wasted enough time.”

Before he knew it, Mydei was being shepherded into another room, a wide rectangular waiting area filled with equipment and wires. There was nothing drab and gray about this one, unlike the corridor which they’d come from. Instead, a group of technicians ran about the place, all of them boasting earpieces or walkie-talkies of their own, each of them deep into conversation with someone else on the line.

But Mydei had no time to fully take in the scene. He allowed himself to be led by Aglaea and the crew instead, multiple people surrounding him all at once to brush up on his make-up or straighten his clothes or hand him his crimson red electric guitar. Then they fitted him with an earpiece of his own, explained that his guitar was already tuned and ready, and instructed him to align himself with the micstand already prepared upon the stage.

At any other time, Mydei would have already been overwhelmed. This was a calibre of a production unlike everything he has known, and he would have easily gone under from the pressure of everyone’s expectations.

But Phainon was right about one thing. Whatever they shared in the janitor’s closet was nothing more than offer to ease his mind.

And ease it did.

Mydei was asked to stand over a circular platform, and another technician explained that it would rise in about ten minutes to take him up to center stage. Mydei nodded in acknowledgement, and then the crew began to dissipate, each of them trickling away to make preparations of their own now that Mydei was all ready to go.

Aglaea, who had taken a step back to let everyone fuss over him, finally stepped forward once more. She beheld Mydei, her emotions carefully hidden from her face.

“Are you ready?” she asked. If Mydei didn’t know better, he would have thought that she sounded almost gentle.

Mydei's fingers tightened against the neck of his guitar as he adjusted the strap over his shoulder. "I am," he said. Then, when Aglaea continued to stare at him, he repeated it in a more confident tone. "I'm ready."

Aglaea finally nodded. Then, at last, she smiled. "Think of it as any other performance you've had in the past."

"Hmm," Mydei mused. "I don't think I've ever had fifteen thousand pairs of eyes on me before."

Aglaea snorted. Then, in unison, both her earpiece and Mydei's crackled with static. A voice advised them that Mydei was set to go up on stage, and Aglaea stepped back and away from the platform.

"You'll do great," Aglaea whispered, repeating Phainon's well wishes onto Mydei.

Mydei nodded. "Thank you," he replied just as softly.

Then, in no time at all and with someone counting down into his ear, Mydei felt the platform beneath him begin to rise.

Mydei took a deep breath. The interior of the waiting room fell away, plunging him into momentary darkness. Above him, he heard the excited screams of the crowd, their muffled cries turning sharper and sharper the closer he got to the stage. Mydei reached up to adjust his earpiece, pressing it deeper into his ear so that he wouldn't miss any cue he may be given.

And then he was on stage, his eyes taking in the complete darkness of the stadium, illuminated only by the scattering of flashlights shining from cameras and phones. Mydei's fingers clenched around his guitar, his one last purchase to hold on to solid ground, his one last reminder that this was it, this was happening, this was *real*.

The platform stopped rising, finally clicking into place against the floor of the stage. Mydei heard the sound of drumsticks coming together, counting down from three.

Think of it as any other performance you've had in the past, Aglaea had advised.

Two.

Mydei grabbed the the micstand and pulled it closer to him. Even in the dimness, he could see its silhouette positioned perfectly before him.

One.

Sorry, Aglaea, Mydei thought. *I can't.*

Then the spotlight was upon him, and Mydei ran his hand over the strings of his guitar, surrendering himself to the music as he summoned the first note of the first song to his very first tour performance.

Because this is so much better than anything I've ever known.

Before him, the crowd responded in kind. Their shouts reverberated throughout the place, almost loud enough to drown out his own song blaring from the speakers.

Mydei lifted his head and stared back at them. He took in the thousands before him, all screaming and all chanting his name, over and over and over.

Then he smiled. And, leaving behind every trace of his anxieties far below him, Mydei stepped up to the mic and began to sing.

It was a feeling unlike everything he had ever known. Mydei knew that he was the one strumming the chords on his own guitar, playing one of the very first songs he had ever written and released. Mydei knew that he was the one singing over the microphone, his voice loud and clear as he sang the lyrics with perfect pitch and timing. Mydei knew that he was the one performing, his head bobbing as he let the band behind him back up his tunes and his vocals.

But, at the same time, he felt like he was watching everything unfold from outside of his own body. It felt like he was another bystander on the mosh

pit, staring up at him in wonder as the gleam of the stones on his leather jacket caught the light and reflected it back to them. It felt like he was another person on the seats, screaming his name as they recorded Mydei playing a riff over his guitar, fingers steady and sure as they coaxed the music out of the instrument. It felt like he was another person on the sidelines, gleeful tears welling in their eyes as they watched Mydei play song after song after song as the opening act for the Flame-Chasers.

It was intoxicating and overwhelming and completely out of this world.

And Mydei couldn't get enough of it.

Whatever worries he had previously been preoccupied with seemed so distant now, like they were so far past behind him they were almost nonexistent. Before he knew it, he had finished the whole of his line-up, and his next and final cue was being whispered to him in the small speaker of his earpiece.

"Get ready," the voice said. "Entering the Flame-Chasers in five minutes."

Mydei continued to play, finishing the last chorus of his own song. Still, he moved discreetly across the stage, stepping up to his next blocking as he made space for the main act that was set to enter.

Then, once he was in position, he strummed the last of his song and let the sound hang in the air as he concluded his own individual setlist.

With heaving shoulders, he stared up at the crowd, drinking in all their praise and all their approval and all their showered glory.

"Thank you all for tonight," Mydei said into the mic. He gave the crowd time to yell back their love, grinning up at them as he basked in the afterglow of his performance.

"However," Mydei started, once he felt a slight lull in their cheers, "I do have one last song to play for you all. It's a cover of a popular track most of you are probably familiar with. But here's the catch."

Slowly, the lights began to flicker shut. One by one, portions of the stage fell into darkness: first the backmost portion, then the left side, then the right. The whole stadium turned dark until only Mydei's spot was bathed in light.

He grabbed the mic and pressed his lips against it. "This time, I'm not singing alone."

And then the light over him went dark.

Mydei knew what was happening now. After all, this was something he and the Flame-Chasers had planned and arranged right from the start. Despite the totality of darkness, he knew that Castorice and Anaxa were now rushing over to their instruments, trading places with Mydei's own team as they did so.

And as faux smoke began to fill the floor of the stage, as Mydei began to play the first few chords of the song they were covering, as the stadium became a cage of everyone's excitement, Mydei knew that Phainon was beginning to rise from the platform on which he had been previously standing upon.

"*Alright, alright,*" Phainon's familiar voice began to blare from the speakers. Beside Mydei, the platform rose higher and higher until he could see the silhouette of the white-haired singer appear.

"*Alright, alright,*" Mydei sang back.

And when the platform locked into place, when Castorice slammed her drumsticks against her drums, when Anaxa began to strum across his bass guitar, that was when the lights all came back on. It illuminated the stage in full, revealing the Flame-Chasers now positioned over the stage, with Mydei standing alongside Phainon.

"*Alright, alright! It's a hell of a feeling though! It's a hell of a feeling though!*" Phainon leaned into his mic, raising his arms out. "Sing it with us!"

Mydei continued to sing through the familiarity of the song, even as the crowd began to yell the lyrics back at them. Phainon, meanwhile, had the widest beam on his face as he pointed his own microphone back at the audience. Beneath the spotlight, he looked like the sun, blazing in a glory of white and gold, as he gathered the crowd to sing with them.

As soon as the refrain ended, he took back his mic and placed it back against his lips. With one glance and a wink towards Mydei, he slid right into the verse, continuing to sing alongside him without missing a beat.

Ah, Mydei thought distantly, even as he continued to perform. *So this is what a seasoned rockstar looks like.*

And though they had rehearsed this multiple times before, Mydei found himself falling down into a different kind of feeling altogether.

None of the rehearsals they had, he realized, could compare to the real thing.

Mydei allowed himself to be possessed by the music, his body and soul completely at the mercy of the song he and the Flame-Chasers were sharing. He allowed the notes to lead him by the hand, to take him into a different kind of excitement unlike anything he has ever known. He even allowed Phainon to guide him, both of them moving around one another like they were the sun and moon orbiting over the other.

And if he had been just a little more conscious, Mydei could have avoided what came next. If he had been just a little less passionate, he could have anticipated what was to come.

If he had been just a little less greedy and ambitious, he could have changed the trajectory of his life and prevented the mess he was about to plunge himself into.

But Mydei was too caught up in the moment to notice the ropes of wires by his feet. By the time he did notice it, the toe of his boot was already entangled upon them, ensnaring him and bringing him down to their clutches.

And before he knew it, before he understood what was happening, before he could even begin to process why his line of sight was suddenly askew, he was falling, falling, falling.

Only then did he realize what was going on, and he braced an arm out, already ready to break his fall.

Shit.

Except, instead of solid ground, he found himself resting against solid warmth instead. Then he was staring face to face at a pair of familiar blue, so bright and concerned and just as surprised as Mydei was.

“When I told you to break a leg,” Phainon said, voice breathless from singing and voice strained from catching Mydei’s body weight, “I didn’t mean it quite literally.”

Mydei was keenly aware of three things, all at once. Firstly, he was suddenly all too aware of how close they were. Phainon was leaning over, his knees and his waist bent as he positioned himself to brace Mydei’s fall and hold him up. Their legs were tangled together and their faces were near enough that Phainon’s expression was almost blurring in Mydei’s eyes. Drops of sweat from Phainon’s bangs fell across Mydei, and every drop that fell rolled down the bridge of his nose.

Secondly, he was all too aware of how tightly they were holding onto one another. The arm that was holding Mydei was the same one that was holding his microphone, and Mydei could feel the equipment digging over his lower back now. Mydei, who previously had his own mic in his hand, had dropped it on the stage completely. Instead, both his hands were clutching the collars of Phainon’s white jacket, fingers tight as he clung onto him for dear life.

And lastly, he was all too aware of everyone around them gasping. Then those gasps rose in pitch and in volume, rising higher and higher until it was a cacophony of shrieks that broke whatever bubble he and Phainon shared.

Mydei whirled around, his eyes wide as he beheld the packed stadium. From this angle, each and every one of the spotlights shone directly onto his line of sight. Still, he could see through them enough to know that all eyes were on him and the main vocalist of the Flame-Chasers.

Not only that, but every phone, every camera, every video recording device was now held up high to capture the scene they were putting onstage.

Oh no, Mydei thought. He turned back to Phainon, who was still looking down at him with an unreadable expression. His eyes were imploring him to know something, to realize one thing, to understand a message he was trying to convey. But all Mydei could glean from it were his words from nights and nights past.

The last thing either of us needs is a rumor amidst everything going on.

Mydei felt his fingers tighten against Phainon, hoping he could quietly convey his apology in that manner.

Whatever rumors were going to come out of this—and he *knew* there would be an abundance of them—he really hoped they would be kind to him and Phainon.

Because he knew that, as of this moment, he was in deep fucking shit.

Chapter End Notes

> i once received a lighthearted comment saying that the secondhand embarrassment they felt while reading another fic of mine was diabolical. so i'll be the first to say it this time: i'm sorry for putting you through another round of secondhand embarrassment with this chapter. 😭

the good, the bad and the dirty [track 04]

Chapter Notes

track 04: *the good, the bad and the dirty* by panic! at the disco

additional tags: anal sex

See the end of the chapter for more notes

During their first year of fame, right after they garnered the people's attention with their band's debut single, the Flame-Chasers began to receive a steady string of offers from various brands. From the bigger, luxurious ones to the smaller, rising ones, each and every one of those names sought for their partnership and collaboration to boost their products.

Phainon remembered his first shoot clearly. After all, he had been nothing short of ecstatic but nervous on the day itself. He'd been rolling around a lollipop in his mouth the whole morning, a habit he once had to help him manage more nerve-wracking situations.

"Do you think they'd kick me out if I did something extremely stupid on set?" he'd asked. Back then, all they had was a van that carried them to and from places, nothing as grand as the tour bus they had now, and he and his bandmates were all seated at the back.

Cyrene, who had occupied the passenger seat and was busy arranging their schedules, had looked up from her tablet. When she'd looked over her shoulder at him, her pink bob had moved with her. "Are you planning something?"

Anaxa, who had been quiet up until that point, had sighed. "Not entirely out of the realm of possibility."

"I'm not planning anything!" Phainon had protested. Then, realizing the question he'd posed sounded misleading, he'd clarified, "What if I

accidentally ruined one of their leather products? Or break one of their bag straps? You know, honest mistakes like that."

"Phainon," Castorice had said, horror etched onto her face, "I really, really hope you don't break any of the things they're asking us to model. And please don't attract such negative thoughts."

Phainon had left it at that. Castorice had a point anyway; there was no use thinking of such possibilities when he could work to avoid those mishaps instead.

And Phainon had succeeded for the most part. He had broken none of the things they were modeling.

The only thing he did manage to break was a lightstand. He had accidentally leaned too far against it while waiting for his turn to pose, and he had been unable to break its fall in his panic. It had fallen and shattered into a hundred shards of glass on the floor, and they'd had to stop the shoot for an hour or so until they had everything cleaned up. Phainon had been too ashamed to face the heads of the brand after that, and he'd kept his head bowed as he issued apology after apology to them.

While they did assure him that things were alright, the rumor that Phainon was a clumsy rookie of a star circulated behind the scenes for a long, long time. It had taken him multiple projects to regain the trust of crewmen again, and even then, they still took extra caution to always position him away from fragile items from then on.

But the rumor had passed and Phainon had cleared his name and now he was someone the brands invited back time and time again.

That was a lesson he learned during the first year of his career. Whatever rumor went around could always be undone, given the right amount of time and the right amount of effort and, if needed, the right amount of connections.

He just didn't know if Mydei knew that yet.

Or, scratch that. He *knew* for certain that Mydei didn't know that yet.

That fragment of a memory ricocheted in his mind now as he sat at the breakfast table of their hotel lobby. It was the morning after the first concert of their tour, and the plan had been for Phainon's and Mydei's teams to eat a hearty meal together in the private function room before they made their way to their next tour stop. It was meant to be a celebratory breakfast of sorts, an acknowledgement that they had gotten past the first show.

Instead, a solemn atmosphere loomed over the table where Phainon, Anaxa, and Castorice sat. Mydei, Aglaea, and Cyrene were still nowhere in sight, though their manager assured them that they were already coming down from their rooms.

"So," Castorice started, her eyes flitting away from her phone briefly to address her bandmate. "It seems like you and Mydei are still trending."

Phainon, who was busy scrolling through his own phone, raised his brows. "I'm well aware."

And it was true. After their show had concluded, the first thing he did once he was alone was throw himself down a rabbit hole of all the things people were saying about their concert. He didn't even need to search his or Mydei's name; the posts were already curated and arranged on his timeline the moment he opened his app.

Pop Crave @PopCrave • 5h
Mydei stuns in his first performance as the opening act for The Flame-Chasers.

gyu @samoyedphainon • 4h
NO BC LITERALLY EVERYONE WAS SCREAMING WHEN PHAINON CAUGHT MYDEI OUUUUUUUU TOP 5 CONCERT MOMENTS OF ALL TIME

just a fujoshi @notabot1059 • 2h
PLEASEEEEE can anyone sell me their ticket to the next flame-chasers

concert i wanna watch phainon and mydei live PLEASE GUYS PLS PLS PLS

Daily PhaiDei Slop @daily_phaidei • 2h
Making this account right now because I just know those two are gonna keep getting freaky.
> **just a fujoshi** @notabot1059 • 1h
> *omg there's already a ship name??*
>> @PRINCESS2352691 • 1h
>> *M Y P U S S Y I N B I O*

Pop Crave @PopCrave • 4h
Fans go wild during The Flame-Chasers's first concert after the band's lead singer, Phainon, catches Mydei in his arms during a fall.

The posts went on and on, not just from what he could see in Twitter, but in the other social media platforms as well. It was all he saw anywhere he went, the videos all boasting various angles of the moment Mydei had tripped on stage and the exact time Phainon had whirled to catch him.

Not like Phainon needed any of those to remind him of what happened. Even without the thousands of video recordings circulating online, Phainon had that memory memorized. He recalled, with perfect clarity, the moment he noticed Mydei walking towards the tangled rope wires of their instruments. He recalled, with flawless precision, the moment Phainon stepped closer to him, his arms still hesitant on what he would do with his microphone and his own guitar.

Then he recalled, with absolute remembrance, the moment Phainon had caught him, his blue eyes locking with Mydei's gold ones as he quietly asked him with his stare, *Are you alright?*

He was still waiting for Mydei's answer to that question.

Phainon placed his phone on the table now and sighed. "Don't you think you guys are blowing this out of proportion?" he said. "Bad publicity is still publicity."

“So you admit,” Anaxa remarked, “that this is bad?”

“Uhm. Well.” Phainon scratched the back of his head. “For our managers, I guess this is a PR nightmare. But if they play our cards right–which they will–it can be something we use to our advantage. It’s not like something truly awful happened.”

Anaxa crossed his arms over his chest. “That may be,” he agreed. “But you already know that romantic rumors are some of the worst kinds. The press will begin to hound us like never before, and we’ll have to tighten our security to avoid our privacies from being invaded by them.”

“Okay, point taken.” Phainon threaded his fingers together and rested his chin atop of them. “But don’t act like it’s Mydei’s fault. It’s not like he tripped himself on purpose. We made mistakes when we were rookies too.”

“You’re right. It’s not his fault.” Anaxa narrowed his eyes. “It’s yours for catching him in such an intimate manner.”

“My fault?” Phainon asked incredulously. “So was I supposed to just let him fall?”

“No, but you didn’t even have to hold him for that long. You could have just righted him back up instead of keeping him in your arms. Would you have caught me in the same manner if I was the one who fell?”

“I wouldn’t have caught you at all because you’re being obtuse about this.”

Before Anaxa could get another word in, Phainon heard the amused chuckle of someone behind him.

“Pointing fingers over spilled milk will do us no good,” the sweet and familiar voice of his manager intoned. “Instead, why don’t we try working out a solution that benefits all of us?”

Phainon turned, the legs of his seat scraping against the floor as he moved. Standing a few feet away from him, just by the open door, were the remaining three people their group had been missing.

Cyrene entered the room first, her posture poised and her expression calm as always. There was no doubt that she had been up all night assessing the situation, but whatever stress may be plaguing her did not reflect in the way she carried herself. If anything, her smile remained composed and bright.

Half a step behind her was Aglaea. Whereas Cyrene was the personification of being carefree, Aglaea looked a little more stern. From her face alone, it was difficult to tell just how disapproving she was of the predicament they were now all in. The only consolation Phainon had was that she looked like she had come to an agreement with Cyrene, evident in the way she looked to her for confirmation and support.

And, behind the two women, was the person Phainon had been waiting to see all this time. Although there were dark circles beneath his eyes, evidence of a night poorly spent tossing and turning, he looked far less avoidant than he had been hours ago. In fact, he looked at everyone in the room head-on, as if he had come to terms with the mistake he'd made and was ready to discuss what became of it next. When his eyes finally landed on Phainon, Phainon felt the tense set of his own shoulders relax.

Mydei.

Mydei, to his credit, gave him a slight nod before he looked away once more.

Phainon continued to watch him as Mydei took the empty seat beside him. Cyrene helped herself to the chair beside Castorice, and Aglaea took her place beside Mydei. Now, with the whole team complete and settled, Cyrene placed her tablet before her, clasped her hands together, and gave everyone a reassuring smile.

"Let's cut to the chase," she started. Even though it was still the start of the day, she was already dressed and styled pristinely, ever the image of calmness. "I understand that this is a very interesting turn of events. But it's nothing we can't control, and it's nothing I haven't heard of before."

Cyrene casted her gaze upon Mydei, and her smile softened. "So please. Don't feel too bad about it. After all, handling this is part of our job

description, both Aglaea and I.”

Mydei nodded. Still, he didn’t say a word.

“The most important part is that Mydei is unscathed,” she went on. “That would have been a far more difficult dilemma for us to solve if we had to suddenly pull out our opening act for the rest of the tour.”

“Are we supposed to let the rumors die down then?” Castorice piqued. She tapped several times over her phone before revealing her screen to everyone on the table. “They already have fancams of what happened.”

Phainon watched the video playing from her device, the corners of his lips twitching amusedly as he beheld the way the video cut and transitioned to various angles of Mydei’s fall and Phainon’s rescue. Beside him, Mydei sighed and rubbed at his temples, clearly embarrassed to review the spectacle.

Cyrene, to her credit, watched the entirety of the video with rapt attention.

“Cute,” she remarked with a laugh, once the video looped around back to the beginning. “But going back to Castorice’s question, the answer is no.”

Castorice blinked. She pulled her phone back to herself and exited from the app, plunging the room back into quiet. “No?”

Cyrene shook her head. When she looked at Phainon and Mydei next, her resolve was absolute. “This time, I want you to feed into the rumors.”

And, just like that, there was silence. Complete and utter silence. If Phainon didn’t know any better, he would have thought that a vacuum of gravity and space had come and swallowed their group whole. Everyone, save for Aglaea, was too busy staring at Cyrene in shock. Even Phainon had traded his usual cheery demeanor for one of complete dismay.

What? he thought to himself. Feed into the rumors? What game was Cyrene playing at this time? Was he just mishearing things?

“Wait,” he finally said. He leaned forward, his movements slow and hesitant, as he struggled to comprehend her suggestion. “You want us to what now?”

Cyrene remained unfazed. All she did was reach for her tablet, angling it so that everyone could see the charts and sheets of numbers she pulled up on its screen. “Aglaea and I have been monitoring the public reception and the tour sales overnight.”

She swiped over the numbers, and though Phainon understood little of the data being presented, he understood enough of the line graph and its rising green arrow.

“It seems like Cas was right,” Cyrene went on. “The two of you have become very popular among the fans, and everyone wants to see more.”

“The shows that were yet to sell out all sold out last night,” Aglaea added. She gestured to Cyrene’s tablet as the pink-haired manager continued to flash them another tally of numbers. “Even now, we have been receiving numerous requests to add additional stops to the tour, all for a chance to see you.”

Beside him, Phainon heard Mydei inhale a sharp breath. Then, for the first time this morning, he spoke. “I’m not sure I follow.”

Phainon glanced at him. With how deep his frown was, Mydei was definitely following the conversation. But, like Phainon, he was in complete disbelief at the solution their managers were presenting to them.

“The chemistry you and Phainon displayed on stage was rather captivating,” Cyrene said. “Given that you are both already, well, *close* with one another–”

Phainon and Mydei both coughed at the same time, their thoughts converging to the moment Aglaea caught them red handed yesterday.

“–it shouldn’t be too hard to fan the flames here and there,” Cyrene finished.

“Having the both of you as the face of this tour can also put Anaxa and Castorice a little less out of the spotlight,” Aglaea said. “Something I heard Anaxa express concerns over.”

Across from them, Anaxa hummed. “It sounds plausible in theory. But we *will* be followed by the paparazzi just as much as you are.”

“Not as closely as Phainon and Mydei will be.”

Phainon drummed his fingers across the table. “So that’s the play this time? Mydei and I will be the sacrificial lamb to take the brunt of the press?”

Cyrene pouted. “Please don’t word it so poorly,” she said. “Of everyone in this table, you are the most used to the attention from the press anyway. Mydei just has to learn a trick or two from you on how to play pretend.”

“And what are we doing this for exactly?” Mydei asked.

“Profit,” Aglaea replied simply. “The revenue from the sold tickets have already exceeded our expectations, but they continue to rise in number. Moreover, the brand deals and partnerships after last night’s stunt have already begun to pour in. Apart from financial profit, these additional projects will mean more exposure and opportunities down the line.”

Mydei leaned back against his seat. It was difficult for Phainon to glean whether or not he approved of this proposal. “What happens if the people find out that this is all for show? Wouldn’t that backfire on us?”

Cyrene shook her head. “We’re not asking you to be explicit about the status of your relationship. In fact, I would encourage you to keep it as subtle as possible. When asked in interviews, you are even free to acknowledge that there is truly nothing between you.” She flashed them a saccharine smile. “After all, the best lies are the ones with a hint of truth in them.”

Aglaea nodded in agreement. “All we are asking is that you string the people along, just a little bit,” she said. “Just enough to keep their attention on us.”

“If we refuse this,” Mydei asked, “what happens then?”

Cyrene opened her mouth, already ready to give him an objective reply. But Phainon turned to Mydei and beat her to the punchline, answering in her stead.

“If we were to actively stamp down the people’s perceptions of us, it would only be a fight we’d lose,” he said, catching on to Cyrene’s reason. Mydei glanced at him, and Phainon forced himself to keep their shared eye contact. “Regardless of what we say at this point, they will continue to think that the two of us are dating anyway. We might as well run with the narratives in their heads and maximize profit while we’re at it.”

From across the table, Cyrene hummed in approval. “It’s exactly as Phainon said.”

Mydei rubbed a hand over his lips. “I’m assuming I have little say on this matter.”

“Well, I *am* open to ideas!” Cyrene amended. “If you have a better suggestion on how to go about this, then be my guest.” She nodded at Phainon. “Same goes for you.”

Phainon pressed his hands against his lips, his mind churning with a thousand thoughts and possibilities per minute. “We only have to pretend until the end of the tour, right?”

“Correct.”

Phainon sighed. No matter which way he looked at it, Cyrene’s solution was the most feasible at the moment. The people were going to keep talking anyway. They might as well take advantage of the momentum already preceding them.

With another sigh of resignation, he rested his elbows against his seat’s armrests. Then he turned to Mydei and held out a hand for him to take. “Well, what do you say, babe? You jump, I jump, right?”

Mydei glared, first at his outstretched hand and then at him. “We don’t have to pretend here. There’s no one watching us now.”

“Come on,” Phainon cooed, batting his lashes at him. “Is that any way to look at your lover?”

Mydei slapped his hand away. “Knock it off.”

Phainon laughed, and suddenly all the tension in the room fell apart with the sound. Castorice and Anaxa shared a glance of relief, exchanging a silent conversation of their own with that look alone, while Cyrene grinned at all of them.

“So I guess that’s settled.” She pulled herself closer to the table. “Now that everyone is happy with this arrangement, let’s enjoy the rest of our breakfast and get this show on the road.”

It was all the dismissal their group needed. They wasted no time packing away their gadgets and belongings, all of them favoring to peruse the menu instead of chatting any further about unwanted mishaps and marketing strategies.

But now, with everyone distracted and vying for the servers’ attention to take their orders, Phainon snuck a look towards Mydei’s direction. Mydei, feeling Phainon’s gaze on him, glanced back.

Neither of them had had a chance to talk about last night yet. Phainon had no idea whether any of this was actually settling well with him, and he had no way of truly knowing until they were out and done with their breakfast.

The least he could do now was give a thumbs up and a questioning look, an unspoken question directed towards Mydei in the aftermath of everything they’ve just discussed.

Mydei hesitated. After another moment’s pause, he nodded once before flashing him a questioning look of his own.

Phainon nodded back. Then he smiled, looked away from him, and called upon a server to order food for the both of them.

They'll have plenty of time to discuss last night later on, he decided. For now, as Cyrene had said, he was ready to put this aside in the meantime and enjoy their first meal of the day.

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Hours Ago, After Last Night's Concert

For the most part, the rest of the show remained smooth sailing.

In fact, from start to finish, the first night of their tour was outstanding. From the turnout of the attendees to the execution of the lights and sounds by the technical team to the way the Flame-Chasers and Mydei played to their hearts' content—it was, by all means, a successful concert.

The only thing marring its perfection was the tiny little incident in the middle.

And that incident had been haunting Phainon the whole time since it occurred.

"Where is he?" Phainon asked, almost as soon as they exited the stage. They were already being heralded back to their tour bus, but he had yet to catch sight of Mydei amongst the throngs of people and staff ushering them onward.

Castorice, who kept pace beside him, gave him a suspicious look. "Phainon–"

"I'm not angry," he immediately clarified. He looked at her. "I want to know if he's okay."

"You should be asking if your reputation is okay," Anaxa said. He was a step behind him and Castorice, his voice breathless as he went from playing the bass vigorously to running after their tour bus.

“Well, that’s not what I was asking about.”

With none of them knowing the answer to Phainon’s question, the trio allowed the security team to lead them back to their bus. They made quick work of leaving the stadium from the back exit, where their vehicle was already waiting and idling by. Several fans were gathered near it, all of them standing behind a set of barricades, and they erupted into cheers as soon as the Flame-Chasers came into view.

Phainon flashed them a quick smile and a brief wave, the only bit of fanservice he could afford them in the meantime. Then he was stepping up and onto the bus, the full blast of the air conditioning unit immediately assaulting him and making him feel colder than he did.

Phainon looked up, doing a quick scan of the rows of seats. He spotted Mydei almost immediately, in the same seat he always sat in at the back of the bus.

Across the space, their eyes met. Phainon’s lips parted and he took a step towards him.

But Mydei glanced away, his eyes staring resolutely out the tinted window of his seat, and Phainon stilled.

“Phainon.”

He looked over his shoulder at the same time Castorice placed her hand over his arm. Then she was pushing him forward, leading him from blocking the way until she had both of them in a pair of seats. She pulled him to sit on the inside while she took the aisle seat after him.

“You should just leave him be first,” she said beneath her breath. The rest of their team, including Anaxa, began to file into the bus, and Castorice leaned closer to Phainon. “We’ll probably talk about it tomorrow anyway. Give him time.”

Phainon resisted the urge to peek out over the chairs and check on Mydei. Instead, he settled against his seat and pulled out his phone from the pocket

of his pants. “Yeah. Okay.”

The last to board the bus were Cyrene and Aglaea, along with a pair of security guards behind them. As soon as they had taken their seats, the bus began to roll forward and away from the place. Phainon pulled the curtain of his window closed, concealing him from the general public even though the tinted windows already assured him that they would not be able to see him anyway.

And as they continued to roll away, Cyrene stood up briefly to address everyone and congratulate them for a job well done. Still, Phainon heard little of it as he focused instead on pulling up his messages and typing in several of them.

< Phainon: hey [10:49PM]
< Phainon: take your time [10:49PM]
< Phainon: but dont blame yourself for it [10:49PM]
< Phainon: you did gr [10:49PM]

His finger slipped on the last message, his thumb pressing send even before he had a chance to finish what he was saying. It was no fault of his own but entirely on Castorice, who had confiscated his phone and was regarding him with a glare.

“Hey!” Phainon protested.

“What part of leaving him alone do you not understand?” she said, tucking his device out of his reach.

“I was just trying to help!” Phainon held his hand out in a silent plea to get his phone back.

But Castorice was steadfast. She crossed her arms over her chest and closed her eyes. “You can help him tomorrow.”

And that was that. The rest of the ride back to the hotel was quiet and uneventful, though Phainon tried to steal back his phone multiple times from his friend (to no avail).

It was only when they were back at the hotel parking lot did Castorice return it. Even then, she waited until they had all disembarked from the bus before she handed it to him.

“Don’t even think about it,” she warned as they entered the hotel lobby. Their group quickly made their way out from the most open area and towards the elevators. Thankfully, the night was late enough that there was hardly a throng of people in the area. Most of the people who milled about were hotel staff, and they all greeted them amicably as they waited for their ride.

“I get it!” Phainon sulked. He pocketed his phone for emphasis. “See? Hands off.”

Still, even as he kept his phone out of sight, he looked around discreetly for any signs of Mydei. But when he found only Aglaea and the rest of their crew lingering around, Phainon frowned. “Where is he now?”

“Probably running from you.” Castorice patted his shoulder. “I told you to leave him alone.”

Phainon ran his fingers through his hair in defeat. He supposed he should have expected as much. He would have been embarrassed too, if he had caused a scene for everyone during his first tour.

Their group waited for several more minutes for the elevators to arrive. Once they did, everyone filed in quickly, all already eager to get back to their rooms, all eager to wash away the sweat and grime that lingered over their skin and clothes.

The only problem was, with such a large group in tow and considering that they had their security team as well, the elevators filled up much faster than they thought. Everyone but Aglaea finally managed to squeeze themselves inside, and Phainon watched with raised brows as the blonde woman waved them off.

“Go ahead,” she urged.

But Phainon was already stepping out. “No, no.” He held the door open and gestured for her to take his place. “You go on ahead. I’ll take the next one.”

Aglaea regarded him with a curious look. Then, just as Phainon thought she was going to refuse his offer, she stepped inside the elevator.

“Thank you,” she said.

“No worries.” Phainon smiled. He meant it anyway. What kind of gentleman would he be if he had left Aglaea alone to wait in the lobby?

She continued to look at him with the same expression. Then, right before the doors drew to a final close, she called out to him.

“Feel free to take the stairs,” she advised cryptically.

Then the doors closed shut, leaving Phainon staring at his own reflection with a confused expression on his face.

“The stairs?” he echoed to no one in particular. “To the twentieth floor?”

Phainon reached out, his finger already hovering over the button to call the next available ride. But right before he pressed on it, he hesitated, reviewing the way Aglaea had looked and spoken to him.

“Hmm,” he murmured. Then, in an attempt to confirm his suspicions, Phainon turned on his heel and began making his way towards the stairs.

Thankfully, his hypothesis, led on by Aglaea’s coy prompting, was proven true almost immediately. As soon as he pushed the door to the stairwell open, he was greeted by the sight of Mydei sitting down on the bottom most part of the steps.

At the sound of the door opening, Mydei looked up. Then his blank expression turned guarded as he stared at Phainon.

Phainon stared back at him, momentarily frozen. Mydei was still wearing everything he had worn during the concert, though his jacket was a neat pile at his feet and his hair was tied back in a low ponytail. He had his phone in

his hand and his earbuds over his ears. From where Phainon stood, he could see that he was watching an episode of two people baking against one another in a contest.

Both of them remained still for several seconds, their eyes meeting across the space between them.

“Oh. Hi,” Phainon said finally, softly.

Mydei waved. Then he turned back to his phone, refusing to look at Phainon any longer than he had to.

Phainon hesitated. Was this really a good idea? Castorice did tell him to leave him alone until their managers had everything sorted out tomorrow.

Then again, it was one of the managers who tipped him off about Mydei’s whereabouts in the first place. That meant that, at the very least, he was welcome to join Mydei, right?

Phainon took another step in. When Mydei made no move to chase him off, he took another. And another and another until the door was closing behind him. Then, before he could lose his resolve, he flourished his own phone, sat on the space right beside Mydei, and sighed.

“Don’t mind me,” he said as confidently as he could, when Mydei shot him a sideways glance. Phainon took out his own earbuds case from one of the pockets of his jackets and began fitting them over his ears. “I’m just doing my own thing here.”

Phainon stayed true to his word this time. He pulled up one of the streaming apps on his phone and selected one of the shows he was keeping up with. Then he clicked on the last episode he’d stopped at and began to watch it quietly alongside Mydei.

This should be fine. He glanced at Mydei, who was too engrossed in his own show to even look at Phainon. *If he asks me to leave, I will. But this should be fine.*

He didn’t know how much time passed after that. He was too busy watching through the episode and too busy being mindful of the warmth Mydei radiated beside him. With his attention divided, he had no opportunity to assess how long they had been sitting there.

Not like he was keeping track anyway. He was happy enough to stay by his side for this long.

But even with half of his attention on Mydei, even with half of his attention fixed on the minute movements he made, Phainon had no way of predicting what he did next. As soon as the episode Phainon was watching drew to a close and the screen moved on to the next, Mydei scooted over.

Then, with the gentle shyness of someone unsure if they deserved this, Mydei leaned his head on Phainon’s shoulder.

Huh?

Phainon forced himself to remain still. So, so very still, but not tense, not frozen, not stopping dead in his tracks. His intuition told him that if he did, if he showed even the slightest sign of uncomfortability, Mydei would retreat immediately.

Even though he was anything but uncomfortable. Besides, it’s not like Phainon wanted him to go anyway.

Wait. What?

Phainon risked a glance at him. From this angle, he could only see the top of Mydei’s head now. And from this view, he could clearly see the episode playing on his phone screen. It seemed to be at an intense part, and the two bakers were busy throwing hands with one another, the other eventually gaining the upper hand and flinging their opponent down onto the kitchen floor.

But Phainon didn’t care about any of that. What he cared about and what he wanted to see more than anything was Mydei’s expression right at this very moment.

What are you thinking of, Mydei?

Phainon finally looked away and back at his own phone. Though all his efforts were spent successfully ensuring that he was nonchalant about this, his thoughts and emotions had all come to a screeching halt. In his ears, the episode continued to play, its dialogues and soundtrack reverberating into his sense of sound. In his hand, his phone continued to heat up, its screen bright and glaring as it showcased the video playing on it.

In his heart, however, the beat of his cardiac muscle began to drum erratically, starting up a quick rhythm unlike anything he had known.

Get it together, he thought to himself. *He's just laying his head on your shoulder. You've done more intimate things together. Aren't you here precisely because you want to comfort him?*

Yet no amount of mantras he recited to himself helped. For the rest of their time together, up until Phainon's episode finished, all he could think, see, smell, taste, hear, feel was the warmth of Mydei's head upon his shoulder. Even after all their time playing at the concert and despite the undeniable smell of sweat that lingered between them, Phainon found his proximity alluring and intoxicating.

He couldn't take it anymore.

Phainon shifted, just the slightest bit of his arm moving, and it was as he had guessed. Mydei pulled away immediately.

And though it was exactly as he planned, he couldn't help but feel a little disappointed at the loss of Mydei's touch.

Phainon blew out a breath, exhaling all the nerves from his system.

"We should probably go up now," he said at last, relieved when his voice came out strong. He packed away his earbuds and his phone before turning to Mydei. "But can we take the elevator back for it? I'm not really in the mood to climb twenty flights of stairs."

Mydei continued his vigil of silence. Though Phainon could see him clearly now, there was nothing in his face that could indicate what he was feeling, let alone thinking.

Still, he kept his own devices and stood. Relieved, Phainon did the same, and both men quickly found their way to the elevators. And, with no one left milling about this late into the night, it didn't take long for them to find their way back to their hotel floor and in front of the doors to their rooms.

Mydei's room came up first. As such, he stopped first, his hand already over the handle of his door. Then, after inhaling a shaky breath, he turned to Phainon. His eyes were the most vulnerable they have ever been. "Thank you," he said. He swallowed. "I appreciate it."

Phainon, who was still several steps away from the door to his room, stopped too. He didn't need Mydei to spell it out further; he understood everything he was grateful for. "Don't worry about it," he said. "Really."

Mydei turned away without another word. Then he placed his keycard over his door, let the lock beep as it let him pass through, and helped himself inside his suite.

And that was that. Just like that, the first night of their tour had officially come to a close.

Phainon thought he'd do the same. He thought he'd go inside his room right after Mydei did, shedding the grime of his clothes for the comfort of the hotel robe.

Instead, all he did was rest his head against the wooden panel of his door, his thoughts a mess inside his head.

Tomorrow, Castorice had promised him earlier. Everything was going to work itself out tomorrow.

Phainon glanced up at his door and placed a hand over it.

For the love of God, he begged. *Let it work itself out tomorrow.*

▶ •ıı|||ı|ıı|||| |

Well, Phainon thought now, as he found himself staring at another door, though this time it wasn't his. *I guess it did work itself out somehow.*

Or, at least, it did for the most part. It still left him dumbfounded on one thing, and it was the sole reason why Phainon remained standing outside of Mydei's door.

Phainon rubbed the back of his neck, sighing. He didn't know why he was hesitating this much. It wasn't like this was the first time he was approaching him. If anything, he was used to always bothering Mydei, coming and going as he pleased, ringing his doorbell in the middle of the night, and other things of the like. If he were to knock on his door now, he knew Mydei would welcome him with barely any resistance.

Still, those facts did little to boost his courage. He let the minutes slip through his fingers, the quiet solace of the hallway keeping him company, until he had enough of his own cowardice.

"Whatever," he murmured to himself. Taking a deep breath, Phainon reached up and pressed the doorbell. He heard the sound ring through from the cracks beneath the door. "YOLO."

"'YOLO'?" came a voice from behind him. "Who even says that anymore?"

Phainon spun on his heel at once. Even before he saw Mydei leaning against the wall, his legs crossed at the ankles and his arms crossed over his chest, Phainon was already blushing. He could feel all the blood rush to his face, turning his ears, his cheeks, and even his neck a dark shade of red.

"Uh," he stuttered. "Wh–I just–how long, exactly, have you been standing there?" Even to his own ears, his voice was shrill.

Mydei continued to stare at him coolly. If Phainon didn't know better, he would have thought he was amused, his face softening into an almost smile.

“I’ve been here.” He shrugged. “That’s on you for not noticing.”

“Then you should have said something!” Phainon exclaimed.

Mydei pushed himself off the wall and brushed past Phainon to tap his keycard against the lock. “You seemed so deep in thought that I didn’t want to disturb whatever it was that got you so preoccupied.”

“Ugh.” Phainon buried his face in his hands, even as he shuffled after Mydei and into his room. “So embarrassing.”

Mydei glanced at him. “What were you thinking about anyway? Usually you’d come barging in my room no matter the occasion.”

Phainon was hurriedly fanning away the heat from his face with his hands, but he stopped at Mydei’s question. “Oh.” He let his hands fall to his sides, sobering. He began to pick at a stain on the carpet with the toe of his shoes. “I was just wondering if you were up to talk about last night already.”

Whatever teasing mood Mydei had evaporated immediately. “Oh,” he repeated.

Damn, Phainon swore to himself. *Was that too straightforward?*

Mydei closed the door behind him. Then he leaned back against it and faced Phainon completely, albeit with a little uncertainty this time. Although he was a far cry from his appearance last night, a sense of guilt still lingered around his edges.

“I’m sorry for getting us into this mess,” he said finally, voicing out the one thing Phainon knew he had been keeping all this time. “I didn’t get to a chance to say it before, but I’m saying it now.”

But Phainon only waved a hand dismissively. “Please.” He shuffled forward, closing the distance between them until they were only one foot apart. Still, that’s all he did, and he offered nothing more to bridge the remaining gap between them. “The good, the bad, and everything in between–it’s all part of being in the limelight.”

Mydei raised a brow. “Including having pretend lovers?”

Phainon laughed. “Well, not usually. But I know plenty of stars who have pretended to be together for the sake of a new album or a new song collaboration.”

Phainon crossed his arms over his chest. He leaned against the wall to his right, his eyes roving over Mydei and taking in the whole of him.

“But I didn’t come here to talk about that,” he admitted. “I came here to ask how you were doing.”

Mydei hummed. “Did you really?” he asked in a deadpan.

“Hey! What do you take me for?” Phainon smirked. “Unless *you’re* the one with different expectations from this visit.”

Mydei sighed. Then, with a more sober tone, he confessed, “I’m fine.” When Phainon continued staring at him dubiously, he added, “Well, I’m fine *now*, since we have a solution to our predicament.”

“Okay. That’s good.” Phainon finally leaned forward. He reached for the waistband of Mydei’s jeans and pulled him towards himself. “If you were still beating yourself up over what happened, I would have had to kiss your sorrows away.”

Mydei’s eyes flashed. Immediately, he had his hand between them, his palm effectively covering Phainon’s mouth as Phainon attempted to close the distance between them. “Our rules still stand,” he said with a frown.

“You mean the only remaining one?” Phainon continued to speak despite the hand over his mouth. Though his words were muffled, they were close enough that he could still be heard clearly. “I think we’ve already broken at least one. Maybe two, if we’re being generous.”

“No kissing, Phainon,” Mydei reiterated sternly. “And I want no part in an actual romance.”

Phainon wrapped his fingers over Mydei's forearm. Although he pulled it away from his mouth, Phainon leaned down to nuzzle into Mydei's open palm. He kept his eyes on Mydei as he moved deeper, planting a kiss upon the inside of Mydei's wrist. "Understood, babe."

Mydei scowled, even as his cheeks began to turn pink. "And can you keep the act to a minimum? Don't call me pet names when you don't have to."

"But can I touch you like this?" Phainon began to slide one hand beneath Mydei's shirt, his fingers moving over the rough planes of his muscles. "Even when I don't have to?"

"Don't test me." Mydei reached down between them, and Phainon could feel his fingers work to undo the buttons of his pants. "We're amending rules, not scrapping our arrangement entirely."

"Alright. Just make sure not to fall for me." Phainon pressed his palm over Mydei's chest. When he ran a thumb over a nipple, he made sure to lean in and bite the edge of Mydei's earlobe as well. It disarmed Mydei completely, and whatever Mydei had been unzipping in Phainon's pants was forgotten as his arms came up to embrace him. "I can be quite convincing, you know."

Mydei hissed as Phainon continued to rub over his nipple. As Phainon began sliding his shirt upward to expose the rest of his torso, Mydei breathed out, "With the way you can't keep your hands off of me, I think you're the one who should be worried."

Phainon snorted. "Ha!" He nipped at Mydei's ear once more. "We'll see."

But Mydei was right on one account: Phainon couldn't keep his hands off of him.

Phainon took his waist into his grasp, pulling him flush against him until both of them could feel how hard they were for the other. Then he spun Mydei around, moving him quickly until he was slamming right against the door. Mydei braced his hands against it, though the velocity and the impact was enough to draw a loud bang.

“*Phainon,*” Mydei admonished. “Not here. The walls are thin.”

Phainon rested his chin on Mydei’s shoulder as he snaked an arm around to reach for the front of Mydei’s pants. He popped the button of his jeans open and pulled its zipper down.

“Sorry,” Phainon said, not sounding sorry at all. “But I can’t hold back any longer.”

Mydei made a strangled noise of protest as Phainon pushed his pants and his underwear down to his knees. But his protests soon turned into a moan as Phainon freed Mydei’s cock from the restraints of his clothing, his hand coming up to wrap around the base and begin a fast pace.

For someone who wanted to remain quiet, Mydei was doing a poor job of keeping face. His pants and his moans were loud enough to echo in the entryway of the suite, and Phainon knew he was just as audible on the other side of the door. Without faltering, Phainon used his other hand to take the hem of Mydei’s shirt. He lifted it up until it was right over Mydei’s lips.

“Bite it,” he urged. “You’re making too much noise.”

Mydei didn’t have the pride to fight back. Instead, he obeyed Phainon dutifully, his teeth sinking between the black fabric of his shirt as he continued to hum his praises of pleasure. It muffled his noises considerably, and Phainon decided that that was enough for now.

Phainon continued to slide his hand up and down Mydei’s shaft. From the way Mydei rutted against his hand, Phainon knew that it wouldn't be long before he reached his orgasm too.

So, not wanting to miss out on the action, Phainon quickly finished what Mydei had begun with his own pants. He clumsily pulled his own cock out, already hard and already leaking. Then, with one hand still gliding over Mydei, he used his other hand to begin touching himself too.

Mydei moaned a little louder when he felt the tip of Phainon’s cock against the swell of his bare ass. He attempted to look over his shoulder, but

Phainon pressed his body against his, trapping him from looking further.

“Give me a minute,” Phainon said. Despite being the one to direct their sex, he sounded just as winded and breathless.

Phainon began to move faster, his movements relentless as he rubbed Mydei and himself. By now, he didn’t know who was grinding more. All he knew was that both of them were gyrating their hips, both of them moving forward as they met Phainon’s hands inch by inch, thrust by thrust.

And as soon as Phainon felt his orgasm begin to arrive, he positioned his cock and slid it in the space between Mydei’s ass. After several more pumps of his hand, Phainon began to cum, white ropes of his seed tainting the entrance to Mydei’s hole and turning the skin there into a sticky mess.

The feeling of Phainon’s warmth upon him became Mydei’s own undoing as well. His hips stuttered, his cock twitched, and then Phainon felt Mydei cum, his release painting the base of the door with strings of white. Mydei threw his head back against Phainon, his mouth letting go of the shirt he was biting, as he closed his eyes and moaned through his orgasm.

Phainon pressed a kiss against Mydei’s temple as he felt Mydei coming down from his high. But if Mydei thought this was all that Phainon wanted to do, then he was sorely mistaken.

Even before Mydei relaxed fully in Phainon’s arms, Phainon was already moving. He angled his cock over Mydei’s entrance, both of them now wet and lubricated with Phainon’s cum.

Mydei’s eyes flew open and he straightened to look over his shoulder once more. “Wait.”

“Just one more,” Phainon pleaded. Still, he didn’t bother waiting for an answer as he slowly pushed himself inside of Mydei. “I need to feel you, just this once.”

Mydei words were unintelligible as Phainon continued to slide himself home. His hands struggled to find purchase against the flat surface of the

door, and his body trembled from the feeling of Phainon's girth invading and stretching his entrance.

Phainon cooed into Mydei's ear. He reached up, threaded his own fingers over Mydei's, and rested both of their hands over the door. "Relax," he whispered in his ear, once he was halfway inside of him. "I got you."

"Ha," Mydei gasped out once Phainon began to pull out. "It's too much."

Phainon smirked. "Thanks for the compliment."

Mydei clenched his jaw. "I wasn't talking about your size, you id—*ah.*"

Whatever curse he was set to bestow upon Phainon was lost as Phainon slammed himself back inside of him. Phainon felt Mydei's knees buckle from the impact, but he continued to hold Mydei up with his own body, never letting him fall, never letting him lose his foothold.

Phainon continued to thrust in and out of Mydei afterwards. Though it was only Mydei complaining from his heightened senses from his first orgasm, Phainon felt the same. Every time his cock slid against the walls inside of Mydei, Phainon could feel himself shudder just a little more from his own oversensitivity. He knew that it wouldn't take long before he was cumming again, but he did his best to hold out and stave off his orgasm until the end.

This time, however, Mydei came first. Phainon only knew he had come again because Mydei began to tremble beneath him. Phainon bit down against his shoulder, drawing another surprised cry from Mydei, before Phainon increased the strength and the speed of his thrusts further.

"Fuck," Mydei whined. "I'm still cumming."

Phainon only hummed and sank his teeth further into Mydei's shoulder. Then, after several more powerful thrusts, he slammed his hips forward and home and came inside of Mydei.

Neither of them pulled away for a long while after that. Even after Mydei had succeeded in making a sticky mess over the door, even after Phainon

had filled Mydei to the brim with his cum, and even after both of them had come down entirely from their high, they remained joined together.

It wasn't a problem, and it had never been one before. But as Phainon's lust abated and his thoughts began to slow, the memory of Mydei resting his head upon his shoulder rose unbidden to the forefront of his mind.

Phainon stiffened. And, because he did, Mydei did too.

"What?" Mydei asked. He moved his fingers until he had wiggled his way out of Phainon's own hands over him. "What's wrong?"

Phainon let him go. Then he began to pull himself out of Mydei, moaning in equal parts pleasure and pain, as he disentangled from him completely. Drops of cum fell upon them, both on their clothes and onto the floor, and he groaned at the mess they were making.

"Nothing," Phainon dismissed. Then, seeing as how Mydei was turning to face him, he flashed him a grin, erasing the thoughts from his face. "I was just thinking how loud you were."

Mydei moved away from the door, wincing in disgust at the moist patch of his own cum onto it. Then he gave Phainon's shoulder a soft punch. "I told you to do it someplace else instead."

Phainon snickered. "Consider this your first lesson then," he said, "on how to best feed the rumors."

A flash of emotion crossed Mydei's features, but it dissipated just as quickly as it came, there and gone again. Phainon didn't have time to decipher it entirely, even though he had a feeling that it was something particularly important to both of them.

"Then," Mydei said, brushing past him to begin cleaning himself up in the bathroom, "I look forward to every lesson after."

Phainon stared after his retreating back.

Lessons, he thought, as he followed after Mydei to wipe himself as well. *Lessons and arrangements and boundaries and rules.*

That’s all it was. Phainon knew that’s all it was ever going to be.

And, as Phainon watched Mydei now, he knew there was no point in wanting anything further than that.

Chapter End Notes

> i've been in some commercials before, so i know that cyrene's PR decision to keep feeding into the rumors is completely within the realm of possibility. i don't know if it's the wisest decision in reality, but thank God this is only a work of fiction, so let's run with it!
>
> also, i'm having the best time choosing the chapter titles for this fic. every song is chosen specifically because they reflect the chapter's story, and i've been enjoying going down memory lane and relistening to all the punk rock/pop rock songs of my youth.

crushcrushcrush [track 05]

Chapter Notes

track 05: *crushcrushcrush* by paramore

additional tags: phone sex

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Unlike the first stop of their tour, the remaining shows from here on out granted them little to no time to fully rehearse prior to the actual show. While their second concert was still tomorrow night and while they were set to pay a visit to the stadium before settling down at their hotel, neither the Flame-Chasers nor Mydei would get a chance to practice as extensively as they did before.

Still, Mydei didn't let that thought bother him too much. As long as he kept to his set list and as long as they were all on the same page when it came to the songs they were covering, everything should carry on smoothly.

However, Mydei quickly realized that Phainon had different plans of his own.

After they loaded all their bags and their remaining equipment onto the bus, each of them ready to embark to the next stop, Mydei reclaimed his usual seat by the back. He had barely settled into it when a familiar shadow loomed over him.

"Can I bother you for a second?" Phainon asked.

Mydei allowed himself the leniency of staring at him for several seconds. It was clear that Phainon had just come fresh from the shower, if his damp hair was anything to go by. He had his usual choker clasped around his neck, although it was hardly seen from the high cut of his blue hoodie's collar. The dark pants he had previously worn (and stained) had also been

replaced by a pair of skinny jeans, their tight material emphasizing the strong curves of his long legs.

Phainon tilted his head, no doubt wondering why Mydei had paused for so long. In response, Mydei cleared his throat. “You already are.”

The silver-haired man grinned. “Heh.” Without waiting for further permission, he slid into the empty seat beside Mydei. Then he flourished his phone and a set of wired earphones from his pocket and set them upon his lap.

“I was thinking we could change the song we’ll cover for our next show,” he started, plugging the earphones into his phone. “Well, not tomorrow’s show. The one after that.”

Mydei watched him scroll through his music app. “To what?”

Phainon continued scrolling through his list until he found the track he was looking for. He tapped the title on the screen. “Have you heard of this one?”

“Hmm.” Mydei peered at it. “I have, but I’m not entirely familiar with it.”

“That’s alright.” He placed one of the earphones into his ear and offered the other to Mydei. “Here, let’s listen to it together.”

“What happened to your Bluetooth earbuds?” Mydei asked, even as he took the wired version Phainon was offering to him and placed it inside his own ear.

“They ran out of battery,” he said dismissively. He tapped the song again, and the first beats of the drum began to echo in Mydei’s ear. “Anyway, let me know what you think.”

Mydei leaned back and let himself sink into his seat. As he listened to the song, the bus began to move forward, slowly at first as it pulled away from the parking lot and then a little faster as it exited onto a major road. Mydei watched the world outside his window pass him by, even as his own thoughts turned inward towards the song Phainon was making him listen to.

But even before the song drew to a close, Mydei had begun to express his approval of it with the way he bobbed his head in time to its beat. Phainon knew it too, because his smile was wide and triumphant by the time the lyrics tapered off into silence.

“Do you have the chords for this?” Mydei asked, once they had listened to it in its entirety.

“I do! I’ll send it to you right now.” Phainon picked up his phone and began tapping on it. As he did, the next song began, though neither of them made any move to disentangle the earphones from the other.

Mydei’s own phone lit up with Phainon’s forwarded message. As he opened the file to the music sheets, Phainon leaned in. “So is that a yes?”

“Why not?” Mydei continued to peruse the written chords. “It’s a good song to keep Cyrene’s plan in motion.” Then he turned to Phainon and pointed to his ear. “What about this one?”

“I hate this song,” Phainon answered. He pretended to snore. “Boring ass song.”

Mydei flashed him an affronted look. “I do like it.”

Phainon paused. Then he cleared his throat and adjusted the earphone in his ear. “I like it too.”

Mydei continued to frown at him.

“You know what?” Phainon said loudly. “You’re right. We should probably choose more romantic songs to sing from here on out. Help with the rumors and all.”

“Don’t put Cas and Anaxa through the ringer by changing up our set list entirely,” advised Mydei, even as Phainon continued to go through his playlists. “I don’t want to have to start from scratch either.”

“Fine, fine. We can choose the ones we’re all already familiar with then.”

“And we don’t have to make it *too* romantic.”

“Too late. We’re already in my ‘Rock Love Songs’ playlist.”

Mydei shook his head, already exasperated by the whole ordeal.

Still, they spent the next few hours in a similar manner, their bodies hunched together as they appraised each song they took turns suggesting. Phainon was in charge of playing the tracks and researching the music sheets, while Mydei busied himself cross-checking the list they already had and ultimately deciding whether they were going to keep a song or scrap it entirely.

And despite Phainon’s whims, he was extremely considerate when it came to choosing the songs. Most, if not all, of them were tracks Mydei or the Flame-Chasers had already covered before; if it wasn’t, then he made sure to pick one that wasn’t too difficult to play. By the time the bus entered the vicinity of their next stadium, they had a new setlist of songs to cover, a mix of titles they’ve already decided on beforehand with Castorice and Anaxa and titles they wanted to pitch to them for further approval.

The succeeding hours flew by just as quickly, if not faster. The technical team made sure to work with utmost efficiency, and their equipment was nearly ready by the time they climbed onto the stage for their rehearsals. Phainon and Mydei didn’t procrastinate either; they presented the new list to Castorice and Anaxa immediately, and the four of them discussed and bargained until they reached a unanimous decision on their final setlist. Then the Flame-Chasers went on ahead to begin their soundchecks, promptly followed by Mydei and his team.

But with the limited time they had on their hands and with the night fast approaching, they had to leave the stadium sooner than later. Before Mydei knew it, he was back on the bus, his joints protesting as he settled into his seat and resigned himself to another hour of traffic and travel back to their hotel.

And, just like earlier, Phainon approached him as soon as he sat down.

“What now?” Mydei asked, though his scowl didn’t quite reach his eyes.

Phainon leaned over his row. “Why? Is this seat occupied now?”

“No.”

“Then I’ll continue to sit here then!”

Mydei sighed as Phainon plopped down beside him. This time, however, Mydei didn’t bother to entertain him. He pulled out his phone, opened his notes app, and rested back against his seat. “As long as you don’t disturb me this time.”

“No promises,” Phainon grinned. His eyes fell on Mydei’s phone, and Mydei angled himself away consciously. It drew a surprised reaction on Phainon’s face, and his curiosity only grew with his smirk. “What are you doing?”

“Trying to write a song,” Mydei said simply, honestly. It’s not like he could deny it anyway.

“Already? You should focus on the tour first. You’ll have plenty of time to record a new album once this is over.”

“It *is* part of the tour.” Mydei glanced at him. “I’m planning to debut it as a new single at our final show.”

“Oh!” Phainon’s teasing look gave way to one of genuine excitement. “How’s it coming along?”

Mydei glanced back at his phone. All he had was the beginnings of a chorus and nothing more. Between meetings and rehearsals and actual concert shows, he had had little time to add anything else to it. “It’s alright.” He leaned away from Phainon, who had begun to take a peek again. “Stop trying to get a look. I’m not showing it to you.”

“What’s it about anyway?” he asked, his eyes wide with a silent plea to get a glimpse of the progress.

“I’m not telling you either.”

“Do you need me to help you write it?”

“No.”

Phainon let out an exaggerated sigh. He took out his wired earphones and his phone once more. “What a shame,” he pouted. “Feel free to bother me if you do get stuck, though!”

“I’ll think about it,” Mydei relented, hoping that would be enough to keep Phainon at bay.

And thankfully, it was. Phainon didn’t press the matter any further than that. In fact, he left Mydei alone completely, opting instead to turn to his phone and pull up the same series he had been watching the night before.

Mydei had been thinking of the beginning notes of his song, but he was distracted by Phainon’s intense fixation on his screen. He observed him discreetly from the corner of his eye, and he raised his brows questioningly when he caught Phainon clicking on the previous episode he had already finished.

That again? he almost found himself asking. The words were already there, right at the tip of his tongue, just waiting to be vocalized. *Didn’t you already watch that last night?*

But that was exactly why he held himself back from asking the question.

Mydei thought back to the previous night, to the way he had rested his head on Phainon’s shoulder. It had been a last minute decision, a moment of weakness and a careless gamble on his part. All he’d wanted was someone to lean on, someone who would let him forget his mistakes, even if it was just for a little while.

If he moves away, he had thought to himself, as he’d placed his temple and his cheek against the white leather of Phainon’s jacket, *then I’ll move too.*

But Phainon didn’t move. In fact, it felt like he was barely breathing, and Mydei almost had half a mind to pull away and apologize for another mistake on his part. Despite his loudness, Phainon had always been too nice. If he was uncomfortable with Mydei’s proximity, he wouldn’t say so until it was intolerable.

So Mydei had almost straightened. Had it not been for the way his phone caught Phainon’s reflection, he would have. Had the edge of his phone not mirrored the subtle shift of his gaze, he would have. Had the glass of his phone not reflected Phainon’s soft expression, his blue eyes averted from his own screen as he stared down at the top of Mydei’s head, he really, really would have.

Instead, Mydei had seen it all. And he knew, deep down, that Phainon was just as alright with it as Mydei was.

Well, Mydei realized now, dispelling the memory from his thoughts. *I guess that meant he hadn’t been paying attention to the episode he was watching at all.*

Mydei turned away. He had to. He couldn’t afford to let Phainon see the way his lips curved upward, a smile that spoke of multiple quiet realizations.

Oh, Phainon. Mydei went back to his notes app, already dim from idling by. *You have your heart on your sleeve far too much.*

Both of them carried on with their own tasks not long after that. After Mydei had successfully wiped all traces of his smile from his face, he went back to working on the song he was writing, drafting multiple verses and wondering which versions suited the vibe he was aiming for. Phainon continued to watch the series he was keeping up with, his attention so engrossed with every passing minute that he didn’t even realize how loud he was laughing at the punchlines at times.

But the ride between the stadium and the accommodations didn’t take too long, and after they got past the several blocks of traffic, they soon found themselves pulling into the last stretch of road that led them to their hotel.

Mydei set his phone down, his eyes transfixed on the pockets of groups milling in the parking lot. When he leaned closer to the window and squinted his eyes, he realized a large number of them were young women carrying signs that boasted their names.

“Well, well,” Phainon said amusedly. “I gotta say, this is a first.”

Mydei looked over his shoulder. Beside him, Phainon had packed away his phone and was leaning right into Mydei’s personal space to stare out the window too. Whether or not he realized how close he was to Mydei, Mydei couldn’t be sure. He was too busy grinning at the fans waiting outside.

“You don’t usually have fans stalking your hotel?” Mydei asked dubiously. He stared back out at the window as their bus slowed. Immediately, the group began to run towards their direction, their excited cheers seeping in through the closed windows.

“Not this many. Look!” Phainon reached out and pointed a finger. “They have fan signs of you too!”

Mydei followed his line of sight until he pinpointed the one Phainon was pertaining to. Written in block letters on an illustration board were the names *The Flame-Chasers* and *Mydei*, and surrounding them were little chibi versions of all the band members in question. Phainon and Mydei’s chibi selves were holding each other at the bottom of the signage, an attempt at recreating the moment Mydei had tripped on stage.

Despite the reminder of such an awful memory, Mydei found himself laughing quietly. “Cute,” he muttered beneath his breath. He glanced at Phainon. “They even drew our outfits correctly.”

But Phainon was already leaning back, putting several inches of space between them. He blinked at Mydei several times, his expression completely blank. “Do that again.”

Mydei’s mirth immediately evaporated. “What?” he demanded. “Laugh?”

“Yeah.”

Mydei snorted. “What’s wrong with you?”

The bus finally came to a stop in front of the hotel lobby, its wheels screeching to a slow halt. From out the window, Mydei saw the fans gather around the vehicle, clamoring for a chance to see them, before they were gently pushed back by their security team.

Cyrene and Aglaea made a quick announcement to everyone onboard, a reminder that it was fine to interact with the fans briefly, though it was strongly encouraged that they just keep carrying on. They waited on standby for several more minutes after that, and it was only when a hotel staff came up and boarded the bus to hand them their hotel key cards did everyone stand from their seats.

“Phainon and Mydei,” Cyrene said, after they had walked down the aisle towards where their managers were waiting with their keycards. Mydei lingered a few steps behind Phainon, his hands full with all the items he and Phainon had failed to pack away from their seats. “You’ll be on the same floor with Anaxa and Cas. They’ve already gone on ahead, so there’s no need to wait for them. Feel free to carry on to your rooms or briefly interact with the fans. Your assigned bodyguards will escort you the whole way.”

They were each given the keycards to their respective rooms. In front of Mydei, Phainon beamed. “You know, I wouldn’t mind sharing a room with Mydei next time.” He made the sign of a coin with his fingers. “Cut down on the costs and all.”

“I do,” Mydei interjected immediately. “I mind.”

Cyrene smiled coyly. “I’ll be sure to take both of your requests into consideration.”

Mydei shook his head. “Why are you like this?” he asked Phainon as they descended the steps from the bus.

“It was only a suggestion!” Phainon interjected.

Mydei highly doubted that. But he had to put their conversation to a pause once they exited the doors of their tour bus. Immediately, they were welcomed by the sight of fans on either side of them. They were all pressed behind a makeshift set of barricades, with several guards interspersed between them to reinforce their security.

Phainon and Mydei were immediately escorted by their own guards. They flanked both stars protectively, even as several women reached out for a chance to hold their hand or steal an autograph or hand a gift. Mydei was resigned to hurry onward; timid waves and small smiles were all he could afford to give to his fans. He hadn't quite recovered fully from his embarrassment just yet, and he had no intentions to stay any longer than he had to under the public scrutiny.

Phainon, however, had the complete opposite idea. His strides were confident, his smile charming, his waves cheerful. When they disembarked from the bus, he was positioned ahead of Mydei, leading the way and taking charge towards the entrance to the hotel. But in a matter of mere seconds, he had fallen far behind him as he lingered by to sign several posters and take selfies with some of the fans.

Mydei hesitated, his steps slowing. Beside him, his own bodyguard stopped. "Sir?"

"Let's wait for him," Mydei said, watching as Phainon complimented the woman with the chibi signboard. Though they weren't far apart in distance, Mydei couldn't glean what he was telling her. He only knew they were talking about him when Phainon pointed in his direction, and everyone in the vicinity turned their heads towards him.

"Sir," the bodyguard said again, taking a step closer to Mydei to shield him from their unwanted gazes. "With all due respect, it sometimes takes Mr. Phainon a while to wrap up his meet and greet sessions."

Mydei sighed. "Clearly."

Phainon gestured for Mydei to double back and meet him where he was at. And, after quickly weighing his options, Mydei indulged him.

“Mydei!” Phainon greeted, once they were within earshot of one another. “I was telling her that you found her drawings cute.”

Mydei clicked his tongue. “Why are you telling people the things I tell you in confidence?” To the fan, however, he offered the best rendition of his genuine smile. “But thank you. I did find it cute.”

There were practically tears in the fan’s eyes as she stared starry-eyed up at Mydei. She held out her signboard and a Sharpie. “Please, Mydei,” she begged. “Can you sign this?”

Mydei glanced at the signboard. It wasn’t only Phainon’s signature on it; even Anaxa and Castorice had left their own above the drawings of their chibi selves.

“Alright,” Mydei relented. With a small smile, he picked up the pen and wrote his own signature atop his chibi head. “Here.”

“Thank you!” the fan exclaimed, once Mydei handed it back to her. She stared at it, her eyes continuing to shine with unshed tears, before she hugged it to her chest.

“By the way,” she blurted out, just as Phainon and Mydei began to leave. Her eyes bounced back and forth between them before she puffed her cheeks. “The two of you are *so* cute together!”

Mydei stilled. Phainon, on the other hand, erupted into peals of laughter. “Thanks,” he said with a wink.

The fans erupted into a cacophony of shrieks, and Mydei decided that he had reached his limit for the day. With one last polite look towards the crowd, he reached for Phainon’s wrist.

“Let’s go,” he said, tugging him forward. “Time to call it a day.”

Phainon almost tripped on his feet. After all, his eyes were not on the path before them but on the place where Mydei had his fingers wrapped around Phainon.

Ah, shit.

Mydei tried to pull away, realizing his mistake almost immediately. But Phainon reached out to stop him, his posture straightening as he clasped a hand over Mydei's.

"Don't," he whispered. "Just keep holding my wrist." He let his other hand fall back to his side. "Like that."

"Isn't this too on the nose?" Mydei questioned, his voice just as low.

"We're not exactly holding hands." Phainon glanced at him. "But you *are* a quick learner. And here I was thinking I'd have to teach you the ropes."

It was Mydei's turn to stare at where he had his hand wrapped around Phainon's wrist. Though their fingers were far from intertwined, it sent enough of a message to everyone watching. "I wasn't trying to put on a show, though."

"Oh?" Phainon's eyes were undecipherable. "So you just wanted to hold me?"

They both cleared the hotel entrance at the same time, and Mydei had never been more relieved to trade the raucousness of the fans for the calming classical music of the pristine lobby. Still, he didn't let go of Phainon, not until they had rounded the corner and finally escaped away from the general public's eye.

Then, and only then, did he let Phainon go.

"Let's enjoy a good night's sleep," he said, refusing to answer the question and instead changing the topic as they waited for the elevators. Mydei gave him a pointed look, willing him to read between the lines. "I want to get enough rest before tomorrow's show. I don't want to embarrass myself in front of everyone again."

Phainon smiled. Mydei thought it looked too sweet to be genuine, but his words were sincere when he said, "Of course."

Mydei's gaze lingered on him for a few seconds before he finally looked away. Then they continued to wait in silence for the elevators to arrive. Once it did, they remained silent still, even as it continued to ascend into the floor of their rooms. And as they were quietly escorted into their designated floor and towards the doors of their rooms, it was only then that Phainon paused, his hand just a ghost over Mydei's lower back.

"If you change your mind," he said, uncaring that their bodyguards could hear every word. He gestured to the door in front of him. "You know where to find me."

Mydei couldn't help the blush that rose in full force over his cheeks. "Did you really have to say that now?" he demanded. He turned away, briskly walking to his door. "Go to sleep, Phainon."

From behind him, he heard Phainon chuckle. "Rest well too, Mydei!"

Without turning his head, Mydei flipped him off. And, as soon as he reached his own door, he murmured his thanks to his bodyguard, stepped into his room, and quickly closed the door behind him.

"Fuck." He leaned back against the door and sighed. He placed his keycard inside the room's cardholder, sighing again as he did so. "Finally some peace and quiet."

Mydei looked up, surveying his room in the process. It was smaller than the last one, with less extravagant furnishings and without access to a balcony of his own. There was a large desk by the corner, its accompanying leather chair, and a wide flatscreen TV upon one wall. On the other side of the place was a large queen-sized bed and a long couch with a low coffee table in front of it.

He approached this same coffee table now, already beginning to shrug off his jacket as he did so. He set it down atop its surface unceremoniously before going through the pockets of his pants. His phone came to rest beside it next, and then Mydei–

Mydei stopped, staring at the tangled earphones in his other hand. Earphones that were, undeniably, not his own.

He thought back to the bus ride, at his hurried attempt to clean up everything as they'd rushed to claim their keys from their managers. He had meant to return this set to Phainon once they had gotten down from the bus, but he'd forgotten about it at the sight of all the fans waiting for them.

Mydei sighed and gave the tangled pile a pitiful look. Phainon didn't even bother looking for it.

Before he realized what he was doing, he was dialing Phainon's number. He was beginning to undo the tangled mess Phainon's earphones had become when Phainon picked up his call.

"Yes?" came Phainon's easy response.

Mydei pressed his phone between his ear and his shoulder, freeing both hands to continue working at the mess. "You left your earphones with me."

"Oh! So that's where they went," Phainon mused. "I've been looking in all the pockets of my jacket this whole time."

"Well, they're here." Mydei finally finished untangling the wires. He began to loop it in a neat circle over his hand.

"Alright."

There was a pause on the other end of the line.

"But," Phainon finally said, "did you really have to call me to tell me that?"

Mydei's movements slowed to a stop. He stared at the earphones in his hands.

"It was faster than texting you," he said slowly. *Too* slowly. Even to his ears, he knew he was a second too late in his response.

There was the sound of leather creaking on Phainon's end. He was probably reclining back in the desk seat. "Is that so?" he challenged. "Here I thought you changed your mind."

Mydei placed the earphones back on his own table. He glanced at his bed, still pristine and untouched since his arrival.

"Who says I haven't?" he said. His voice was low and quiet.

Phainon drew in a breath. "Okay, I'll be there in a min–"

"No," Mydei cut in immediately. Before he could think better of it, he picked up Phainon's earphones again. He plugged it into his phone jack and placed the buds into his ears. Then he walked over to the side of his bed. "Stay there. Just–"

He sat at the edge of his mattress, the material springing and bouncing twice beneath his sudden weight. He stared at the phone in his hands, at the caller ID with Phainon's name in big block letters.

Just let me hear your voice.

Mydei closed his eyes with a wince. That's what he'd meant to say. That's what he'd successfully stopped himself from blurting out.

What the hell am I doing?

"Phainon," he tried again. He forced himself to sound as confident as he wanted to appear. "If you were here, what would you do?"

There was barely a sound on the other end of the line. Then he heard his voice, rough and low, "Do you really want to know?"

Mydei leaned back against his arm. With his other hand, he reached down and flicked the button of his pants open. "I'm not going to ask again."

Mydei pulled down the zipper of his pants. This time, he made sure it was loud enough to be heard over the phone.

Phainon sounded like his breath was trembling. But there was nothing shaky about his voice as he began to speak once more.

“I would lead you to your bed first,” he started. “Maybe I’ll ask you to sit on the edge. Maybe I’ll ask you to lean back on the pillows. You decide.”

The mattress creaked beneath his weight as he moved towards the other end of the bed. Once Mydei had settled onto it, his back leaning against the stack of pillows he propped up, he turned back to their conversation. “Then?”

“Then I’d crawl up to you. Push your legs open with mine, keep my arms right by yours.” Phainon hummed. “I’d probably wonder why you’ve already got your pants undone while we’re at it.”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Like you don’t know where this is going.”

Despite the situation, Phainon laughed. “Since you’re being such a smartass about this, I’d hold off on touching you down there then.” At once, his voice turned low and sultry. “So you should too.”

Mydei, who already had one hand slowly inching towards the top of his boxers, paused. He supposed this was his own fault anyway. “Fine.”

Mydei could imagine Phainon’s smirk as he started narrating again. “I’d pull up your shirt first, the same I did this morning. Except this time, I’d take it out all the way and I’d undress you right in front of me.”

As efficiently as he could, Mydei pulled out the earphones and pulled his shirt over his head. Then he tossed the clothing aside as he settled back against the headboard and resumed listening to Phainon with the earphones against his ear.

“I’d put my lips over your chest, my mouth taking one of your nipples. I’d take the other one between my fingers, pinching it just so until you make that sweet little gasp I love hearing.”

Mydei closed his eyes. He began to touch his breasts, one hand rolling a nipple between his fingers while one hand palmed the other. As predicted, it drew a surprised gasp out of him, made all the more pleasurable with his imagination that it was Phainon doing all this in his stead.

“There’s that sound,” whispered Phainon. On the other end, Mydei heard the sound of metal clinking and unbuckling.

“I’d stay there for a while,” Phainon carried on. “Maybe a minute or two, until you’re trembling beneath me. But as much as I love giving your chest the attention it deserves, I’d want what’s between your legs more.”

Mydei’s brows drew together as he pinched himself and moaned. It’s almost criminal how good Phainon was at describing these things.

“I’d slide a hand down from your chest, let my fingers draw a trail over the midline of your abs. Then I’d thank you for already undoing your pants as I lift your hips up and begin sliding them from your legs.”

Mydei stopped touching himself long enough to do as he was told. He lifted his hips up off the mattress, his thumbs hooking at the waistband of his pants as he slid them down and away. Once he kicked them away, he opened his eyes. He was embarrassed to find himself already hard and moist beneath the protection of his underwear.

“Staring at yourself?” Phainon guessed, as Mydei remained quiet. “I would be too.”

Mydei huffed. “Get on with it.”

Phainon snorted. “Can’t you hear how patient I’m trying to be for you? If it were up to me, I’d already be balls deep inside of you.”

“And I’d be ready.” Mydei pulled his own boxers down. He brought two fingers to his mouth, lathered a good layer of saliva over them, and reached down between himself. He didn’t bother concealing his moan as he began to press them inside his entrance, the stretch still easy considering that

Phainon had just been inside of him this morning. “I’d prepare myself for you, put two of my own fingers inside of myself while you watch.”

A strangled sound echoed from the other end, accompanied by the sounds of slickness and friction. “Mydei?” Phainon asked. “Am I really not allowed to go there tonight?”

“Not–*ha*–not tonight.” Mydei continued to slide his fingers in and out of his hole. “I’d prefer it if we used our imaginations this time.”

“Cruel. You’re a cold and heartless man, Mydeimos.”

Mydei snorted, just a short sound that ended as quickly as it came. It was replaced quickly by another low moan as he pressed on the edges of his prostate.

“Phainon,” Mydei said breathlessly. He took his fingers out long enough for him to spit on them. Then he was back inside, his two fingers turning into three as he scissored himself open. “I’d like you to continue with your narration now.”

When Phainon spoke next, he sounded far more winded than he had been mere seconds ago.

“I’d watch you open yourself for me,” he said. “But I’d lose control just as quickly, and I’d be sliding myself inside of you in no time.”

Mydei pulled out. Then he reenacted Phainon’s words, slamming his own fingers inside of himself until he was a moaning mess on his bed. He took his cock in his other hand, his fingers furiously rubbing up and down his shaft as he continued to finger himself.

“I’d thrust in and out of you, with reckless abandon and without consideration. I’d be too busy chasing after my own high, too busy drowning in the feeling of you, too caught up in how good you feel.”

Phainon and Mydei groaned at the same time. In the silence, all Mydei could hear were their shared gasps, their simultaneous masturbation, their

music of skin slapping their own skin.

“But I’d look at you,” Phainon said, his voice breaking, “and I’d watch your fucked-out expression, the one you love to make when you think I’m not looking.”

“Ha,” Mydei breathed. It was all he could afford to say. Besides, he had left his pride the moment he’d started this call.

“I’d begin moving faster.”

Mydei moved faster–both the fingers inside him and the hand over his cock.

“I’d begin moving rougher.”

Mydei moved rougher, his friction increasing until it was almost painful.

“I’d begin moving inside of you until the bed beneath us creaked.”

Mydei whimpered. What he wouldn’t give to hear that sound right now.

Phainon continued to pant. With the way he was fraying, he sounded like he was close. “And I’d–”

He let out a choked sob.

“Mydei,” he said urgently. “I want us to cum together.”

Mydei didn’t bother to think of a smart retort to that. “Are you close?” he asked instead, his question demanding. “Because I am.”

“More than you know,” Phainon replied.

Mydei’s hips began to stutter from the joint stimulation he brought upon himself. He squeezed his eyes shut, calling forth the best of his imagination, conjuring an image of Phainon moving over him, within him, on him. He pictured his white hair shining beneath the lowlights of the room, his blue eyes dark as it bore into him, his body gleaming with a thin layer of sweat.

“Phainon,” he whispered, yearning to reach up and cradle his face in his hands. “*Phainon.*”

“Mydei,” he said, his name like a prayer on his lips. “My dear Mydeimos.”

Mydei swallowed. He had never heard someone say his name with so much devotion.

With one more gasp, Phainon commanded, “Cum for me.”

Mydei nodded. Then, with a curl of his fingers over his prostate and one last stroke of his hand over his cock, Mydei came. He turned his head to the side, hoping that doing so could make him sound less whiny than he already was, but all it did was amplify his voice onto the microphone of the earphones. He felt the warm liquid of his cum all over himself as he gasped through every shudder that wrecked through him, and he had a fleeting thought that he wished he could feel Phainon’s own warmth inside of him, the same as it did earlier in the day.

By the time Mydei finished cumming, he realized that Phainon must have finished as well. On the other end of the line, he heard only the heavy pants of a man still trying to catch his breath, and Phainon sounded like he was busy sorting through his own post-nut clarity to speak first.

“Phainon,” Mydei said. He sounded winded too.

“Mydei,” he said at last. He took a deep breath and exhaled it with a tremble. “I’m really requesting for a shared room at our next stop.”

Mydei laughed. It was the second time he did so for the day, but he couldn’t help it. Phainon sounded far too ridiculous. “You can try.”

“Oh, I will. Don’t test me.”

Mydei shook his head. Then he stared at his hands, both soiled from all the things he’s done. “So.”

“So.”

Mydei rolled himself to a sitting position. It was about time he got into the shower anyway. “See you tomorrow.”

“See you tomorrow.” There was a brief pause before Phainon added, “I’ll try to keep my hands off of you before the show this time.”

“Sure.”

“Emphasis on try.”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Good night.”

He didn’t have to see him to know that Phainon was smiling. “Good night.”

And, by the time both of them hung up on the other and terminated the call, Mydei found himself smiling too.



Phainon, thankfully, made good on his promise not to bother Mydei before the show.

Although it wasn’t like he had a choice. This time, their dressing rooms were apart from one another, and Phainon couldn’t bother Mydei even if he wanted to. Between all their stylists, all the technical crew hovering over them, and all the last minute reminders their managers imposed on them, neither of them had the time to properly check on each other. Mydei could barely get his own thought in, his mind too busy running after everything that happened around him.

“There isn’t a riser for this stadium,” Aglaea explained to him. She stood beside a technician who was presenting Mydei with a printed copy of the area layout. “You’ll be coming up from the side of the stage, right as the fog machine blows smoke all over the place.”

“Got it,” Mydei murmured. He couldn’t turn to his manager, not when the make-up artist was busy drawing lines over his eyes with a red eyeliner. “Less wires on the floor, I assume?”

Aglaea snorted. “Seems like someone’s manner of speaking is beginning to rub off on you.”

Mydei cringed. Then he closed his eyes after his stylist instructed him to do so. “Ugh,” Mydei said. “Forget I said anything.”

Aglaea was quiet, though Mydei could still feel her presence lingering. After his make-up artist finished styling him and the technician handed him his own earpiece for the concert, Aglaea cleared her throat.

“I haven’t had the time to properly ask how you were doing,” she said. “For that, I apologize.”

“That’s alright,” Mydei said, leaning closer to the mirror as he assessed his make-up. It was a similar rendition to his previous show, though a layer of glitter sparkled at the edge of his eyes this time. “This is all part of the job. Both mine and yours.”

Aglaea watched his reflection fit the earpiece over himself. “You’re adjusting to the stardom quite well.”

“I have to.” Mydei met her eyes in the mirror. “I knew the risks and the rewards before I even signed the contract. This is just the manifestation of all those expectations.”

He leaned back in his seat. In his earpiece, the technical crew announced that they had fifteen minutes before the show began, and they advised Mydei to come up to the front to wait on standby.

“Although I have to admit,” he said, rising to his feet. He straightened the lapels of his black jacket, flipped his hair over his shoulder, and fingered the singular gold loop earring over his other ear. “I wasn’t expecting to fake a romance this early on in my career.”

Aglaea’s lips twitched as they left the dressing room side by side. “You don’t seem to mind it all too much, though.”

This time, Mydei kept his gaze straight ahead. “Don’t I?” he asked dully.

Their conversation tapered off to a close as the familiar thunder of the crowd seeped through the walls. Mydei forced himself to take deep breaths as he braced himself for his segment. The closer they walked towards the end of the corridor, the louder the cheers became, until it was difficult to even hear Aglaea speak.

“Break a leg,” she finally said, as several crew members began to hover over Mydei. “But be careful on the way down.”

Mydei strapped his electric guitar over himself. “Thanks.”

Aglaea nodded. Then she stepped back and allowed the crew to have their way with him. In a blink of an eye, his golden manager was there and gone, swallowed up by the small throng of people crowding around him to disappear into her own corner.

He risked one last sweep over the staff, trying to ascertain where she’d gone. Then he traded his search for gold with silver, wondering where the lead singer of the tour’s main band was.

Mydei stopped himself after that. He forced himself to look away, to pay attention to the final instructions from the technicians and to put all thoughts of Phainon out of his mind and out of his sight. This was no time to be distracted after all.

The people around him continued to hover until they all fell away, one after another. In the end, and with only five minutes left until he was set to perform, he was left with only one companion, a man with a clipboard who was busy talking in his own earpiece. Mydei stood beside him dutifully, waiting for his cue to be sent onto the stage.

For some reason, he didn’t feel as nervous as he did. Even with the ghost of his mistake looming over him, he felt more at ease.

Mydei flicked his fingers over the strings of his guitar. Perhaps it was because the worst had already happened, he presumed. And, even with that, their teams had banded together to get them through it. Surely, any mistakes

onward–though Mydei hoped there would be no more errors on his part–would be dealt with in a similar manner.

“Sir,” the crewman said now, drawing Mydei out of his reverie. He pointed to the lights, which steadily dimmed. It was inversely proportional to the noise that rose from it, and the man had to lean into Mydei’s ear to say, “That’s your cue!”

Mydei nodded. Then, guided by the limited light at his feet, he began to scale the steps and walk onto the platform.

The crowd caught his silhouette immediately, and the screams only grew.

Mydei swallowed. *Inhale.*

He stepped up to the mic stand. He knelt down and picked up one of the wires, the one that would connect his guitar to the speakers. Once he had that all set up, he gave an experimental strum.

The notes ricocheted off of the closed walls, and the atmosphere was immediately electrifying. *Exhale.*

Mydei closed his eyes. “Alright,” he said into the mic. Behind him, the rest of his team settled over their designated instruments, each of them carrying up the task to play the drums, the bass, the keyboard. “Let’s take this from the top.”

Mydei gave one more powerful stroke over his guitar, this one louder and more pronounced than the last. At the same time, all the lights came on, and the rest of the music started up into play. The beginnings of Mydei’s first song began, and he pulled one more riff from his guitar before he began to sing.

It was the same kind of magic as his first time. Mydei was predicting that he would be a little more reserved, a little more afraid to let himself loose after the other night. But it was like another force had taken over him once more, guiding his voice and his hands and his body to be the best version of himself in front of everyone now.

And as one song blended into the next, as one track melded to the other, Mydei carried on with the same kind of fever rush he had before. By the midpoint of the setlist, his sweat was raining down onto the stage and onto his boots. And by the end, he was covered head to toe with a layer of it, the humidity of the place making his clothes stick to him far more than he anticipated.

He didn't care though. All he cared about was how he sang and played to his heart's content, and all he cared about was how the crowd sang and cheered back to him with just as much passion. Right until the end, right until his last original song bled out from the speakers, he remained on fire, his soul alight with the adrenaline rush of performing before thousands of people.

These same people chanted his name in perfect synchrony now, their voices rising as one roar as they called out for him. "*Mydei! Mydei!*" they called. "*One more song! Mydei! Mydei!*"

Mydei lifted his chin up. And maybe Aglaea *was* right about one thing this time. Maybe a certain someone's manner of speech was beginning to rub off on him.

"Alright, alright," he said into the mic, his crooked grin aimed at the people all staring down at him. He even laughed a little; he was living too far in the moment to care anyway. "I hear you all, loud and clear."

Mydei cradled his crimson guitar.

"So before I go," Mydei started, already beginning to strum on his electric guitar, "I'll share one more song with all of you."

Similar to their last concert, the stage went dark. But whereas last time's transition came in chunks of darkness, this time it was a gradual dimming of the lights until it was only Mydei that was under the spotlight.

The crowd was ecstatic, their cries rising in excitement as Mydei continued to play the intro to the song they'll be covering.

Mydei breathed out into the mic. “Hopefully,” he said, “there’ll be less falls for me this time.”

Everyone erupted into coos and cheers, understanding full well what Mydei meant.

He took that as his cue. He strummed on his guitar once, twice, his cue for Castorice to join in. Cas, who had taken her place by the drums, understood completely. She slid smoothly into the song as she pounded on the drums at the same time the lights all went back on.

“Let’s go!” Mydei yelled into the mic. Then he entered into the song, singing the beginning parts of the first verse immediately.

“*I got a lot to say to you,*” he began. “*Yeah, I got a lot to say.*”

From somewhere in the stage came another voice. Though the audience still couldn’t pinpoint where he was, they all knew who was singing, and they screamed with their shared recognition.

“*I noticed your eyes are always glued to me,*” Phainon sang, “*Keeping them here and it makes no sense at all.*”

At once, the stage was plunged into darkness once more. Save for where Mydei stood, the whole place was once again bathed in shadow as he started the pre-chorus.

“*They taped over your mouth, scribbled out the truth with their lies.*”

Mydei pointed his finger towards the side of the stage, drawing everyone’s attention to that spot.

“*Your little spies.*”

Then he was shrouded in darkness, the spotlight transferring directly to the spot he had directed everyone to look. The light revealed Phainon, one leg resting on the step higher than him and his blue guitar draped over his body. He was holding a microphone in his hand as he filled in the next part.

“*They taped over your mouth, scribbled out the truth with their lies. Your little spies.*”

Mydei was lit up once more as he entered with a guitar solo. But as Phainon began to walk into the center of the stage, the lights began to blink all around them, interspersing them between light and shadow.

Mydei gave one long strum before letting Castorice and Anaxa take over the bass with their instruments.

“*Crush,*” Phainon whispered to his mic, moving closer to stand before the stand already set for him.

“*Crush,*” Mydei whispered back, strumming again.

“*Crush,*” Phainon said. This time, he began jumping on his feet, hyping the crowd to join him. “*Crush, crush.*”

“*Two, three, four!*” Mydei yelled.

Then all the lights went back home, and both Phainon and Mydei began to play on their own guitars, even as they continued to sing together.

“*Nothing compares to a quiet evening alone.*” Phainon was still jumping on two feet.

“*Just the one, two, I was just counting on.*” Mydei flipped the hair back from his eyes, his sweat spraying onto the surface of his guitar.

“*That never happens, I guess I’m dreaming again.*”

“*Let’s be more than—*” With a glance at Phainon’s direction, Mydei sighed. “This.”

The whole stadium screamed as Mydei and the Flame-Chasers entered the instrumental part of their song. Mydei snuck a glance at everyone, thrilled to find that even Castorice and Anaxa were giving it their all, their bodies working overtime as they surrendered to the rhythm.

The four of them continued to play out the song, vocals and instruments blending as they built back a popular track with their own version. Phainon was the same superstar he'd always been, knowing when to draw close to Mydei to garner the audience's glee, and knowing when to turn to them to continue hyping them up.

Mydei took a page out of his own playbook, goading Phainon to come closer to where he stood as he encouraged the audience to sing along with them. And by the time they had finished the second verse and were on the last parts of the second chorus, he and Phainon were practically back-to-back against one another.

"*That never happens,*" Mydei sang now, as he looked over his shoulder at Phainon. "*I guess I'm dreaming again.*"

"*Let's be more than—*" Phainon stopped singing to shout the next part to the crowd. "This now!"

They pulled apart from one another. Mydei began to strum the beginnings of the bridge on his guitar as Castorice took control of setting up the beat with the bass drum. Phainon, meanwhile, let his mic stand go and brought his hands up over his head to clap alongside the beat. Once the crowd had all caught on and was clapping as one, he gestured an arm out to point in Mydei's direction.

Mydei strummed the same chords over once more before leaning back over his mic to sing once more.

"*Rock and roll, baby,*" he started, his rhythm never once faltering over his electric guitar, as Castorice and Anaxa retook their control over the drums and the bass guitar. He glanced at Phainon. "*Don't you know that we're all alone now? I need something to sing about.*"

Phainon grabbed his mic and leaned over it, singing the next lyrics in time to Castorice's playing over the cymbals. "*Rock and roll, hey! Don't you know, baby, we're all alone now?*"

He looked at Mydei from beneath his lashes. “*I need something to sing about.*”

Mydei took a step closer, grabbing his mic with him as he did so. This time, they sang the last repeat of the bridge together, both of them leaning close to one another.

“*Rock and roll, hey! Don’t you know, baby, we’re all alone now?*”

Phainon pursed his lips in silence as Mydei belted the last line.

“*Give me something to sing about!*”

“Alright,” Phainon grinned, winking at him as the drums rose to a crescendo.

Mydei raised a brow at him, even as he continued to sing and strum his guitar. “*But nothing compares to a quiet evening alone.*”

Phainon took a step closer. “*Just the one, two, I was just counting on.*”

Mydei closed the gap between them with another step. “*That never happens, I guess I’m dreaming again.*”

Phainon reached forward. He grabbed Mydei’s waist and tugged him towards him, their guitars clanking together as they collided. “*Let’s be more than–*”

Mydei’s eyes widened. He brought a hand over Phainon’s lips, singing the next part and realizing how fitting it was for their predicament. “*No!*”

Phainon let him go, and both of them took a step back from one another. Though Mydei was surprised by the sudden intimacy, they carried on singing in unison without missing a beat.

“*Nothing compares to a quiet evening alone.*”

Though Mydei was looking at Phainon now, he thought back to last night, to the quiet solitude he enjoyed alone in his room.

“*Just the one, two, I was just counting on.*”

Though Phainon had taken another step closer, Mydei remained still as thought back to how easily he had phoned Phainon without a second thought, uncaring how it came across.

“*That never happens, I guess I’m dreaming again.*”

Though neither of them made any more move to become closer, Mydei thought back to the way it unraveled so quickly, the evening neither quiet nor lonely any longer.

Phainon looked at him. He took the last step that would bring him within arm’s reach again. This time, he cupped Mydei’s cheek, his eyes bright as he sang the next part. “*Let’s be more than–*”

And Mydei didn’t know what came over him. Maybe it was because they were tasked to act or maybe it was because of last night’s weakness or maybe it was because Phainon was holding him in such a gentle manner. But Mydei tilted his head into Phainon’s hand, nuzzling against his open palm as he placed a hand over his.

“*More than this,*” he sang back, finishing the next part of the lyrics and forgetting his guitar solo completely.

“*Oh,*” Phainon intoned.

Mydei swallowed. Then, coming back to himself, he continued playing the electric guitar, picking up right where he left off. He looked away, focusing on his instrument instead, even as Phainon continued to hum into his mic.

Castorice let her arms down, slamming them one, two, three more times. On the final time, Mydei gave one last stroke over his guitar.

Then the song was over, his part of the show was done, and the crowd began to erupt into total chaos.

Mydei was breathless, his chest rising and falling in deep pants, as he beheld the crowd going wild. He drank up all their voices, humbled to hear

his name alongside the Flame-Chasers as the sea of people chanted their praise. With the lights on and all the camera flashes going off in different bursts, he realized that this was his first *successful* performance at the tour.

With one more exhale, he grinned up at the world and raised his arm out in the air.

Beside him, Phainon was smiling just as brightly. “Everyone!” he yelled into his mic. Once again, he gestured an arm out towards his direction. “Give it up once more for our opening act for this tour, Mydei!”

Mydei turned to Phainon, still smiling. But his smile faltered, just briefly, just a little, as he thought back to their lyrical performance.

Let’s be more than this.

Though Phainon remained beaming, he tilted his head ever so slightly, a quiet question as he caught on to Mydei’s shifting thoughts.

But Mydei was spared from having to further explain himself as he heard his cue to exit from his earpiece. He turned back to the crowd, waving at them one last time, before he exited the stage with his crimson guitar still strapped over him.

No, he thought to himself, a similar response as the one he had sung earlier to Phainon. He descended the steps and immediately returned backstage, where he was quickly escorted away from the public eye.

It was just a performance, after all. A very heated, very intimate performance, but a show nonetheless.

Mydei would not–could not–afford to mistake it for anything more than that. He knew that if he did, it would be a far greater error than the one he had made on the first night.

And he knew that, if he did, it would be the last mistake he’ll ever make.

Chapter End Notes

the song phainon called boring at the beginning of this chapter was *all i wanted* by paramore. just thought you all should know. (i disagree with his opinion completely.) as for the first song they shared and listened to, it's *right girl* by the maine. both songs are currently in the fic playlist!

anyway, here are the videos i heavily took inspiration for this chapter's *crushcrushcrush* cover: paramore's live performance • drum cover (loved the part where she was clapping to hype the "crowd" at 2:02) • guitar cover (FAVE) • bass cover

right girl [track 06]

Chapter Notes

track 06: *right girl* by the maine

additional tags: anal sex (hehe)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon didn’t get a chance to talk to Mydei until much, much later.

Their second show was a resounding success, finally without mishaps and complete with a perfect encore. Phainon was thrilled, and he was on cloud nine from the moment he hopped off the stage and exited towards their bus.

But he had been too busy rehashing his favorite moments of the show with Anaxa and Castorice to properly find Mydei. By the time he had thought to congratulate him for his outstanding performance, they were already back at their hotel.

And, like a cat slinking away, Mydei disappeared as soon as they reached the hotel lobby.

Phainon had wanted to follow him, to find him the same way he did the other night. He didn’t think that Mydei had anything to be ashamed of during his segment, but he wanted to check in with him just to be sure.

Still, he had to delay his plans of looking for him when Castorice invited her bandmates to go on a quick run with her to the convenience store nearby. Phainon–and, surprisingly, even Anaxa–took her up on the offer. But as Phainon quickly changed into a more comfortable set of clothes, briefly wiping his sweat with a towel before donning on the first shirt he pulled from his luggage, his attention lingered distractedly on Mydei. Before he knew it, he was crafting him a text and shooting him a message.

< Phainon: you were perfect tonight [10:54PM]
< Phainon: also we're going to the convenience store [10:54PM]
< Phainon: if u wanna come with [10:55PM]

Phainon set his phone down to throw on an old pair of pants. Once he was done and ready, he grabbed his keycard, his wallet, and his phone. Then he exited his room, checking his phone for Mydei's reply as he made his way back to the hotel lobby.

> Mydei: Thanks. [11:00PM]
> Mydei: But I'll pass for now. [11:00PM]

"Alright," Phainon murmured to himself, typing the same thing and sending it over to Mydei. At least Mydei was responding, he thought. He was just probably tired from the events of the day.

Maybe later, Phainon promised, he could knock on his room and check up on him.

In the meantime, he resolved to put all thoughts of him out of his mind as he met with Castorice and Anaxa by the exit of the lobby.

"What," Anaxa immediately began, frowning at Phainon from head to toe, "are you wearing?"

Phainon glanced down at himself. He'd been so distracted that he didn't even bother checking what he was grabbing from his bag. He found himself wearing a polka dotted yellow shirt a size too big on him and a faded pair of lilac sweatpants that he'd been meaning to throw into the washer.

"Why? Is it bad?" Phainon glanced up at them. Apart from the glaring color choices that could attract potential fans towards them, he didn't think it was too dismal of a choice. He pointed at Anaxa. "I could ask you the same though!"

Anaxa scowled. He wore the same black jeans as he did from the show, though this time he wore a light green hoodie instead of the black shirt he'd worn earlier. He had the hood over his head now, revealing the triangular

floppy ears attached towards the top. Diamond-like patterns were also etched by his ears, giving the illusion of animal scales. “It’s subtle enough that it’s passable.”

“You’re both laughable,” Castorice intervened. Among the three of them, she was the only one well suited to make such a remark. She wore a dark violet shirt over a pair of denim shorts, plain and unassuming enough. “Did you want to attract the paparazzi to us?”

The three of them cleared the doors of the exit. Out in the night, the sidewalk was quiet and the air breezy but humid. The three of them walked side by side as they crossed the street to the convenience store.

“Relax,” Phainon reassured her. “It’s not like we’ll be recognized by anyone at this hour.”

“They might not recognize us if you’d worn something subtle,” Castorice said. “They surely will now.”

“We’re not staying long anyway.” Despite his earlier confidence, Phainon ducked his head, slumping his shoulders into his chest as if he could make himself smaller. “We’ll grab our snacks and go.”

Thankfully, Phainon’s hypothesis had been a correct one. Apart from the lone cashier—who immediately gaped at their wardrobe choices before recognizing them and politely asking for a picture—they had the convenience store all to themselves. The three of them all purchased the same bowl of instant ramen noodles, a cool drink of their choice, and a chosen pastry for the road. Seeing as no one nearby was running to come to them, they decided to heat their noodles then and there and eat it in one of the tables by the glass windows.

Neither of them spoke for a few minutes as they blew on their noodles and slurped through their first bites. Phainon glanced at his friends, knowing they must have been as hungry as he felt after all the adrenaline from the show. Then he looked down at his own bowl, wondering if Mydei was hungry too, and made a mental note to buy him something before they left.

“What time are we leaving tomorrow?” Castorice asked, once all three of them were less famished and more willing to strike a conversation. Her cheeks were round as she used her teeth to cut a bite of noodles. “Tomorrow night’s already our next show, right? That means we’ll go straight to the stadium to rehearse and remain there until the show ends.”

Anaxa, who had his phone in his hand as he ate, scrolled through their group chat with their manager. “Cyrene said the bus leaves at eight. We aren’t too far from the next destination, but she wants to get there earlier rather than later.”

“That’s fair,” Phainon said, continuing to eat. “I want us to do a runthrough of the song we’ll be covering. And I want to practice it at least twice for my peace of mind.”

Anaxa raised a brow. “Whose brilliant idea was it to change our list at the very last minute?” He shook his head. “If it weren’t for Mydei, I would have said no to your suggestion.”

Phainon, who had noodles already halfway to his mouth, paused to ask. “Why? What about Mydei?”

“He’s just so sincere about everything,” Castorice said, answering in Anaxa’s place. “It’s quite difficult to say no to him. Seeing how he had put in the effort to run with your impulsivity, we might as well go with it too.”

“Wow.” Phainon chewed through the rest of the food in his mouth before swallowing. “Here I thought I was still number one in your hearts.”

“Don’t start,” Anaxa said. “You’re just as fond of him as we are.”

“Well, actually,” Phainon corrected, “I’m more fond of him than either of you are to him.”

“How is this a competition?”

Castorice leaned back as she chugged from her bottle of juice. “But speaking of Mydei,” she started, twisting the cap back over the plastic in

her hand, “how has he been holding up with…everything?”

Phainon shrugged. “I have the same question for him actually. He looks like he’s adapting quite well to all that’s happened so far. But sometimes, it’s hard to tell with him.”

Castorice nodded. She flourished her phone and typed something on it.

“I have to admit, though,” she said, showing her screen. It was a new post from someone online, a clip of their earlier performance from the moment Phainon reached out and pulled Mydei close against him. Though the volume was muted, Phainon could guess how loud the fans must have been based on the way they were pumping their hands in the air. “He knows how to ride with whatever show you put up for the audience.”

Phainon looked away, smiling down at his bowl. “He does.”

“Unless, of course, there’s a ring of truth in your ‘performances’ somewhere.”

Phainon immediately snapped his head up. “That’s ridiculous,” he said. “Mydei and I both agreed that we can’t let actual feelings get in the way of all this.”

“How professional,” Anaxa said. Phainon couldn’t tell whether he was being sarcastic or not.

“We are,” he agreed instead. He looked at the clip still playing on Castorice’s phone. Then he grinned smugly. “Though you’re right: I’m glad we both know how to put on a show.”

Castorice’s gaze was sharp. “Hmm.” She continued to stare at him, as if she was picking him apart from the inside out. Then she resumed eating her noodles once more with a sigh. “Just be careful not to overdo it. The audience can lose interest quickly once they suspect this is all just propaganda for our sales.”

Phainon waved a hand to dispel her thoughts. “Of course. You don’t need to worry about that.”

The trio carried on the rest of their meal in a similar fashion, their topics ranging from evaluating their performances to laughing at another meme Cas showed them to discussing the next few days of their tour.

In the end, the convenience store run Castorice had meant to be quick turned into an hour. By the time they finished their snacks and by the time Phainon doubled back to buy Mydei a slice of strawberry cake and by the time they were finally back at their hotel, it was well past midnight.

After exchanging their farewells, the three of them parted at their hotel floor. Castorice and Anaxa headed to their respective rooms immediately, both of them already ready to call it a night. But Phainon lingered a little more, flourishing his phone to text Mydei as he held his cake in one hand.

< Phainon: u awake? can u open ur door [12:26AM]
< Phainon: i got u a snack [12:26AM]

Phainon stood in front of Mydei’s door, shifting his weight from one foot to another as he waited. He was just about to wonder whether Mydei was already asleep when he received his response.

> Mydei: I’m not in my room. [12:27AM]

Phainon frowned.

< Phainon: where r u then [12:27AM]
> Mydei: The poolside. [12:27AM]

“The pool?” Phainon repeated in confusion. He turned on his heel, letting his feet lead him back to his own room.

< Phainon: can i join u [12:28AM]
< Phainon: ill bring the cake too [12:29AM]
> Mydei: Sure. [12:29AM]

Phainon tapped his phone against his thigh, considering. Then he threw his doubts aside, exchanging it to go back to his room instead and quickly change into a pair of swimming shorts. This time, he brought with him a roll of towel, his cake, his keycard, and his phone, and he texted Mydei a heads up as he entered the elevator.

< Phainon: going there [12:38AM]

Mydei offered no reply after that. Not that he had to anyway. In no time, Phainon reached the poolside floor, and he pushed the door open that lead him outside to Mydei.

Deep in the night and with no one else awake but the both of them, Mydei sat by the edge of the pool. He had both his feet in the water, with his sweatpants rolled up all the way to his knees to keep them from getting soaked. He had his head down and averted towards the phone in his hand, but he looked up at Phainon's entrance.

"Why are you never in your room after a show?" Phainon asked him, once he was by the sunloungers.

"Why are you looking for me in the first place?" asked Mydei.

"Am I not allowed to?" Phainon placed his belongings, including Mydei's cake, beside Mydei's. Then he took a seat, leaning against one arm and crossing his legs by the ankles as he did so. He peered down at Mydei. "Besides, I just wanted to congratulate you for a successful show!"

"You already did." Mydei held up his phone for emphasis. "Through text."

"I wanted to tell you in person too! We were amazing back there."

Mydei looked away. It was hard to determine the truth in the dark, but Phainon liked to believe that it was a ghost of a smile that he saw on Mydei's face. "We were."

Phainon leaned closer. "So what's bothering you then?"

Mydei looked up at him again. "Nothing."

“Says the man who’s here at one in the morning.” Phainon straightened and squinted at the signboards around them, trying to decipher the pool hours written on them. “I don’t think the pool is even open at this time.”

“No one stopped me.”

“Because no one else is here.” Phainon looked back at Mydei, glimpsing the contents of his phone for the first time. There was a video of a guitar cover taking up the whole screen, though it was put on pause for now. He glanced at Mydei. “Are you nervous about tomorrow’s cover?”

Mydei shook his head. He closed his phone and set it aside. “Not really.” He leaned back on his hands. “It’s fairly easy to play on the guitar.”

“Hmm.” Phainon squinted at him, still not quite believing that everything was fine. He nodded to the pool, at the lights that streamed from its walls and its floor. “Maybe a dip will wash your worries away.”

Mydei kicked his legs, breaking the still illusion of the water’s surface. “It’s late, Phainon.”

Phainon stared at the gentle waves, entranced. Then, with the resolve of a man with nothing to lose, he rose to his feet and began pulling his shirt over his head.

“Are you serious?” Mydei gaped at him as Phainon tossed his shirt onto the sunlounge. As he shrugged free from his sweatpants, revealing his swimming shorts hiding right beneath, Mydei’s shock turned to horror. “You can’t be serious.”

“Like you said,” Phainon said, making his way to the edge of the pool. He grinned. “No one’s stopping me.”

With that, Phainon let himself fall into the water. He made sure to do it as quietly as possible, though his body still made a slight splash as he fell into its depths. He immediately swam back to the surface, still grinning as he wiped away the droplets of water from his eyes. He held a hand out to Mydei. “Come.”

Mydei shook his head. “No, thanks.” He withdrew his legs from the pool to reinforce his answer.

“Why?” Phainon ran his fingers through his hair before shaking the water from them. As he did, a shiver ran through him, his body finally feeling the full force of the pool’s coldness. “Scared the water’s temperature isn’t for you?”

“No.”

“Maybe your skin’s just a little sensitive then.” Phainon laid down on his back, willing himself to be weightless as he floated. His teeth were beginning to chatter lightly, so he moved his arms and his legs to generate heat. “That’s okay. I understand not everyone can withstand the cold.”

“The water isn’t cold.”

“Only sore losers say that.”

“It’s really not–” Mydei huffed. He rubbed his hands over his face before he pushed himself to his feet. “Fine. *Fine.*”

Phainon gathered some of the pool water in his mouth before blowing it out in a makeshift fountain over himself. “Yay.”

Mydei continued to curse Phainon under his breath, even as he began to strip himself down. Phainon continued to float above the water, though he kept his gaze locked on Mydei, watching as he pulled down his pants first and then pulled his shirt over his head next. The reflected lights from the pool cast a bluish hue over his skin, making his tattoos glow almost as if they truly were lit from within.

Phainon gave him a once-over. Then, as Mydei stepped up to the edge of the pool, he gave him another look from head to toe.

“Where’s your swimming shorts?” asked Phainon, finally bringing himself back to his feet. He pointed towards Mydei’s waist. His fingers were

beginning to tremble. “You’re seriously going to jump in with only your boxers?”

Mydei crossed his arms over his chest. “I wasn’t actually planning to swim, you fool.”

“Well, it’s too late to go back now.” He held his arms out. “Jump in the water, Mydei!”

Mydei cursed him once more, his voice too low to be heard clearly. He took a seat by the edge, dipping his legs in first. Then, with one last push towards the concrete, he let himself fall into the water.

Phainon paddled over to him, his grin the widest it’s ever been. As soon as Mydei resurfaced, he pushed back the hair from his eyes and glared at Phainon. “See. It’s not cold at all.”

Phainon positioned himself so that he was sitting by the ledge of the pool. His body was still submerged, but his waist and his legs were finally resting in a seated position against the cold tiles. “Now you’re just lying.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Maybe *you’re* the sensitive one.” He appraised Phainon more closely before realization dawned on his face. “You’re shivering.”

Phainon crossed his arms over his chest in disapproval. It most definitely, most certainly had nothing to do with how cold he actually felt. “The dark is playing tricks on your eyes.”

“Really now?” Mydei quietly swam over to where Phainon was. “I’m completely fine.”

“So am I!” Phainon lied, even as he continued to shiver.

Mydei finally reached him. He stood in front of Phainon for several passing moments, his gold eyes dark in the night.

Then, in the most surprising turn of events Phainon had ever known, Mydei rested his hands on Phainon’s shoulders, pulled himself up, and straddled

him.

“If you want warmth,” Mydei said, letting the buoyancy of the water bring him close and flush against Phainon as his legs settled on either side of him, “just say so.”

Phainon’s brain short circuited completely. Nothing–no thought, no emotion, no action–streamed into his mind. Nothing else was processing except for the fact that Mydei was now on his lap, his legs hooking by Phainon’s sides and his arms gently holding his shoulders down. Everything that Phainon did–unfold his own arms, place his hands by Mydei’s waist, stare up into his golden gaze–was completely done out of muscle memory and intuition.

“Uhm,” Phainon finally managed to stammer out. Down below, he could feel himself growing hard. “This isn’t what I expected.”

Mydei must have interpreted it completely incorrectly. His questioning expression immediately darkened and he let Phainon go. “Ah,” he said. He was already leaning back. “Then let me just–”

“No!” Phainon yelled immediately. His hands grabbed Mydei’s wrists, and he directed them back to hold him against his shoulders. Then he wrapped his arms around Mydei again, one hand coming to rest against his lower back while the other cradled the space between his scapulae.

“I didn’t say it was a bad thing!” he rushed to explain. “In fact, this is great! Way better than I expected!”

In this position, Mydei was almost a full head taller than Phainon. He scowled down at him now, his cheeks dark with his blush. “Start with that next time.”

“Why?” Phainon rested his chin between the valley of Mydei’s breasts. Then, with his mind now functioning at full capacity once more, he smirked up at him. “Was your pride wounded at my rejection?”

“You *just* said it wasn’t a rejection.”

“Heh,” Phainon laughed. “You’re cute when you’re sulking. But don’t worry.”

Phainon pulled away from Mydei. He reached up and cupped his face in his hands. “I could never reject you.” He squeezed his cheeks together for emphasis, pushing them close until Mydei’s lips were pouted like a fish.

Mydei’s brows drew together. “Let me go,” he tried to say. Except, with Phainon squeezing his face, it sounded a lot more like, “Wet we wo.”

“So cute,” Phainon murmured. “But no.”

He wrapped his arms around Mydei once more. This time, when he placed a hand against his lower back, he made sure to push Mydei forward until there was hardly any space between them. In this manner, the evidence of both their arousals were touching one another, impossible to deny and impossible to ignore.

“Finish what you started with me,” Phainon said. He bucked his hips forward and upward, letting both of their clothed erections rub against one another. “Take responsibility.”

Mydei clenched his jaw, grunting as Phainon continued to grind against him. “That’s exactly what I was doing before you gave me mixed signals.”

“What do you m—?” Phainon started, though whatever he was about to say was lost on him as Mydei placed his hand over Phainon’s cock.

“Be quiet,” he urged. His fingers traveled to the waistband of Phainon’s swimming trunks before pulling it back slowly. Another shiver wracked through Phainon as his bare cock was exposed to the water, its cold temperature making him feel even chillier than he already felt. “We don’t want to wake the other guests up.”

Phainon clamped his mouth shut immediately. With a lingering look on Mydei’s face, he casted his eyes downward. Mydei already had his attention there as he rolled down his boxers until enough of his ass and his erection was just as exposed.

Mydei lifted his hips off of Phainon's lap momentarily. The still water around them broke in gentle waves with the singular movement, and the water continued to move as Mydei reached for Phainon's cock. He pulled himself as close as he could against him, their bare chests and torsos rubbing one another. Then, with his head angled towards his backside, Mydei positioned the tip of Phainon over himself and began to slide down.

Phainon felt the moment his shaft breached Mydei's entrance, and they both gasped at the sudden feeling of their joint warmth. Mydei's breaths were trembling as he continued to ease his way down, his expression contracting into a wince, as he struggled to accommodate Phainon against the rough friction of the water.

"Need some help?" Phainon whispered, his head tilted up towards him. He splayed his fingers across Mydei's back, guiding him downward.

"I'm fine," Mydei breathed out, sounding anything but. He swallowed and glanced at Phainon. "It just feels a little more full than usual."

Phainon raised a brow. "What a roundabout way of complimenting my size."

"Shut up."

Phainon's laugh was like a whisper. Still, he didn't let Mydei go, and he continued to bring him down as gently as he could. It was taking all his self-control not to just slam his hips upward right then and there, and he mentally congratulated himself for holding back on his carnal desires.

After what felt like hours, Phainon finally had the whole of himself inside of Mydei. Mydei remained tense as he adjusted to the size and feel of him, and it took him another while before finally relaxing in Phainon's arms. His head remained bowed and his eyes started to close as he stayed still, finally giving himself the grace to catch his breath.

Phainon was still staring at him. His eyes hadn't left his face since the moment his cock penetrated him. Then, when Mydei's eyes remained shut, Phainon tilted his head up and brought his forehead against Mydei's.

He knew Mydei's eyes flew open with the sudden contact, but it was Phainon's turn to have his own closed.

"Take your time," he said. He let their noses brush against one another. "Ride me or sit still, it doesn't matter. Use me however you want to."

Mydei only sighed in reply, and Phainon felt his breath fan against his mouth as he did so.

Then, without another word, Mydei began to move.

The pace he set was slow, slower than if Phainon were the one to take the lead. It started with a roll of his hips, a rocking of forward and back, a grinding of upward and down. Then Mydei would cycle through the motions, repeating it just a little faster and a little rougher each time.

Phainon only continued to hold Mydei through it all, his fingers tracing soothing lines against his back. At one point, he pulled away from Mydei to watch him move, pleased when he found Mydei's face flushed with pleasure. Neither of them made any sound save for the occasional grunt and a barely contained sigh, and Phainon had it in his mind to outlast Mydei in his silence this time.

He promised himself he'd win. He promised himself he'd let Mydei move on his own as he generated enough warmth between the two of them.

What he didn't promise, however, was to remain quiet even after Mydei broke.

And when one particular press against Mydei's lower back made Mydei moan, the sound far louder and lewder in the silence of the night, Phainon finally smiled. He himself moaned right after, relieved that he could finally express the pleasure he felt.

"I win," he said.

Mydei glanced at him. There was a thick cloud of lust obscuring his vision, but he managed to see through it to frown. "What?"

This time, Phainon began to move. He made sure to time his shallow thrusts to Mydei's bouncing against his lap, and Mydei threw his head back with a gasp as Phainon's cock speared him even deeper.

"Could it be," Phainon asked, their pace increasing steadily, "that you're quite sensitive here?" He pressed a finger down against the same spot over Mydei's lower back.

Like clockwork, Mydei flinched, his moan unabashed. Then he placed a hand over his mouth, horrified, before punching Phainon's shoulder. "I told you we have to be quiet."

"You're the only one making a noise," Phainon retorted. As if his own voice wasn't rough and low from their sex.

"*Ha.*" Mydei leaned down and wrapped his arms around Phainon. "Keep touching me there. I'm close anyway."

Phainon clenched his jaw. He stroked over the spot on his lower back. "Don't tempt me."

"I'm not tempting you." Mydei was so, so breathless, and it was made all the more obvious as he leaned forward and rested his chin against Phainon's shoulder. "I'm giving you permission."

Ah. Well.

If permission is what he was granting, then who was Phainon to defy him?

Phainon adjusted his position, even as he and Mydei continued to move as one. Then he began pounding into him, his hips moving up roughly as the last of his self-control fell away. He buried his face in the crook of Mydei's shoulder. "I'm close too."

Mydei's thighs rose and fell against Phainon's in strong but erratic bursts, his own rhythm faltering as he neared his climax. Around them, the waves sloshed against the walls of the pool with an audible sound. "Don't stop."

Phainon hummed. “You too,” was the only thing he could dumbly, idiotically reply.

They moved together once, twice. Then, on the third time, and with one last slam of Mydei’s hips down into Phainon’s, both of them came simultaneously.

Phainon emptied his seed inside of Mydei, his arms like claws against Mydei’s back as he shuddered into him. Mydei, meanwhile, had his own dick pressed between both their bodies, and Phainon felt the moment it twitched to release its cum. Then, and only then, did Phainon moan again, his body rubbing against Mydei’s pulsating cock as it finished through its orgasm.

After they came down from their high, both of them panted like they’d just sprinted through the night. Mydei continued to embrace Phainon tightly, like he was his lifeline and he would drift away otherwise. Phainon extended the same energy to him, his arms strong and sure around the bare muscles of Mydei’s back.

This feels nice, Phainon thought, his face still resting against Mydei’s shoulder. Between the stillness of the night and the slowing waves of the pool, even his own thoughts were loud. *If only I could be inside of him everyday.*

If only—

But Phainon caught his words immediately. Whatever he had been about to wish, whatever he had been about to think, Phainon knew it was only something stupid and reckless. He wouldn’t dare entertain that thought further, regardless if he knew where it was headed or not.

Phainon sighed. Then he inhaled the scent of Mydei’s skin, forcing himself to be grounded back to reality.

“God.” He buried his face deeper in the space between Mydei’s neck and shoulder. “You feel amazing.”

If only—

Mydei's chin continued to rest against Phainon's shoulder, a similar position to the one Phainon held. "Thanks?"

"Take the compliment." Phainon bit down against Mydei. "After all, you're the best fuck buddy I've ever had."

As soon as the words left his mouth, he knew it was the wrong thing to say. Even before Mydei stiffened in his arms, he knew he should have held his tongue and refrained from making such a remark.

Oh. Phainon started to pull away, holding Mydei at arm's length and hoping he could see his face.

If only—

But Mydei was faster. In one swift motion, he lifted himself up and let Phainon slide out of him.

"Thanks," he said again, more brisk and curt this time. His face was carefully averted from Phainon's gaze as he stood against the pool floor. Then he pushed up against the ledge and let the water drip in a waterfall over him as he exited the pool.

Phainon turned his head, watching as Mydei grabbed his towel and began drying himself off.

Apologize.

Phainon swallowed. He knew he should. He had felt the mood shift considerably the moment he'd let his words fly.

But Phainon knew he had no reason to apologize either. It was, after all, the truth. It was a mere reminder of the boundaries they'd set with one another, a fact that this is what they were to each other.

If he looked at it in that light, what was there to be sorry for?

And yet.

The water shifted around him as he turned to face his companion completely. “Mydei–”

“Don’t stay for too long.” Mydei threw his towel over his head as he gathered his dry clothes in his arms. He paused as he stared at the container with the slice of cake, and Phainon had a momentary fear that he was going to leave it there.

But Mydei sighed and picked that up too. Then he glanced over his shoulder, though most of his face remained shrouded in shadow. “You’re going to catch a cold if you do.”

Phainon watched, helpless, as Mydei began to walk away. He followed his retreating figure all the way until he was back inside the hotel, until he had turned into the hallway leading to the elevators, until he was out of his sight completely.

Phainon rested his back against the wall of the pool and blew out a breath.

Facts be damned, he decided, pulling his shorts back over himself before rising out of the pool. He had to find a way to set this straight and to set this right.

We have to be okay, Phainon thought as he began to dry himself. *Especially with tomorrow’s show coming up, we have to be okay.*

But somehow, Phainon didn’t think it was just all for the show anymore.

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Unfortunately, Phainon didn’t have the time nor the opportunity to get Mydei alone after that.

Seeing as they were all pressed for time, the whole ensemble rose early to begin loading their belongings on the bus. By the time everything was set in

place, it was approaching eight in the morning, and Cyrene wasted no time bringing everyone onboard to get them on the road.

Phainon couldn't even sit beside Mydei on the bus. Aglaea had already taken her place beside Mydei, and both manager and talent seemed engrossed in their own conversation that Phainon didn't have the heart to interrupt them. He opted to take his usual seat by Castorice instead who, thankfully, didn't press too much on the matter.

"Did something happen?" she asked him as Phainon settled in the seat beside her.

"I'll work it out," Phainon merely said. He placed his wireless earbuds in, cursing himself when he realized that his wired ones were still with Mydei. "It's fine."

Castorice looked like she doubted him, but she let the matter slide. Instead, she drowned herself in her own music, her earphones sliding into place as she slid a sleeping eye mask over her face.

Time seemed to slip through Phainon's fingers after that. It felt like he was merely teleporting from one place to another: from his seat on the tour bus to his seat in the next stadium's dressing room to his spot on the stage as they began their rehearsals. All the while he kept one eye on Mydei, longing to go to him and smooth things over and make him feel at ease around him again.

But Mydei, while professional in his conduct, was undoubtedly refusing to meet his gaze.

Phainon felt like he was going to tear his hair out from the stress of it all.

"Can we do one more run of the song?" he asked his bandmates and Mydei now. They had hours to go before their official show began, but they had mere minutes left to rehearse before they had to run off to their stylists. Even so, it was already their third time practicing the song they were set to cover, and they still couldn't get it right.

Phainon adjusted his mic before strumming over his guitar. “I keep missing my cue on the last part.”

“You do,” Anaxa said accusingly. His green hair was already dripping with sweat, and he had to wipe away the ones that rolled over his eyepatch. “What’s gotten into you?”

“Give me a minute,” Phainon said. He hummed the last few lyrics to the mic, quickly fast forwarding the chorus until he got to the guitar solo designated to him. Then he played the chords over his guitar, still humming, before stepping back. “Okay, I got it.”

“Hey.”

Phainon turned, surprised. It was the first time Mydei acknowledged him since the day began, and he looked at Phainon now with a frown on his face.

“If you can’t get the timing right,” he said, stepping away from his own mic, “leave it to me.”

“I got it,” Phainon insisted. “I just really need to run through it one more time.”

Mydei sighed. He cradled his own guitar, his fingers flitting over the strings. “Stay focused.” He looked at him dead in the eye. “Can’t afford to have any distractions now, can we?”

Phainon straightened. “I know.” He looked back at Mydei with the same fire. “But I’m not one to make the same mistake twice.”

Mydei continued to stare at him. Still, Phainon thought that maybe, just maybe, his eyes softened. Just a little bit.

Unless, of course, he was seeing things now.

Castorice cleared her throat. “Anyways.” She brought her drumsticks together. “Starting again in three, two….”

At one, she brought her drumsticks down over her drums. Phainon and Mydei composed themselves immediately, both of them switching their focus to their song, as they entered the rhythm with their respective guitar strums.

Mydei was assigned with the first guitar solo of the song, and he was also assigned to sing the first lyrics as opposed to Phainon. He stepped up to his mic now, his eyes staring out into an empty stadium as he began to sing the first verse.

"*Got caught running up a tab. Couldn't drive home, so I had to share a cab.*"

He glanced at Phainon for his cue, but Phainon was already looking at him.

"*Introduced himself by his last name,*" he sang, deciding on a whim to change the pronouns of the song. Mydei's eyes widened, even as Phainon carried on, "*The kind of boy you steal from the football team.*"

"*Brought up a silver spoon mess,*" Mydei returned. "*Always trying to tear off my Catholic dress.*"

It was Phainon's turn to be surprised, shocked that he changed the lyrics to pertain to himself.

"*Told me he's over this place,*" Phainon continued. He couldn't help the small smile that had begun to break over his face. "*Needs to feel the midwest wind on his face.*"

Mydei looked away. "*But the alcohol made its way down.*"

He closed his eyes, his hand still strumming over his guitar.

"*He was the last thing that I saw last night before I hit the ground.*"

Phainon rocked his body forward to strum over his guitar. This time, his smile was like the sun as he sang his part out.

"*Oh god, I did the wrong thing,*" he looked at Mydei, "*to the right boy.*"

He grabbed his mic, letting his guitar go as he used his other hand to point to his temple. “*My mind was only in it for a minute.*”

Phainon pulled the mic free before spinning on his heel towards Mydei’s direction. “*Had a bad fling with a good boy. I was stupid and dumb, not giving up.*”

Mydei rolled his eyes. Still, he continued playing on his guitar as he sang his next part.

“*The blank stare out the window. If I could just sober up, I could just admit __*”

In unison, they sang, “*I did the wrong thing to the right boy.*”

Mydei took a step back to let Phainon have his solo part. Phainon used that moment to hold a hand out to Mydei, his fingers curling until it was pointing towards him. “*It was your world, baby, and I just lived in it!*”

Mydei slammed his hand down over his guitar, beginning another riff anew. This time, Phainon took back his own instrument in his hand, playing alongside Mydei as they waited for him to repeat the last lyric of the chorus.

“*It was your world, baby,*” Mydei sang, “*and I just lived in it!*”

Both of them continued to play the instrumental segment leading to the next verse. As they did, Mydei walked over to Phainon, leaning in until he was yelling over the music to be heard.

“What’s gotten into you this time?” he asked.

Phainon grinned, leaning away from his mic. He placed a hand over his mouth and said into Mydei’s ear, “Just happy you’re finally acknowledging me again!”

Mydei rolled his eyes again. He shuffled back to his mic stand as he and the Flame-Chasers entered the next segment of their cover.

They carried out the rest of the song in a similar manner, neither of them missing a cue or faltering on a beat this time. Their earlier rehearsals had been stiff and tense, lacking the fire and emotion that Phainon poured out now. Mydei had been right to question Phainon's sudden change in mood, but Phainon had been honest in his reply.

Though he had yet to apologize verbatim, he knew Mydei understood enough of his apology in this song.

And Phainon knew, based on the way Mydei played, that he had accepted it enough as well.

By the time the song's bridge began to close and transition back into the last chorus, Phainon and Mydei were just as relaxed and free as they would have been if this was a real performance. Phainon never could quite replicate the way his soul burned, but in this rehearsal, he came very close to the real thing.

So, during the last chorus, he decided to continue giving it his all.

"*Oh god, I did the wrong thing to the right boy,*" Phainon sang for the final time. "*My mind was only in it for a minute.*"

"*Had a bad fling with a good boy,*" Mydei complemented. "*I was stupid and dumb, not giving up!*"

"*The blank stare out the window.*" Phainon pumped an arm up into the air. "*If I could just sober up, I could just admit: I did the wrong thing to the right boy.*"

Both Phainon and Mydei looked at one another. Then, as one, they leaned forward, bringing themselves together until their foreheads were touching.

"*It was your world, baby,*" they sang simultaneously, "*and I just lived in it!*"

Phainon pulled back, entering with his guitar solo. He beamed, proud with the way he slid right into his cue this time. He was ecstatic as he looked at Mydei, and Mydei nodded back to him in approval.

“*Oh, it was your world, baby, and I just lived in it!*” Mydei stepped right into Phainon’s personal space.

“*Oh, it was your world.*”

Mydei pressed a hand over Phainon’s chest.

“*All yours.*”

Phainon’s blush was immediate. Still, he carried on with his part, his hands working to remain over his guitar, as he sang, “*Please, please, baby, come back.*”

Mydei stepped back, letting his fingers fall away from Phainon’s chest in slow motion. “*Yeah, it was your world, baby, and I just lived in it.*”

Phainon had an impulsive thought to reach out and thread his fingers over his. But he dispelled that urge as he continued to sing, “*Please, please, baby, come back.*”

Mydei took a step back, his eyes still on Phainon.

“*Please, please, baby, come back.*”

Phainon couldn’t help himself. With one last strum, he let his guitar go and reached an arm out.

“*Please, please, baby, come back.*”

They all let the last note linger in the air, and Phainon continued to let his outstretched arm hover in the space between him and Mydei. It almost felt like time had stopped, suspending all of them into a picture of yearning, a still frame of what it meant to embody the song into reality.

Then Phainon took a deep, deep breath, and he let his arm fall back to his side, and the moment shattered.

“Alright,” Anaxa said, speaking up first. He set his bass guitar down in its stand before resting his hands on his knees. “Are we all done now?”

Phainon turned to him.

“Yeah, we’re done,” Mydei answered first. He slung his guitar over his head and placed it in its own stand. He took the hem of his shirt and lifted it up, exposing the muscles of his abs as he wiped the sweat from his cheeks. “We have to get changed anyway.”

Phainon took another deep breath. Then he set his own guitar down and gave a slow clap. “Good job, everyone!” he cheered. “That was a perfect run!”

The four of them began to exit the stage, every one of them already resigned to return backstage. Phainon was the last to linger, falling five steps behind everyone else. When he looked up, he was pleasantly surprised to find Mydei falling back, looking at him as he waited for Phainon to catch up.

“Yes?” Phainon said, batting his lashes at him. “Were you waiting for me?”

Mydei scowled. Once Phainon reached him, they began to walk side by side. “Already getting on my nerves.”

Phainon laughed. Then, after another moment’s hesitation, he grabbed Mydei’s arm and hugged it tight. “I’m sorry,” he murmured against his bicep.

“Get off of me,” Mydei said, shrugging him off. “You’re not slick.”

“What are you implying?” Phainon said, holding onto him tighter and pressing his cheek against Mydei’s muscles. “I’m just a man begging for forgiveness!”

“And what,” Mydei began, “are you apologizing for?”

Phainon stopped. He glanced up at Mydei.

For saying you’re just someone I sleep with, he thought, *and that you’re nothing more than that. Even if it’s the truth.*

Because it *is* the truth.

Right?

“For being an idiot,” he said at last. When he smiled again, it was a little tight at the edges. “For hurting your feelings.”

Mydei sighed. He reached over with his other arm and flicked the top of Phainon’s head. “You didn’t hurt my feelings.”

“Liar,” Phainon accused.

“Maybe,” Mydei agreed. When he pushed Phainon off of him this time, it was gentle but absolute. Phainon allowed himself to be directed away. “Let’s just put it behind us so we can perform without any hitches.”

Phainon straightened. As he did, the back of his hand brushed against Mydei’s.

“Whatever you say,” he said, as they continued walking backstage towards their dressing room. He glanced at Mydei. “Like I said, though, I don’t make the same mistakes twice.”

Mydei merely shrugged. “We’ll see.”

Phainon smiled. *We’ll see indeed,* he thought to himself. After all, only time will tell whether he could prove his words true this time.

Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for all your lovely comments so far!!

1. i’m v glad a lot of you like the performances because the most challenging part of this fic is writing them. i really want the performances to be as immersive as possible (which is also why i chose familiar rock songs that hopefully resonate with a lot of readers). so seeing how much you guys like the concert/rehearsal scenes makes me very happy!!

2. thank you for reading this, like genuinely. to be honest, i wanted to discontinue this fic, not because i don't like it (i like writing this A LOT) but because i did NOT expect the attention *parasocial* got. i felt so much pressure to write something as good as that, and for a while that's all i thought about.

in the end, though, i ended up enjoying the drafted scenes so much that i carried on. now i'm at a point where idgaf if it's compared to my previous works. all that matters is that i'm enjoying writing this!! and i hope you’re enjoying reading this as well. :D

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!